

CM distributes bicycles to 1,100 schoolgirls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday distributed bicycles to 1,100 schoolgirls in Shalimar Bagh. The Chief Minister also announced that around 1.3 lakh girls studying in Class 9 in Government schools will receive free bicycles every year to improve access to education.

The event was held at Sarvodaya Vidyalaya in Pitampura on the occasion of Durga Ashtami. The initiative aims to address commuting challenges faced by schoolgirls, which officials say often affect attendance and, in some cases, lead to dropouts. Addressing the gathering, the Chief Minister said the scheme is part of a broader effort to support girls' education and make them self-reliant.

"Daughters are like goddesses. Supporting their education is our responsibility," she said, adding that Navratri is a time not only for worshipping the goddess but also for reaffirming respect for girls.

The Chief Minister said feedback from students had highlighted transport as a



Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta poses with young girls during 'Kanya Puja' on the occasion of 'Durga Ashtami' at Sarvodaya Vidyalaya in Shalimar Bagh, New Delhi

major barrier to continuing education. The Government has now decided to provide bicycles to all girls entering Class 9 each year, benefiting about 1.3 lakh students across Delhi. She clarified that the bicycles distributed on Thursday were given to Class 10 students as part of her personal initiative, while the larger scheme will cover Class 9 students annually.

Interacting directly with students, the Chief Minister encouraged them to learn cycling if they did not already know how. "Now you will

complete your education on your own strength," she said.

The event saw emotional scenes as several students received bicycles and spoke about their struggles. Some said they often faced difficulty reaching school due to a lack of reliable transport. Others said the bicycles would help them attend classes regularly and save time.

Alongside the bicycle scheme, the Chief Minister highlighted other initiatives for girls announced in the recent Delhi Budget. She spoke about the Lakhpati

Bitiya Yojana, under which financial assistance will be provided to girls at different stages of their education.

According to the Chief Minister, funds will be deposited directly into a beneficiary's account at key milestones, including birth and during classes 1, 6, 9, and 12, as well as annually during college. By the time a girl graduates, she is expected to receive around ₹1.25 lakh under the scheme.

Taking a strong stand against criticism, the Chief Minister said it was "shame-

ful" to question initiatives meant for girls.

"Calling such schemes into question reflects a regrettable mindset," she said, adding that there should be no politics over welfare measures for daughters.

She also announced steps to improve women's economic independence. The government will issue 1,000 new auto permits to women under a 'Pink Auto' scheme. These autos will be driven by women, providing them with employment opportunities.

In another announcement, the Chief Minister said the government will offer free blood tests for all newborns in Delhi to detect 56 genetic disorders. The cost will be fully covered by the government to ensure early diagnosis and treatment.

The Chief Minister also spoke about safety and confidence, urging students to aim high and pursue their goals without fear. She assured them that the government is committed to their progress and well-being. The event ended with students sharing their aspirations. Some spoke about dreams of becoming civil servants, while others said they wanted to support their families through education.

Verma urges residents not to immerse offerings in Yamuna

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma on Thursday urged residents not to immerse *khetri* (Navratri offerings) in the Yamuna River during Navratri. The Minister called on citizens to adopt environmentally responsible practices and use designated processing units instead.

Speaking after offering prayers at Jhandewalan Temple with his family, Singh appealed to people to combine faith with civic responsibility. He emphasised that while *khetri*, grown during Navratri, symbolises devotion and tradition, its disposal should not harm the environment. "By the grace of Maa, we all grow *khetri*. It carries our faith, hard work, and emotions. But I would like to make a small request: please do not immerse the *khetri* in the Yamuna River," Verma said.

Highlighting the environmental concerns, the minister described the Yamuna as the lifeline of Delhi and stressed that keeping it clean is a shared duty. He encouraged residents to bring their



khetri to designated processing units, where it can be converted into compost.

"If you bring your *khetri* to the processing unit at the nursery in front of the Secretariat, it will be converted into compost and will help make Delhi greener. It may seem like a small step, but its impact will be significant," he said.

The initiative is part of broader efforts to reduce pollution in the Yamuna, which has long struggled with contamination from waste and religious offerings. Officials believe that redirecting ritual waste to composting facilities can help reduce the ecological burden on the river.

Verma framed the appeal as an opportunity to start a

new tradition. "Let us begin a new tradition where faith goes hand in hand with protecting nature. This is true devotion, this is true service," he added. To facilitate the initiative, authorities have identified multiple locations across Delhi where residents can deposit their *khetri*. These include ITI Vivek Vihar Green Area, Golden Jubilee Park along the Yamuna Pustea, Sanjay Lake, Smritivan Kondli, Siri Fort Phase-I Green Area, and Vijay Mandal to Begumpur Green Belt.

Other designated sites include Maa Anand Mai Ashram in Harkesh Nagar, Kalkaji Dhoobi Ghat Green Area, Aastha Kunj in Kalkaji, Picnic Hut Park in Tughlakabad, and Millennium Park near Sarai Kale Khan.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Transfer of ownership in respect of constructed Booth No. 42, Sector 14, Urban Estate Gurugram consequent upon the death of Co-allocotee Smt. Sarno Devi. Smt. Sarno Devi who was the Co-allocotee of the subject cited property as per record dated on 02/07/2017 and has registered will favouring Anita Kumari (daughter) D/o Sh. Biru Ram Sroy, R/o H. No. 895/17B, Gurugram and Anita Kumari intend to apply for the transfer of the said property in her favour being the beneficiary as per will (legal heir) and request for re-allocation in the name of Anita Kumari along with the existing Co-allocotee Biru Ram Sroy if any person is having any objection against the transfer of said booth please submit objections in writing to the Estate Officer, HSPV, Gurugram along with supporting documents within 30 days from the date of publication of this notice, otherwise the Estate Officer may accord permission to transfer/re-allocation of the said property as per HSPV policy and may not entertain subsequent claim, if any.

CHANGE OF NAME/D.O.B

I, (Army No. 10525605M) Rank-Sep, ASHISH son of SH. HAWA SINGH R/O VILLAGE + POST- RABHRA, TEHSIL GOHANA, DIST. SONPAT HARYANA presently at New Delhi, do hereby solemnly affirm and declare that the name of my mother is wrongly mention as Santi Devi instead of shanti and date of birth 01.07.1957 instead of 11.09.1956 and also my father's date of birth is wrongly mentioned as 01.07.1955 instead of 05.07.1954 in my Army service record.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the general public on behalf of our client (i.e. HOPC Bank Ltd.) that Mrs. Raghava Infra-Estate Private Limited is claiming to be the owner of Freehold Industrial Property Bearing No.B-122 land area measuring 617 Sq. Yds, situated at Rewari Line Industrial Area, in Block -B Phase-I, known as Mayapuri, New Delhi-110064, vide Sale Deed Dated 26.04.2019 executed by Mr. Gagan Prasad Madhani & Mr. Sharan Madhani, duly registered with SRO-VII A Sarojini Nagar New Delhi as Doc No. 2106. It has been informed by the owner that some original documents i.e. Allotment, Possession, Lease Deed dt.05.06.1979, GFA, RTS & Will dt. 29.03.2000 & last 3 pages (including reg. particulars page) of above Sale Deed dt.26.04.2019 in respect of said property are lost & not traceable. All persons are hereby informed that above mentioned Owner wants to mortgage the said property & intends to obtain a loan from our client (i.e. HOPC Bank Ltd.) against the said property, if anybody has any objections upon the ownership of above owner over the said property, its mortgage/litigation, and any other objections, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present.

ESTATE OFFICER HSPV - I Gurugram

On behalf of Anita Kumari and Biru Ram Sroy

AXIS BANK LTD.

PUBLIC NOTICE FOR - AUCTION OF PLEDGED ASSETS BEING GOLD ORNAMENTS

The Borrowers, in specific and the public in general are here by notified that public auction of the gold ornaments pledge in the below accounts is proposed to be conducted by the Axis Bank at the below mentioned Branch.

The below mentioned Borrowers has availed the credit facility from the **Axis Bank Limited** against the pledge of gold ornaments ("Gold Loan Facility") in favour of the Bank towards the security. The Demand notices were issued to the Borrowers/Guarantors calling up the Borrowers/Guarantors to pay their outstanding amount towards the Gold loan facility availed. As the Borrowers/Guarantors have failed to repay the outstanding loan amount, the bank is constrained to invoke the pledge and proposed to conduct an auction sale of pledged gold ornaments more particularly described in schedule of property hereunder on **27-04-2026 at 11:00 AM on "As Is Where Is", "As Is What Is", "Whatever There Is" and "No Recourse Basis"**. Auction will be held at

Customer Name	Loan A/c No.	Amount Outstanding (₹)	Date of Recall Notice	Gross Weight	Net Weight
B.O.-: GREATER NOIDA [UP]					
DEV DUTT SHARMA	XXXXXXXXXXXX6625	₹ 8,24,720.36	16-11-2025	173.700	160.800
GYANVEER SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX9028	₹ 7,25,382.00	19-12-2025	135.400	119.300
GAURAV BANSAL	XXXXXXXXXXXX5094	₹ 4,52,290.66	09-02-2026	68.200	64.950
TRIKALAGYA .	XXXXXXXXXXXX1931	₹ 3,12,307.00	16-02-2026	67.600	57.800
DEEPAK	XXXXXXXXXXXX1145	₹ 1,66,124.00	27-10-2025	29.800	27.600
MANIKA KANSAL	XXXXXXXXXXXX5328	₹ 1,36,038.29	16-06-2025	26.200	24.900
AASHISH BHATI	XXXXXXXXXXXX1244	₹ 48,241.00	10-01-2026	10.000	9.500
B.O.-: KALKAJI, NEW DELHI [DL]					
DEEPAK .	XXXXXXXXXXXX5822	₹ 27,10,697.43	09-02-2026	366.500	353.600
DEEPAK .	XXXXXXXXXXXX7524	₹ 10,52,908.00	09-02-2026	199.700	197.400
MOHIT MAHENDRU	XXXXXXXXXXXX0536	₹ 1,68,506.25	10-01-2026	40.700	38.700
MD NAZ	XXXXXXXXXXXX3573	₹ 2,35,774.57	25-03-2021	22.900	21.900
ABASIS ALAM	XXXXXXXXXXXX7253	₹ 1,77,556.00	12-12-2025	14.700	13.900
B.O.-: MALVIYA NAGAR, NEW DELHI [DL]					
SNEH BHARTI	XXXXXXXXXXXX4240	₹ 37,86,607.00	09-02-2026	681.000	642.600
REKHA SAKSAINA	XXXXXXXXXXXX1059	₹ 5,17,610.34	10-12-2025	88.200	84.400
SHUBHANKAR DUTTA	XXXXXXXXXXXX4251	₹ 2,61,022.00	27-10-2025	59.400	57.500
RAVI RANJAN	XXXXXXXXXXXX9647	₹ 1,23,051.04	09-02-2026	21.400	20.500
B.O.-: NOIDA [UP]					
VISHNU SHARMA	XXXXXXXXXXXX9548	₹ 36,34,923.24	09-02-2026	497.720	471.820
SUMAN .	XXXXXXXXXXXX3895	₹ 3,94,081.00	16-02-2026	82.180	60.880
B.O.-: PALAM VIHAR, GURGAON [HR]					
SEEMA YADAV	XXXXXXXXXXXX1548	₹ 17,90,426.00	12-02-2026	240.400	226.200
SHAMSHER KHAN	XXXXXXXXXXXX0747	₹ 12,12,897.48	27-10-2025	217.200	209.700
SEEMA YADAV	XXXXXXXXXXXX5291	₹ 12,62,253.00	23-02-2026	214.300	200.000
SEEMA YADAV	XXXXXXXXXXXX4501	₹ 3,80,998.00	23-02-2026	214.300	200.000
VIBHA SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX9923	₹ 88,959.00	12-02-2026	17.200	16.700
RUBEL RANA	XXXXXXXXXXXX8849	₹ 53,195.39	30-09-2023	8.000	8.000
NARAYAN KUMAR MISHRA	XXXXXXXXXXXX7029	₹ 33,168.00	16-06-2025	6.800	6.000
B.O.-: PARADISE MALL S GUR HR					
ANNURADHA .	XXXXXXXXXXXX3810	₹ 5,45,766.89	10-12-2025	92.800	89.800
KAMINI SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX5237	₹ 3,63,033.00	27-10-2025	65.000	62.700
KAMINI SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX7301	₹ 3,22,849.00	27-10-2025	55.600	52.700
KAMINI SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX6345	₹ 2,93,614.00	27-10-2025	51.200	49.400
ABHINANDAN CHAUDHARY	XXXXXXXXXXXX2221	₹ 2,74,465.10	10-01-2026	51.000	47.000
RIDDHIMA GUPTA	XXXXXXXXXXXX9230	₹ 1,04,425.00	16-11-2025	19.700	19.200
POOJA CHAUHAN	XXXXXXXXXXXX9800	₹ 69,933.07	10-01-2026	10.400	10.000
LAKSHMAN YADAV	XXXXXXXXXXXX0562	₹ 61,724.00	31-07-2025	13.700	12.900
VICKY KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX9047	₹ 44,374.00	16-11-2025	7.800	7.200
B.O.-: SECTOR 16, FARIDABAD [HR]					
TINKU .	XXXXXXXXXXXX4467	₹ 14,68,826.00	19-12-2025	190.000	184.200
ROMA BHATI	XXXXXXXXXXXX4621	₹ 10,36,722.00	16-02-2026	200.300	156.240
SUNITA	XXXXXXXXXXXX3713	₹ 3,27,418.00	10-01-2026	57.300	55.000
SEEMA .	XXXXXXXXXXXX8345	₹ 3,19,186.00	10-12-2025	56.100	54.410
KRITI SAGAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX9108	₹ 2,25,639.00	05-06-2025	47.500	45.640
AJAJUL HAQUE	XXXXXXXXXXXX1124	₹ 50,700.00	16-11-2025	8.800	8.540
VISHAL MEENA	XXXXXXXXXXXX3050	₹ 1,87,784.00	12-12-2025	25.200	24.000

TERMS & CONDITIONS OF TENDER

The Base/Reserve price will be given on the auction day/date to the tenderers on which the auction bid will be considered. The bid/offers in the prescribed tender form provided by the bank shall only be considered for bidding.

Incomplete bid form/tender are treated invalid and shall liable to be rejected.

The tender documents along with the terms and conditions shall be collected from the above branch. The tender document duly completed to be handed to the concerned branch official during working hours on **27-04-2026**. Tenders received after the due date will not be considered.

The said properties is / are offered for sale on "**As Is Where Is", "As Is What Is", "Whatever There Is" And "No Recourse"** Basis. The Bank does not undertake any responsibility to standard, purity and /or any other dues, taxes, if any, in respect of the said property.

Tenders will be opened by the Bank on the auction date in the presence of the tenderers who may choose to remain present on the day and time as said above, inter alia, for raising / revising their respective offers.

Branch Names Mentioned Above. Auction Date : 27-04-2026.

Offer/tender once submitted cannot be withdrawn and bidder will liable to deposit the bid amount if there is single bid/offer for particular article/asset/ornament.

If there are more than one bid for particular article/asset/ornament, inter-se bidding shall take place amongst the bidder and highest bidder shall be declare as successful bidder.

Bidder should submit all KYC documents i.e. PAN Number, PAN Card, Adhar Card & Address proof etc. Bidder should submit valid E-mail ID & Contact Number

The Bank reserves its right to accept or reject the offer at its sole discretion.

Any disputes / differences arising out of sale of the said property/ offered for sale shall be subject to the exclusive jurisdiction of Courts / Tribunals at Mumbai only.

PLACE: DELHI & NCR, DATE: 27.03.2026

SD/-, AUTHORIZED OFFICER, AXIS BANK LTD.

The Pioneer

Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Vikram Singh, Father of- No.16026676H Nk Yogendra Singh Panwar, R/o- H.No. 801, Ward No. 15, Vill & Post- Kuchrod, Dist- Mandasaur, M.P.- 458895, declare that in my Son's service record my name is wrongly recorded Vikram Singh Panwar, whereas my correct name is Vikram Singh, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(663)C I, Gendkunwar, Mother of- No.16026676H Nk Yogendra Singh Panwar, R/o- H.No. 801, Ward No. 15, Vill & Post- Kuchrod, Dist- Mandasaur, M.P.- 458895, declare that in my Son's service record my name is wrongly recorded as Genda Kunwar whereas my correct name is Gendkunwar, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(664)C I, Roshni Devi, Mother of JC-473702P Nbsub Deepak Kumar, R/o- Balab(112), Garhi Ballab, Rohtak, Haryana- 124411 have changed my name from Roshni Devi to Roshani Devi, vide affidavit dated 25/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(665)C I, No.15440041M Nk Raut Prabhu Ashok, R/o- Vill- Belora, Post- Janephal, Teh- Jafrabad, Dist- Jalna, Maharashtra- 431206, declare that in my service records, my brother's name is wrongly recorded as Samadhan whereas his correct name is Samadhan Ashok Raut which may be amended accordingly.

PD(666)C I, No.15435118A Hav Shinde Sachin Rajaram, R/o- Vill- Islak, PO- Nimblak, Teh- Nagar, Dist- Ahilyanagar, Maharashtra- 414111, declare that in my service documents, my Mother's Name is wrongly written as Mira, whereas her correct Name is Mirabai Rajaram Shinde, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(667)C I, Yogita, Wife of JC-813085F Nb Sub Shirsat Vijay Ashok, Residing at A-201, Mantra Essence Society, Jagdamba Bhavan Marg, Undri, Pune- 411060 (Maharashtra). Declared that, I have changed my name from Yogita to Yogita Shirsat, DOB 01/07/1985 vide affidavit No. IN-DL80200340644277Y dated 25/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi

PD(668)C I, GOPI KANAIN, S/O, SHRI NARAYAN CHAND, KANDRERI, R/O, (78) SHIMLA, HIMACHAL PRADESH - 172001, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO GOPI BALABH. (THAT GOPI KANAIN AND GOPI BALABH IS ONE AND THE SAME PERSON)

PD(669)C I Manish S/o Satish Chand R/o RZ-13 Dabri Vaishali Delhi-110045 have changed my name to Manish Mittal.

PD(671)C I Archana W/o Manish Mittal R/o RZ-13 Dabri Vaishali Delhi-110045 have changed my name to Archana Mittal.

PD(672)C I, Mohd Riyaz, S/o. Kamaaluddin, R/o. C-13/1, Thokar No.8, Shaheen Bagh, Abul Fazal Enclave, Part-II, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, declare that my mother's name wrongly mentioned in my Educational Documents as Razia instead of Rozia Khatun.

PD(673)A I, Mohd Riyaz, S/o. Kamaaluddin, R/o. C-13/1, Thokar No.8, Shaheen Bagh, Abul Fazal Enclave, Part-II, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025, declare that in my service documents, my Mother's Name is wrongly written as Mira, whereas her correct Name is Mirabai Rajaram Shinde, which may be amended accordingly.

PD(674)A I, Kavita Bhardwaj, W/o No.14682998A Hav Mukesh, R/o- Vill- Mahamoodpur, PO- Shikarpur, Teh- Shikarpur, Dist- Bulandshahr, U.P. have changed my name from Kavita Bhardwaj to Kavita, vide affidavit dated 26/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(675)C I, No. 14682998A Hav Mukesh, R/o- Vill- Mahamoodpur, PO- Shikarpur, Teh- Shikarpur, Dist- Bulandshahr, Uttar Pradesh, have changed my Daughter's name from Anshika Bhardwaj to Anshika, vide affidavit dated 26/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(676)C I, Mahender Kanwar W/o- Mangal Singh Chouhan, R/o- Vill- Shri Sela, Dist- Pali, Rajasthan, have changed my name from Mahender Kanwar to Mahendra Kanwar, vide affidavit dated 26/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(677)C I, Yasmin spouse of Havildar Mesaniya Maksudin Usman, resident of 36, Zapa Seri, Kerala-1, Momin Was, Kerala, Morbi, Gujarat- 363621 have changed my name from Yasmin to Mesaniya Yasmin Maksudin vide affidavit dated 26/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(678)C I, Girish Chandra Yadav, Father of- No.17009077H Hav Amit Kumar Yadav, R/o- Vill- Koilyl Purwa, PO- Rasoolpur Sadat, Teh- Bakshi Ka Talab, PS- Chinhat, Dist- Lucknow, U.P.- 226028, have changed my name from Girish Chandra Yadav to Girish Kumar, vide affidavit dated 26/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(679)C I, Rajkumari Devi, Mother of- No.17009077H Hav Amit Kumar Yadav, R/o- Vill- Koilyl Purwa, PO- Rasoolpur Sadat, Teh- Bakshi Ka Talab, PS- Chinhat, Dist- Lucknow, U.P.- 226028, have changed my name from Rajkumari Devi to Raj Kumari, vide affidavit dated 26/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(680)C I, No.15680803F Hav(OCC) Kaliraj P, R/o- 5/347C, Maruthi Nagar, Teacher's Colony, Vill- Pudhupalayam, PO- Kumaraswamy Raja Nagar, Teh- Rajapalayam, Dist- Virudhunagar, Tamilnadu- 626108, have changed my Son's name from Vidhyadharan to Vidhyadharan K, vide affidavit dated 26/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(681)C I, Naina, W/o- No.8376665A WO Gajanan Ramdas Mohankar, R/o- VPO- Paturda BK, Teh- Sangrampur, Dist- Buldhana, Maharashtra- 444201, have changed my name from Naina to Nayana Gajanan Mohankar, vide affidavit dated 26/03/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

PD(682)C I, Gajanan Ramdas Mohankar S/o Ramdas Supdaji Mohankar, R/o Mu PO - Paturda Bu, TA - Sangrampur, Ward Nm 05, Paturda Bu, Buldana, Maharashtra- 444201, have changed the name of my minor daughter Siddhi aged 11 year and she shall hereafter be known as Vaishnavi Gajanan Mohankar.

PD(683)C

Public Notice

General Public is hereby informed that Mrs. Patori Devi has mortgaged her property i.e., Entire First Floor without roof rights "said floor" of Property bearing no. 18A, Area measuring 70 Sq. yds, out of Khata No. 104/24/1, Situated in the area of village Pasma, Delhi State Delhi, colony known as Raja Puri, Uttam Nagar New Delhi. The Hinduja Housing Finance Limited had Untraceable (1) Official Sale Deed dated 29.03.2026 as doc. No. 708 executed by M/S Sahi Associates Thru Partners Ajay Srivastava & Rajbir Kaar in favour of Sh. Pardeep Gupta and Smt. Kalpana Gupta in respect of said property. (2) Official Sale Deed dated 08.10.2024 doc. no. 2024/16/13298 executed by Mr. Pardeep Gupta and Mrs. Kalpana Gupta in favour of Mrs. Patori Devi in respect of said property. Application No- 190624/2026, registered at Police Palam Village, Southwest, Crime Branch, Delhi on dated 26.03.2026. Anyone who finds the above-mentioned documents, kindly handover the same to the Manager of Hindustan Housing Finance Limited, 167-169, 2nd Floor, Anna Salai, Saidapet, Chennai, 600032.

Public Notice

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 07-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline(s): +910120-3101683, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

Public Notice

This is to inform the general public that Shivam Chaudhary is the owner of Entire Ground Floor with Space for Parking Two Cars in the still area and Space for servant room with Common W.C. in the Still Area "the said floor", built up property bearing No. F-13, area measuring 300 Sq. Yds, situated at New Delhi South Extension Part-II, New Delhi through Sale Deed dated 18.10.2024, registered at P.S. Hazukh, South District, Crime Branch, Delhi on 25.03.2026. Anyone who finds the above-mentioned documents, is requested to handover the same to the Manager of Axis Finance Ltd., 85A-2nd Floor, Rishyamok Building, Panchsheel, Near RK Ashram Metro Station, New Delhi.

Public Notice

Shivam Chaudhary is in the process of mortgaging the said floor with Axis Finance Limited. Any objections or concerns regarding this transaction should be raised within a period of 7 days from the date of this public notice. Any objections submitted after the completion of this 7-days period will not be considered binding with respect to the said property or the interests of our client.

Public Notice

If anyone wishes to raise an objection, please do so within the stipulated 7-days period by contacting Law Veritas: North (Advocates & Legal Consultants) at Office No. 11, 1st Floor, Building No. A-44/A, Sector-16, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301; Landline(s): +910120-4499713, e-mail: accounts@lvnorth.in

BEFORE LD. SOLE ARBITRATOR SH. VAIBHAV NITI ADVOCATE, DELHI INTERNATIONAL ARBITRATION AND CONCILIATION, DELHI HIGH COURT, NEW DELHI

ARBITRATION CASE REFERENCE NO.DIAC/9541/1/IN

(CASE/REFERENCE ID NO.DL10/MSWC/01708)

IN THE MATTER OF:- SIMPLY LOGISTICS PVT. LTD.

VERSUS

FEET MITRA INFOTECH PRIVATE LIMITED & ANR.

.....RESPONDENTS

.....CLAIMANT

NOTICE

Whereas the next date of hearing has been fixed for 16.04.2026 at 4.30 p.m. evening for hearing of the case, notice is hereby given to the persons having any interest in the aforesaid case, can appear before the Ld. Sole Arbitrator Sh. Vaibhav Niti on 16.04.2026 at 4.30 p.m. evening Delhi International Arbitration and Conciliation, Delhi High Court, New Delhi.

Ld. Sole Arbitrator Sh. Vaibhav Niti ADVOCATE, DIAC, New Delhi

Police arrest woman, aide for running honey-trap racket

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

A pattern that had been hiding in plain sight has finally come into focus. The Delhi Police Crime Branch has arrested a 44-year-old woman and her associate for allegedly running a calculated racket of honey-trapping and filing false rape and molestation cases to extort money after at least nine FIRs were traced to her name across the city.

The accused, Shabnam Sajid, also known as Sidra Mansoor, and her associate, Yashdev Singh Chauhan, were arrested by the Inter-State Cell of the Crime Branch.

Police say Chauhan posed as an advocate to negotiate settlements, while the woman stayed removed from

direct money dealings. The case, now registered as FIR No. 282/2025 at Mehrauli police station under sections related to extortion and conspiracy, is being probed as part of a larger organised network.

The breakthrough came after a prolonged legal battle led by retired Army officer Captain Rakesh Walia: one of the alleged victims whose case was ultimately quashed by the Supreme Court in February 2025, with the court terming it an “abuse of process of law.”

Walia’s complaint forms the backbone of the present FIR and lays bare a methodical script. According to the FIR, the accused first approached Walia through social media under the pretext of promoting his books. She presented

herself as a well-connected media professional and influencer, offering to translate and promote his autobiography to widen its reach. Conversations moved across WhatsApp and other platforms. A fee structure was discussed.

Walia alleges that he paid an initial amount but resisted further payments. Meetings were arranged, including one near Chhatrapur Metro Station in December 2021. During a car ride, he noticed the woman carrying two phones and a recording device switched on throughout. She allegedly insisted they move to a hotel, which he refused.

Hours later, the narrative flipped. By evening, the woman reached the Noida Sector 37 police station and



attempted to file a rape complaint, alleging she had been assaulted after being offered intoxicants. When that did not hold, she moved across police stations before finally lodging an FIR at Mehrauli late that night.

The FIR details several inconsistencies: she refused medical examination, did not

submit evidence, and could not identify the place of occurrence.

Police records cited in the complaint note that she was seen walking normally at a police post shortly after the alleged incident. Call records also suggested she was continuously on phone calls during the time she claimed

to have been assaulted.

Despite this, a chargesheet was filed. Walia fought back: first in the High Court and then in the Supreme Court, which quashed the FIR.

“The law related to this is a joke. This is a clear case of misuse of law... still, the police and the system caught me in four years of problems,” Walia said.

The FIR and subsequent Crime Branch investigation reveal that this was not an isolated instance. Police say the accused had filed at least nine FIRs across Delhi: three involving rape allegations and six involving molestation and intimidation against different men. The FIR lists multiple cases across police stations, including Mehrauli, Dwarka, Kotwali, Hazrat Nizamuddin, and others.

Investigators found a striking similarity in the modus operandi. Victims were contacted, often through social media. Meetings were arranged in controlled settings. After initial engagement, disputes were triggered and criminal cases filed. Intermediaries would then approach victims for “settlement”.

A pen drive containing alleged audio recordings of such negotiations has been recovered. Voice samples of both accused have been sent for forensic examination. Police also found that Chauhan, who claimed to be a lawyer, was in fact a clerk at Karkardooma Courts.

A key figure in unravelling the case has been Deepika Narayan Bhardwaj, director of Ekam Nyaay Foundation,

who assisted Walia through his legal fight.

Bhardwaj said her intervention helped trace multiple FIRs linked to the same woman, information that is otherwise difficult for an accused person to access. “She has even messaged Walia’s son on Facebook saying, ‘Your father has raped me’,” Bhardwaj said, pointing to the psychological pressure tactics used.

She added that such cases are no longer isolated. “In recent years, many such instances have surfaced where women have filed multiple cases and used them to extort money. Some have turned it into a business,” she said. Advocate Bharat Chugh, who represented Walia, said the arrests are only the beginning.

CM Rekha attacks Kejriwal over Sheesh Mahal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday launched a sharp attack on former Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal over the controversial ‘Sheesh Mahal’. She called it a “symbol of corruption and moral decline” and asserted that the truth is now in the public domain.

The Chief Minister’s remarks came after a video related to the bungalow surfaced, triggering fresh political confrontation in the national capital. She said the visuals expose a clear gap between promises made to the public and actions taken in office.

“The truth can no longer be hidden. What people are seeing now is not just a building but proof of corruption, arrogance, and betrayal of public trust,” she said.

The Chief Minister alleged that leaders who rose to power in the name of the “Aam Aadmi” had built a luxurious residence using public funds. She said the



video allows citizens to judge for themselves how government resources were used.

Referring to the scale of the project, the Chief Minister claimed that the cost of construction rose sharply over time. “The project was initially pegged at around ₹8 crore, but it reportedly escalated to nearly ₹62 crore. This raises serious questions about financial irregularities,” she said.

She also pointed to features shown in the video, alleging that the residence included high-end interiors

and expensive installations. According to her, the property was equipped with around 50 air conditioners, multiple fans, imported appliances, coffee machines, and other luxury amenities.

The Chief Minister further alleged that several private consultants were engaged for different aspects of the project, which contributed to the rising cost. She said such decisions reflected a disregard for rules and financial discipline. Calling the episode a “dark chapter” in Delhi’s governance, the Chief

Minister said the timing of the expenditure was particularly concerning. “At a time when citizens were dealing with a pandemic and economic hardship, such spending reflects misplaced priorities,” she said.

She also referred to earlier claims of simplicity made by leaders, saying the lifestyle reflected in the video did not match those assurances. “Those who once said they would not take official cars or bungalows have built something far removed from the life of an ordinary citizen,” she said.

The Chief Minister appealed directly to the public to view the video and form their own opinion. “People have every right to know how their money was used. Let them see and judge for themselves,” she said. She said her government has already initiated steps to examine the matter.

She confirmed that a detailed probe is underway and will be conducted through the Public Accounts Committee (PAC).

Verma releases *Dhurandhar* 3 video, targets Kejriwal over Sheesh Mahal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh Verma has accused former Chief Minister Arvind Kejriwal of misusing public funds for lavish renovations and furnishings at the 6 Flagstaff Road bungalow, releasing a video titled “Dhurandhar 3: Delhi ke sabse bade Rehman Dacoit ki kahani” to support his allegations.

The video, shared as part of a political campaign, presents what Verma described as a factual account for the public. It includes a detailed walkthrough of the bungalow, showcasing interiors and installations, and raises questions over the scale of expenditure. Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta also commented on the release of the video. She said, “You have been waiting for Sheesh Mahal for a long time. Therefore, Sheesh Mahal is for all of you. Arvind Kejriwal



built this Sheesh Mahal with public money. He crossed all limits of corruption, and now his entire record of corruption is before the people of Delhi. The people of Delhi should see what the criminals of Delhi have done.”

Accompanied by the video release, Verma conducted an on-ground inspection of the property and documented various sections of the residence. “Delhi was promised politics of simplicity and honesty. People were told there would be no big bungalow, no lavish lifestyle. What is visible here today is completely different from

those promises,” he said.

According to the minister, the bungalow features high-end materials, luxury fittings, and advanced automation. He cited installations such as a modular kitchen (₹1.5 crore), chimney (₹5 lakh), chandeliers (up to ₹88 lakh), curtains (₹95 lakh), television units (up to ₹28 lakh), a jacuzzi (₹6 lakh), and a sauna room (₹10 lakh).

Verma further claimed that imported marble, designer fittings, and luxury furniture had been extensively used throughout the property. He said around 50 air conditioners were installed across

multiple sections, including bedrooms, living areas, dressing rooms, and bathrooms.

“Nearly 50 ACs in one bungalow, all maintained on public money. The people of Delhi deserve to know how their hard-earned money is being spent,” he said.

The minister also raised concerns over the timing of the expenditure. He alleged that key approvals and construction-related work took place during the COVID-19 pandemic, when the city was facing a major health crisis. “When Delhi was struggling during COVID, when people were dealing with health crises and basic needs, prioritising such work raises serious questions about governance,” he said.

Verma also referred to the overall scale of the property and claimed that additional expansion plans could have cost nearly ₹60 crore more, which he said has now been prevented, reducing further burden on public funds.



Loud noise at Jafrabad Metro sparks panic

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Panic briefly gripped commuters at Jafrabad Metro station in northeast Delhi on Thursday evening after a blast-like sound was heard on a Metro line towards Burari, officials said. No injuries or casualties were reported.

Police said they received information about the incident at around 6:05 pm. Teams from the Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) and local police immediately rushed to the spot and began evacuating passengers as a precaution.

A senior police officer said all passengers present at the station were safely evacuated. Authorities moved quickly to secure the area and assess the situation.

“Preliminary investigation revealed that the sound was caused by a kite string, or ‘manja’, getting entangled between two overhead power cables of the Metro line. This led to a minor spark and a small fire,” the officer said. According to officials, some children were flying kites in the vicinity when the string became lodged in the overhead wires. The contact between the manja and high-voltage cables triggered the spark, which produced the blast-like sound that alarmed commuters.

“The situation was quickly brought under control and normalcy was

restored after ensuring there was no further risk to passengers or infrastructure,” the officer added.

Security personnel and technical teams inspected the site thoroughly following the incident.

The CISF, which is responsible for Metro security, carried out a joint inspection with Delhi Police and ruled out any foul play. Officials said the incident did not involve any explosive material or sabotage. Instead, it was an accidental occurrence linked to unsafe kite flying near critical infrastructure.

Metro services on the affected line were briefly disrupted during the emergency response and safety checks. However, services resumed shortly after authorities confirmed that operations could continue safely.

Passengers present at the station at the time described moments of confusion and fear after hearing the loud sound. Many initially suspected a blast and rushed towards exits before being guided by security personnel. Authorities said the prompt response by CISF and police helped prevent panic from escalating. Evacuation procedures were carried out in an orderly manner, and no stampede or injuries occurred.

Officials have reiterated warnings against flying kites near Metro lines and other sensitive installations.

Police bust LPG hoarding racket, 459 cylinders seized

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police Crime Branch has seized 459 LPG cylinders and busted an illegal hoarding and suspected black marketing operation in the Ranhola area of outer Delhi on Thursday.

The raid was carried out at HP Balaji Gas Agency on Nilothi Road following specific intelligence inputs about unauthorised storage of cylinders. The agency owner, identified as Susheel Kumar Singhal, was found allegedly

involved in hoarding commercial LPG cylinders, police said. “This action reflects our sustained and proactive efforts to curb illegal activities such as hoarding and black marketing of essential commodities, particularly LPG cylinders, during a period of global supply disruption,” said Harsh Indora, Deputy Commissioner of Police (Crime Branch). “We remain committed to strict enforcement of the law to safeguard public interest and ensure fair distribution.”

According to officials, a



total of 459 empty cylinders were recovered during the operation, including 175 belonging to Bharat Petroleum and 284 to Indane

Gas. The cylinders were allegedly stored without authorisation. Police said the raid followed sustained groundwork and verification

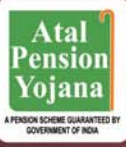
of inputs about hoarding in the area.

Officials said the accused, who owns and operates the gas agency, misused his position to manipulate supply. Instead of distributing cylinders through legal channels, he allegedly stockpiled them to create artificial scarcity. Investigators believe the accused planned to release the cylinders into the open market at inflated prices.

“The stored cylinders were meant to be sold illegally for wrongful gain by taking advantage of the demand-

supply gap,” a senior officer said. The police added that the cylinders were kept under the guise of regular inventory to avoid detection.

The operation was described as systematic and planned. During the raid, the food supply officer, Jag Pravesh, was called to the spot. She carried out the necessary legal procedures as per the rules. The seized cylinders were later handed over on a superdari to Sanjay Kumar Mehta, Sales Area Manager of Hindustan Petroleum Gas.



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IN FOCUS



An illuminated view from the drone show organised by the Maharashtra's Tourism and Cultural Affairs Department in Mumbai. PTI

Ahead of assembly polls, ECI seizes over ₹400 crore

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Illicit inducements worth over ₹408 crore meant to influence voters in four states and a Union territory have been seized in the past month, the Election Commission of India said on Thursday.

While assembly elections and by-elections were announced on March 15, the Electronic Seizure Management System (ESMS) was activated on February 26, it said.

Since its activation, over ₹408.82-crore worth of illicit inducements, including Rs 17.44 crore in cash, liquor worth ₹37.68 crore (16.3 lakh litres), drugs worth Rs 167.38 crore, precious metals



worth ₹23 crore and other freebies worth over ₹163.30 crore, have been seized by multiple enforcement agencies, the EC said.

Besides, 70,944 complaints were lodged using the Vigil application between March 15 and 25. Of these, 70,831 have been dis-

posed of and 67,899 complaints (95.8 per cent) were resolved within 100 minutes, it said.

VIGIL is a mobile application developed by the EC to enable citizens to report model code of conduct violations during elections. Assembly elections will be

held in West Bengal, Assam, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and Kerala next month. A complaint redressal system has been set up, including a call centre number, 1950, on which complaints can be lodged by any member of the public or political party, with the district election officer or returning officer concerned.

The commission has stressed that the enforcement authorities should ensure that ordinary citizens are not inconvenienced or harassed during the checking and inspection for the enforcement of its directives. District grievance committees have also been set up to address any grievances in this regard, the EC said.

CBI conducts searches against Reliance Telecom

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The CBI has conducted searches at the residences of two former directors of Reliance Telecom and the company office after registering an FIR against them in connection with an alleged fraud of ₹114.98 crore in State Bank of India, officials said on Thursday.

"The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) has registered a case against M/s. Reliance Telecom Ltd., Sh. Satish Seth (then Director), Sh. Gautam B Doshi (then Director), unknown public servants and unknown others for offences of conspiracy, cheating under IPC and criminal misconduct and abuse of official position under the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988," a CBI spokesperson said in a statement. The



agency acted on a complaint from SBI about it being defrauded and suffering a wrongful loss of Rs 114.98 crore, she said.

"SBI was a member of the consortium of 11 banks which had sanctioned a total of Rs 735 crore Term Loan facility to Reliance Telecom Ltd.," the CBI said. The agency has conducted searches in Mumbai at the residence of Satish Seth, Gautam B. Doshi and the registered office of Reliance Telecom Ltd. Various documents connected with the loan transactions have been recovered, the spokesperson said.

PM to inaugurate Noida airport on 28 March



View of the newly constructed Noida International Airport, ahead of its inauguration by PM Narendra Modi in Noida. PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will visit Uttar Pradesh on 28 March 2026. At around 11:30 AM, he will undertake a walkthrough of the Terminal Building of Noida International Airport at Jewar, Gautam Buddha Nagar.

Thereafter, at around 12 noon, Prime Minister will inaugurate Phase I of Noida International Airport and address a public gathering on the occasion.

The Prime Minister's Office in a statement said the inauguration of Noida International Airport marks a significant milestone in India's journey towards becoming a global aviation hub. The airport, envisioned as a major international gateway for the National Capital Region (NCR), represents a major step in strengthening the country's airport infrastructure and enhancing regional and international connectivity. Noida International Airport has been developed as the second international airport for the Delhi NCR region,

complementing Indira Gandhi International Airport. Together, the two airports will function as an integrated aviation system, easing congestion, expanding passenger capacity, and positioning Delhi NCR among leading global aviation hubs.

Noida International Airport is among the largest greenfield airport projects in India. Phase I of Noida International Airport has been developed at a total investment of around 11,200 crore under a Public-Private Partnership (PPP) model. The airport will initially have a passenger handling capacity of 12 million passengers per annum (MPPA), with scalability up to 70 MPPA upon full development.

"The airport also incorporates a robust cargo ecosystem, including a Multi-Modal Cargo Hub, featuring an Integrated Cargo Terminal and logistics zones.

The cargo facility is designed to handle over 2.5 lakh metric tonnes annually, expandable to around 18 lakh metric tonnes, and includes a dedicated 40-acre facility," read the statement.

J&K CM warns to refrain crowding petrol pumps

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

Ahead of participating in a meeting convened by Prime Minister Narendra Modi to review the preparedness and plans in the wake of the West Asia conflict, Jammu and Kashmir Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, on Thursday, warned people to refrain from panicking or crowding petrol pumps, claiming that there is no shortage of fuel, LPG or essential commodities in the Union Territory.

"My earnest request is that people stop camping outside petrol pumps. If this



situation continues, I may be forced to shut all petrol pumps for the next few days until this cycle of rumours stop," he told reporters. Abdullah said unnecessary crowding at

fuel stations, despite official assurances, would only worsen the situation. "If people keep gathering outside petrol pumps based on rumours, it will unnecessarily create problems

where none exist," he said, reacting to long queues outside petrol pumps.

On Pakistan positioning itself as a potential mediator in the US-Israel conflict with Iran, Abdullah said any effort that helps end the war should not be opposed.

"The prime minister has scheduled an online meeting tomorrow at 6.30 p.m., in which I will also have the opportunity to participate. It will specifically discuss the situation in Iran and neighbouring regions and what additional steps are being taken to ensure uninterrupted supply of essential commodities,

especially if the conflict continues," Abdullah told reporters.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will interact on Friday with the chief ministers of all states, barring those that are going to polls, to review their preparedness and plans in the wake of the West Asia conflict. Expressing concern over panic buying triggered by social media rumours, Abdullah said such behaviour could itself create artificial shortages. "It is regrettable that when the government speaks, no one listens, but everyone believes rumours," he said.

Karnataka bypolls: 34 candidates in fray in Bagalkote, Davangere South

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Bengaluru

As many as 34 candidates are in the fray for Bagalkot and Davangere South Assembly constituencies bypolls, according to the Karnataka CEO's office.

As per official data, Bagalkot saw 26 nominations filed, of which 14 were found valid after scrutiny. On the last date for withdrawal of nomination on Thursday, five withdrew, and nine candidates are in the fray for April 9 bypolls.

In Davangere South, 45 nominations were received, 36 were accepted after scrutiny, and 25 candidates are now contesting. The bypolls were necessitated following the deaths of sitting Congress MLAs S h a m a n u r Shivashankarappa and H Y Meti in Davangere South



and Bagalkote Assembly constituencies respectively. The Congress has fielded Samarth Shamanur from Davangere South, who is the son of state Mines and Geology Minister SS Mallikarjun and grandson of Shivashankarappa. The BJP has fielded Srinivas T Dasakariyappa.

In Bagalkote, Umesh Meti, son of late H Y Meti, is the Congress candidate and the BJP has fielded Veerabhadra Charantimath. Election authorities said enforce-

ment teams have intensified expenditure monitoring, with seizures amounting to over ₹80 lakh so far.

Cash worth ₹77.34 lakh and liquor valued at about ₹1.74 lakh have been seized cumulatively. A total of 53 FIRs have been registered by surveillance teams and police in connection with seizure of cash, liquor and other items.

The Excise Department has booked 15 heinous cases, four cases for breach of licence conditions and 34 cases under the Karnataka Excise Act, besides seizing 10 vehicles.

Authorities said 24 complaints were received through the cVIGIL app, of which 17 were found to be correct and disposed of, while 21 complaints were received on the national grievance portal, with 18 resolved so far.

CIC seeks transparency in GST processes

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Central Information Commission (CIC) has advised the GST Policy Wing of the Central Board of Excise and Customs to "examine the feasibility of developing appropriate mechanisms, guidelines or public advisories" to enhance transparency and public awareness in GST compliance and remittance.

Issuing the advisory under Section 25(5) of the RTI Act, the commission said such steps may include "transparency tools or awareness measures regarding GST compliance and remittance" in the larger public interest. "The concerns reflect a need for enhanced public facilitation and awareness," the commission observed, adding that the move is in line with the spirit of the RTI

Act to promote transparency and informed citizen participation. The observations came while disposing of a second appeal filed by an applicant who had sought clarifications on issues such as verifying whether GST collected by vendors is deposited with the government and whether consumers can directly remit GST.

The commission, however, upheld the response of the Central Public Information Officer, noting that the queries raised were "largely in the nature of seeking clarifications, opinions, explanations and hypothetical scenarios," and therefore do not fall within the definition of "information" under the RTI Act. However, Information Commissioner Vinod Kumar Tiwari said the "advisory is being issued keeping in view the spirit of the RTI Act".

UAPA invoked against 21 suspects in Pakistan-linked racket

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ghaziabad

Police have invoked the stringent UAPA against 21 people apprehended for alleged involvement in a Pakistan-linked espionage racket, an official said on Thursday.

The invocation of Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) has transformed the case into a high-priority national security investigation, Assistant Commissioner of Police (Indirapuram) Abhishek Srivastava said.

Provisions of the UAPA impose stricter conditions for bail and investigators can take up to 180 days to file a chargesheet without the accused becoming eligible for default bail.



Ghaziabad police officials said the move could also pave the way for the National Investigation Agency (NIA) to take over the

interstate probe.

The suspects, which include a woman and six juveniles, are accused of passing on sensitive infor-

mation to a Pakistan-based handler through social media and other means.

The racket is suspected to have been based across parts of the National Capital Region, Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. According to investigators, the accused maintained cover by working as daily-wage labourers and in other low-profile jobs.

One of the key accused, Sameer alias Shooter, a native of Bihar's Bhagalpur, was allegedly apprehended while working at an eatery in Delhi's Chandni Chowk.

Two juveniles were taken into custody for allegedly installing CCTV cameras on utility poles near Delhi Cantonment and Sonapat railway stations, which were suspected to be used to

monitor train movements, including those of possible military significance. Another accused, Meera Thakur, arrested earlier from Mathura, is suspected to have links to arms smuggling and had claimed to be an informer for the Mumbai Police. Police said the use of juveniles in surveillance activities points to attempts by the network to evade suspicion.

Efforts are underway to trace financial transactions and communication channels to identify handlers operating from across the border, officials said. The espionage racket was busted earlier this month. Further investigation in the case is underway, police added.

Relief scam: Woman tehsildar who took part in Kaun Banega Crorepati arrested

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Sheopur

A woman tehsildar who gained national fame as a participant in the popular television show 'Kaun Banega Crorepati' was arrested from Gwalior in Madhya Pradesh on Thursday for alleged involvement in a ₹2.5 crore flood relief 'scam', officials said.

Amrita Singh Tomar was held in the 2021 'scam' that took place in Baroda tehsil here, an official said, adding she has been lodged in a jail in neighbouring Shivpuri after being produced in court.

"A team led by Baroda Sub Divisional Officer of Police Aneet Sharma arrested



Tomar from her home in Gwalior's Chandravadni Naka. Tomar was tehsildar of Vijaypur but was removed from the post by Collector Arpit Verma on Wednesday," the official said. Tomar had applied earlier for anticipatory bail in the High Court but as well as Supreme Court but

her appeals were rejected, he said. The official said 22 patawaris and one tehsildar have been arrested so far in the 2021 flood relief 'scam', which involves ₹2.5 crore being allegedly transferred into fake bank accounts for the purpose of embezzlement.

Some 110 persons have been named in the FIR in the matter, he added. The case is being probed by the Baroda SDOP, said Superintendent of Police Sudhir Kumar Agarwal. "Tomar had been absent from her duties, and a police team subsequently traced her and arrested her in Gwalior," the SP said.

Tomar had won ₹50 lakh as contestant in 'Kaun Banega Crorepati'.

West Asia crisis: PM to call CMs

The outreach comes as the Union Government closely monitors the potential economic and energy implications of the conflict, particularly risks to fuel supplies and inflation.

Earlier this week, an all-party meeting chaired by Defence Minister Rajnath Singh was held in New Delhi to discuss the situation.

Speaking in the Lok Sabha, Modi warned that global disruptions triggered by the conflict could persist and urged the nation to remain prepared and united, drawing parallels with the collective response during the COVID-19 pandemic.

The government has constituted seven empowered groups, modelled on its pandemic strategy, to oversee key sectors including fuel, fertilisers, supply chains and inflation management. Simultaneously, India is diversifying its energy sources and securing alternative crude oil and gas supplies to ensure continuity.

Highlighting internal security concerns, the Prime Minister cautioned that disruptive elements may attempt to exploit the situation. He said security agencies are on heightened alert, with enhanced vigilance across borders, coasts, cyberspace and critical infrastructure.

Calling for restraint and vigilance, Modi urged States to act firmly against misinforma-

tion, hoarding and black-marketing, stressing the need for swift enforcement and public cooperation.

Final push on Naxals begins

Key strategies include redeploying COBRA commandos to Jharkhand's Saranda forests to target senior Maoist leaders such as Misir Besra alias Bhaskar. A multi-State operation involving forces from Maharashtra, Chhattisgarh, Telangana and Odisha is also underway to prevent regrouping or escape.

The campaign marks a dramatic decline in

the insurgency's footprint. From 76 affected districts across nine States in 2005-06, only seven remain today. In Chhattisgarh's Bastar region — once the epicentre — nearly 96 per cent of the area is now free from Maoist influence, according to Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Sharma. Data show that over 370 Maoists were neutralised and thousands surrendered in 2025. Early 2026 has seen further high-profile surrenders, with only a handful of senior leaders still at large. One such figure, Rammanna alias Ganapathi, is reportedly in contact with Telangana Police and may surrender before the deadline.

The Ministry of Home Affairs has drawn up plans for the post-deadline phase, including

redeploying select battalions, handing over camps to State police and rolling out welfare schemes in former LWE districts.

An announcement on withdrawals and new welfare schemes for former LWE districts is expected on March 31.

"However, the security vigilance will continue even after the deadline," said Vijay Sharma, the Home Minister of Chhattisgarh. Experts stress that sustained development in remote tribal areas will be essential to prevent any resurgence of the insurgency. "There has to be strong proactive measures to address the issues faced by the tribal and the local populace to prevent any resurgence of the deadly Maoist ideology", security experts say.

FROM PAGE - 1

India has 1 month LPG supply, 60 days oil stock: Government

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

Unabated panic buying of fuel in the country prompted the Government on Thursday to assure the citizens that India has about 60 days of oil stock cover and has arranged one full month of LPG supply.

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, for the first time since the war in West Asia broke out, also released stock details of crude oil, fuels and LPG. "There is no shortage of petrol, diesel, or LPG anywhere in the country," it said, emphasising that the country's petroleum and LPG supply situation is "fully secure and under control." The ministry reiterated India's fuel security, saying that the country continues to function as an "oasis of energy security."

"Any representation that India's reserves are depleted or insufficient should be dismissed with the disdain it deserves," the ministry said, dismissing with "disdain" reports of depleted oil reserves in the country. This follows the Centre's earlier clarification dismissing reports that LPG refill booking timelines had been changed. It said the claims were incorrect and misleading, and reaffirmed that the existing timelines "remain unchanged and continue to" operate under the current time limit. Parallely, State-owned oil marketing companies also said there is no shortage of petrol, diesel or liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) and supplies remain stable.

India, it said, has 74 days of total crude oil and fuel stocking capacity. "Actual



Consumers throng at a petrol station amid rumours of fuel shortages due to the war in West Asia in Amritsar on Thursday

stock cover is around 60 days right now (including crude stocks, products stocks and the dedicated strategic storage in caverns) even as we are on the 27th day of the Middle East crisis." "Nearly two months of steady supply is available for every Indian citizen regardless of what happens globally." With the next two months of crude procurement already secured, India is completely secure for the next many months and the quantity in strategic cavern storage becomes secondary in such a supply situation, it said. "Any representation that India's reserves are depleted or insufficient should be dismissed with the disdain it deserves," the ministry said.

With some petrol pumps, especially in smaller towns, finding difficulty in lifting fuel after oil companies put them on cash-and-carry, the

ministry said in a statement that steps have been taken to increase credit to petrol pumps to over three days from earlier allowed one day in order to ensure that there is no shortage of petrol and diesel at any pump due to working capital issues of pump owners.

Stating that all retail fuel outlets have enough supplies, the ministry called upon citizens not to be "misled by a deliberately mischievous, coordinated campaign of misinformation that is being carried out to spread unjustified panic."

While the Iran war has disrupted the supply of half of the crude oil (raw material used to make fuels like petrol and diesel), the country has secured enough crude supplies from elsewhere for the next 60 days. Also, fuel tanks are at optimum levels and can help cover two months

of requirements.

On LPG, whose supply has been scarce because of the shutting down of Strait of Hormuz - the conduit which shipped a bulk of Indian supplies, the ministry said 800,000 tonnes of LPG cargoes have been secured and one full month of supply is firmly arranged.

Separately, Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL) put out posts to say their petrol pumps were operating normally and there was no shortage of any fuels. India, the world's fourth-largest refiner and fifth-largest exporter of petroleum products, has structurally assured domestic fuel availability and continues to supply refined fuels to over 150 countries, the ministry statement said.

Kharge writes to Rijiju over women's quota amendments

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

With the BJP-led Centre likely to convene a special session of Parliament to pass amendments to the Women's Reservation Act, Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge wrote to Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju on Thursday, asking why the Government was in a "great hurry" to amend the women's quota law.

In his letter to Rijiju, Kharge also reiterated that an all-party meeting should be held on the matter after the current round of Assembly elections is completed in April.

Kharge's letter came in response to one from the Union minister to the Congress chief seeking a meeting with the party on plans to amend the Nari Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023, for its implementation.

"I have just received your letter on 26th March 2026. Opposition parties have already written to you on 24th March 2026, suggesting that an all-party meeting be held after April 29th, 2026, to discuss the implementation of the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023," the Congress president said.

"Simply fail to understand why the Government is in such great hurry to further amend a Constitutional Amendment Act, 30 months after it was initially passed. We are all extremely busy with the election campaign. That is the reason why we had suggested that the meeting be held after the election campaign is over," Kharge said.

This will, in no way, affect the implementation of the



Congress chief Mallikarjun Kharge

amended Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023, from the 2029 Lok Sabha election onwards, he said. "In fact, on 21st September, 2023, during the debate in the Rajya Sabha, I had myself demanded the immediate implementation of Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023, but the Government had not agreed with my demand. I once again request you to convene an all-party meeting any time after April 29, 2026," Kharge said.

Several Opposition parties on Tuesday wrote to the Government, asking for an all-party meeting to be convened to discuss the modalities of the implementation of the women's quota law.

In a letter to Rijiju, the Opposition leaders had said the meeting should be held after the current round of Assembly elections is completed in April.

"You may recall that I had written to you on March 16, 2026, requesting that an all-party meeting chaired by the PM be convened at the earliest to discuss, as desired by you, the modalities and roadmap for the implementation of the Nari Vandan Adhiniyam, 2023," the letter written on Congress president Kharge's letterhead had said.

Nation Focus



PM Modi extends greetings to citizens on Ram Navami

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday extended greetings on Ram Navami, saying the ideals of Lord Ram will remain a guiding force not only for the people of India but for the entire humanity for all times to come. The prime minister also prayed that, with the blessings of Lord Rama, everyone is granted well-being, helping pave the way for the fulfilment of the vision of a developed and self-reliant India. "Heartfelt wishes to all my family members across the country on the auspicious occasion of Ram Navami. The life of Maryada Purushottam Lord Ram, marked by sacrifice, penance, and self-restraint, continues to inspire people to face every situation with strength and determination.



Build subways to prevent rail accidents: Vaishnaw to officials

Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Thursday held a workshop with officials from all railway zones and directed them to work out a plan to construct subways around settlement areas to ensure people can cross tracks safely. The Railway Ministry has planned to cover all settlement areas in the vicinity of railway tracks across the country in the next five to six years, according to an official statement.

Vaishnaw asked the officials to design subways in such a way that people feel free to use them and these subways should not face waterlogging during the rainy season.

Congress has become feeder organisation for BJP: CPI(M)

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The CPI(M) on Thursday accused the Congress of becoming a "feeder organisation" for the BJP and slammed its leaders Mallikarjun Kharge and Rahul Gandhi for "targeting" the Left instead of the saffron party in poll-going Kerala.

It said that this raises questions about Congress's claim of "fighting communal-authoritarian forces" and also asked the party to introspect why



several of its leaders have crossed over to the BJP.

In a statement, the Politburo of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) said the Left party "strongly disproves the provocative state-

ments" made by Gandhi and Kharge against Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan and the secular credentials of the CPI(M).

"Such canards are being spread by them to secure cheap electoral gains in the Assembly elections.

By targeting the CPI(M) instead of the BJP, the Congress leaders are reneging on their claim of fighting communal-authoritarian forces. The people of Kerala will see through this sinister agenda," it said.

Highly inappropriate: Gehlot on Jaishankar's dalaal remark in all-party meeting

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Jaipur

Veteran Congress leader Ashok Gehlot on Thursday criticised S Jaishankar over his use of the word "dalaal" during the all-party meeting on the West Asia crisis and said the use of such language by an external affairs minister is "inappropriate".

Gehlot also said that US President Donald Trump's behaviour towards Modi was "difficult to understand".

The central Government on Wednesday told an all-party meeting on the West Asia crisis that there is nothing new in Pakistan's mediation efforts in the matter, as that country has been "used" by the US since 1981.

"We are not a dalaal nation," Jaishankar had told the attendees of the meeting convened at the Parliament complex.

Targeting the external affairs minister for his remarks in the context of Pakistan's



S Jaishankar, Minister of External Affairs of India

mediation in the war, the senior Congress leader said that it is highly inappropriate for the external affairs minister to assert that someone is engaging in "Dalaali."

"I believe that no external affairs minister should use such language when referring to another nation.

If this were a slip of the tongue, he should express regret. Otherwise, he deserves to face severe criticism in the country," he said.

It will be TMC's credit if 30 lakh names feature on voters' list after adjudication: CM Mamata

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dubrajpur (West Bengal)

Trinamool Congress (TMC) supremo Mamata Banerjee on Thursday claimed that it will be her party's credit if around 30 lakh of the over 60 lakh names under adjudication appear on the voters' list.

Addressing an election rally here in Birbhum district, Banerjee, also the West Bengal chief minister, asserted that the TMC will ensure a legal recourse for all those whose names were deleted.

"It is to our credit if 29 to 30 lakh of the over 60 lakh names under adjudication find themselves in the list... it is because of our campaign and fight that these names would be on the list. But I want 100 per cent names to appear on the list as they are all genuine voters," she said.

The Election Commission of India (ECI) released the first supplementary list of 'Under Adjudication' voters on Monday, but did not officially disclose the number of deletions or the precise figure of cases disposed of in that list.

A top ECI official in Kolkata said on Wednesday that 32 lakh 'Under Adjudication' cases have been disposed of so far, and around 28 lakh names remain to be cleared by judicial officers.

Addressing the rally,



West Bengal chief minister Mamta Banerjee

BJP PLOTTING TO DELETE NAMES OF BONA FIDE CITIZENS FROM POLL LIST: ABHISHEK BANERJEE

Kolkata: Trinamool Congress leader Abhishek Banerjee on Thursday accused the BJP Government at the Centre of conspiring against the country's bona fide citizens by deleting their names from the electoral rolls under the pretext of the SIR exercise. Canvassing for TMC candidate Nirmal Chandra Roy at a rally in Jalpaiguri district's Dhupguri, he also charged the saffron party with indulging in politics on the basis of religion and diverting people's attention from core issues of livelihood and housing.

"The BJP Government at the Centre is conspiring against the bona fide citizens of the country. In the name of SIR, those living here for a hundred years are being forced to give proof of their citizenship. "Even elderly people are being asked to stand in queues for hours, just to see their names either deleted (from the electoral rolls) or under adjudication," the TMC national general secretary alleged.

Banerjee, considered number 2 in the TMC hierarchy, claimed that people belonging to indigenous communities are being asked to furnish proof of their citizenship in BJP-ruled Assam.

Banerjee said that TMC's lawyers will help those not on the list fight their cases before the tribunals set up for the purpose.

She said that TMC's camps will be set up in every locality to assist those whose

publish the complete list detailing the logical discrepancies for over 60 lakh people. Claiming that it is still not clear whose names have been deleted from the adjudication list, she asked the Election Commission of India to "come out with the final list if they have the guts." Banerjee said that she will ensure that those who do not find their names on the list appeal before the tribunal. "Do you want to stand in queues again or derail the BJP?" she asked, while addressing the public rally. The TMC supremo pointed out that people had to stand in queues over demonetisation, procuring the Aadhaar card and the SIR exercise.

Banerjee said that the SIR exercise, which she has opposed consistently, "was initiated just before the State Assembly elections to get President's Rule imposed in Bengal."

Stating that all the top officers, including the chief secretary, home secretary and the State's DGP, have been changed by the Election Commission immediately after announcing the Assembly elections, Banerjee said, "I will remember everything."

Maintaining that she is not "vindictive," she said she has faith in everybody.

The tenure of the current TMC Government in the State will end on May 7.



profile individual as Mr Modi," the High Court said in its 18-page ruling.

A bench comprising Lord Justice Stuart-Smith and Justice Jay "refused" Nirav Modi's plea to reopen his extradition appeal under the Criminal Procedure Rules on

Wednesday, noting that diplomatic undertakings given by India between September 2025 and February 2026 "provided a sheaf of assurances that are comprehensive, detailed and reliable".

The pivot in the case was a 'note verbale' sent to the UK Government on December 2, 2025, by the Indian home ministry, signed by Joint Secretary Rakesh Pandey, assuring that Nirav Modi would not be interrogated by the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI), the Enforcement Directorate (ED), the Serious Fraud Investigation Office (SFIO), the Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI), or the Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT).

It also included a detailed plan for keeping Nirav Modi in Mumbai's Arthur Road prison, the facilities he would have access to, and the legal help available to him during the trial.

"The assurances are specific and not general and vague (cf. those given in Bhandari). The assurances have been given by an official within the Ministry of Home Affairs competent to bind the GoI, as well as the State of Maharashtra and the five investigating agencies (which are also bound in our view by the terms of the assurances). Although India is not a signatory to UNCAT, we do not doubt that torture is not permitted under Indian law," the Court held.

5 lakh bighas of encroached land to be freed by next BJP Govt: Assam CM

TONY DAS
■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Thursday said the BJP Government will evict encroachers from five lakh bighas of land if it returns to power after the April 9 Assembly polls.

Addressing an election rally in Bajali Assembly constituency, Sarma said the encroachers, had been taught a lesson over the past five years, and their domination over indigenous communities had "significantly decreased."



Assam CM Himanta Biswa Sarma at the Jana Ashirvad Yatra in Mongoldoi

"In the last five years, we cleared 1.5 lakh bighas of land, but our target for the next five years will be to free five lakh bighas of

encroached Government land," he said. Sarma asserted that only indigenous people will have rights over land in Assam.

"The BJP is committed to protecting 'Jaati, Maati and Bheti' (people, land and foundation), and we will not allow anyone to work against this. A firm handling of illegal migrants is essential for the survival of the indigenous population, and we will not compromise on this," he added.

Attacking Congress State president Gaurav Gogoi, Sarma said that his concept of a new Greater Assam is unacceptable because he (Gogoi) is indirectly suggesting that Bangladeshis and the people of the State will have to live together.

States Focus



GUJARAT GOVT ALLOCATES ₹60 CRORE TO SET UP BIO-CNG PLANTS

The Gujarat Government has allocated ₹60 crore to establish new bio-CNG plants through cooperative milk production societies, an official said on Thursday. Under the leadership of Chief Minister Bhupendra Patel, the objective of this budget allocation is to transform the dairy sector into a hub for clean energy production and to make the rural economy self-reliant, a release said. "A phased plan has been proposed to establish around 10 bio-CNG plants across the State. A bio-CNG plant converts organic waste, such as cow dung, agricultural residues, and food waste, into purified compressed biogas used for transportation and industrial fuel," it said.



SONIA GANDHI RESPONDING, RECOVERING WELL: HOSPITAL

Senior Congress leader Sonia Gandhi is responding well to treatment for a systemic infection and continues to remain under medical supervision at Sir Ganga Ram Hospital, the hospital authorities said on Thursday. Chairman Dr Ajay Swaroop said that Sonia Gandhi, who was admitted on the night of March 24, is being treated with antibiotics for systemic infection and is responding well to the therapy. She is under the care of a team of senior doctors, who are closely monitoring her condition, he said. Sources said Sonia Gandhi is likely to remain under observation at the hospital for a couple more days as a precautionary measure. Her condition is stable and not serious, they added.

Fire on board bus kill 14 in Andhra Pradesh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Rayavaram (Andhra Pradesh)

Fourteen people on board a private bus were burnt to death, and 22 were injured in a blaze triggered following the vehicle's collision with a truck here in Markapuram district on Thursday. Among the injured, three are reported to be in critical condition.

The mishap took place between 5.30 am and 6 am near Rayavaram village on the road leading to Podili when the bus reportedly rammed into the concrete chips-laden dumper truck, colliding with its fuel tank, which sparked a massive inferno.

"There were 41 people in the bus at the time of the accident and all the 13 deceased persons were burnt to death," Home Minister Vangalapudi Anitha said.

According to her, the bus belonged to Harikrishna Travels and its owner hails from Kanigiri. She said the bus possessed license and insurance till December 2026. The private bus was heading to Kaligiri in Nellore district from Jagtial in Telangana.

President Droupadi Murmu, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Andhra Pradesh Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu expressed grief



Smoke and flames billow after a private travel bus collided with a tipper and caught fire in Rayavaram village of Markapuram district, Andhra Pradesh on Thursday

over the incident. The Prime Minister announced an ex-gratia of ₹2 lakh from the Prime Minister's National Relief Fund(PMNRFF) to the next of kin of each deceased person.

The injured would be given ₹50,000. Markapuram in-charge SP V Harshavardhan Raju said the preliminary probe pointed to the bus veering off into the wrong lane and

hitting the truck.

President Murmu condoled the loss of lives and wished a speedy recovery to the injured. "Deeply saddened to learn about the tragic

bus accident in Markapuram district, Andhra Pradesh. I extend my deepest condolences to the bereaved families. My thoughts and prayers are with them. I wish a speedy recovery to those injured," she said in a social media post.

"The mishap in Markapuram district, Andhra Pradesh, is tragic. Condolences to those who have lost their loved ones. May the injured recover at the earliest," PM Modi said.

Andhra Pradesh CM Naidu and his Telangana counterpart A Revanth Reddy expressed profound shock and grief over the road accident.

Naidu held a teleconference with senior officials and ministers, directing them to extend the best possible medical care for all the injured victims and adequate compensation to the families of the deceased and injured passengers.

Ordering an investigation into the accident, Naidu offered his deepest condolences to the bereaved families and assured full support from the State Government. Revanth Reddy directed Telangana Chief Secretary Ramakrishna Rao to gather complete details about those who died and those who were injured in the accident.

India's CO2 emissions growth slows to 20-year low

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India's carbon dioxide (CO2)emissions grew in 2025 at the slowest rate in more than two decades, according to an analysis by the Centre for Research on Energy and Clean Air (CREA).

The analysis also pointed out that emissions in the power sector fell by 3.8 pc as record clean-energy growth combined with weak electricity demand. Also, consumption of imported coal at power plants fell by 20 per



cent in 2025. "India's carbon dioxide (CO2) emissions grew by 0.5 per cent in the second half of 2025 and by just 0.7

per cent in the year as a whole, the slowest rate in more than two decades. "This is a sharp slowdown

from the growth of 4-11 per cent in the preceding four years and marks the lowest rate of increase since 2001, excluding the impact of Covid in 2020," said the analysis on India's CO2 emissions from fossil fuels and cement, based on official data for fuel use, industrial production and power output.

"This is the second in a new series of half-yearly analysis on India's CO2 emissions from fossil fuels and cement, based on official data for fuel use, industrial

production and power output," it added.

According to Lauri Myllyvirta, lead analyst at CREA, the analysis shows that India's power sector is poised for a potential inflection point, where clean-energy additions can meet or exceed the growth in electricity demand.

If clean energy matches expectations, allowing this inflection point to take place, then coal-fired power output and the associated CO2 emissions would see sustained falls.

Panel urges priority funding to boost atomic minerals

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A parliamentary panel has recommended priority-based funding for the Atomic Minerals Directorate for Exploration and Research (AMDER) to scale up uranium and rare metal exploration in the country.

In a report tabled in both Houses of Parliament, the Department-related Parliamentary Standing



Committee on Science and Technology, Environment, Forests and Climate Change flagged inadequate funding for uranium exploration activities.

The panel stated that the full shortfall of ₹118.18 crore in AMDER's capital allocation be restored at the revised estimate stage of 2026-27.

Parliamentary panel on tourism seeks to fast-track changes to monuments Act

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A parliamentary panel has recommended to the Centre to ensure "expeditious" passage of amendments to the Ancient Monuments and Archaeological Sites and Remains (AMASR) Act, 1958, with particular attention to the "flexible" buffer zone provisions.

The Parliamentary Standing Committee on Transport, Tourism and Culture has also urged the Ministry of Culture to "earmark" a portion of the ticketing revenue of ₹365 crore annually from centrally protected monuments for reinvestment in those monuments, and asked the ministry to present a detailed proposal for such a "ring-fenced revenue mechanism" to the panel within six months.

The report — "Demands for Grants (2026-27) of Ministry of Culture" — of the committee, headed by JD(U) MP Sanjay Kumar Jha, was presented in Parliament on Wednesday.

The ministry informed the committee that the AMASR Act amendment has been "prepared for Parliament".

The ministry has said that the "new rules" will make the 100-metre and 200-metre buffer zone limits "flexible," according to the report.

The committee has recommended to the ministry to ensure "expeditious passage

of the AMASR Act amendment, with particular attention to the flexible buffer zone provisions", while also asking the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) to "formulate clear standard operating procedures for denotification decisions, with a defined timeline not exceeding 90 days from receipt of application to final decision".

The panel also asked the ministry to establish a time-



bound mechanism for responding to denotification requests, particularly where essential public infrastructure such as schools and hospitals is affected; and underlined that the staffing measures be implemented "on priority" for ticketed monuments, the report said.

As per Sections 20A and 20B of the AMASR Act, a uniform "00-m prohibited

area" and "200-m regulated area" have been prescribed around all ASI-protected monuments and sites.

The AMASR Act provides provision for prior permission for carrying out any repair or renovation of any building or structure located within the regulated area of a protected site. The committee has raised concerns during the evidence about ASI-protected sites "lacking protectors". It

also noted that monuments are being used as "relieving spots" due to the absence of staff presence.

The ministry informed the panel that it "denotified 18 sites during the current year after careful survey, while notifying 15-16 new sites". The ministry said the denotification process is conducted carefully to prevent manipulation by real estate developers.

Donations to national parties surge 161% in FY25

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Donations to national parties surged by 161 per cent in 2024-25 compared to the previous fiscal, with the ruling BJP accounting for the majority — more than ten times the combined total received by all other national parties, according to a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR).

The report, released on Thursday, said total donations above ₹20,000 declared by the national



parties stood at ₹6,648.563 crore from 11,343 contributions in FY25.

Of this, the BJP alone received ₹6,074.015 crore from 5,522 donations, followed by the Congress with

₹517.394 crore from 2,501 donations.

The BJP's declared donations exceeded the combined total of the Congress, the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), the Communist Party of

India to boost critical minerals, cut import dependence: Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India will scale up exploration of critical minerals, creating a startup-driven mining ecosystem and building strong domestic value chains to reduce import dependence, Union minister Jitendra Singh said on Thursday.

Speaking at a meeting of the National Mineral Exploration and Development Trust, Singh stated that the pace of exploration, particularly for lithium and other critical minerals, needs to align with emerging global demand and India's strategic requirements.

"India must create a con-



ducive environment for Indian companies and startups to enter the mining and critical minerals sector," the minister of State for earth sciences said.

He referred to the success of the biotechnology startup ecosystem, and said that similar institutional support, targeted incentives, and handholding mechanisms can enable innovation in

mining technologies and exploration methods.

Singh also called for strengthening the role of Notified Private Exploration Agencies, improving access to technology and finance, and ensuring faster project approvals so that private participation expands in a meaningful manner.

"Faster approvals, better procurement systems, and timely pre-exploration clearances are necessary to maintain momentum in exploration activities... Issues related to forest clearances continue to affect timelines in several projects and require coordinated efforts for resolution," the minister said.

Jaishankar in France for G7 meet; West Asia crisis tops agenda

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar on Thursday travelled to France for the G7 foreign ministers' meeting, which will discuss the West Asia crisis with a focus on coordinating efforts to ensure that the Strait of Hormuz remains open for international shipping.

While India is not a G7 member, it has been invited as a partner country by France, the current chair of the powerful bloc.

Top diplomats from the US, Canada, Germany, Italy, France, Japan and the UK are attending the meeting. The external affairs minister will visit Abbaye des-Vaux-de-Cernay in France on March 26 and 27 to participate in the G7 foreign ministers' meeting with partner



External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar being received by France Foreign Minister Jean-Noël Barrot on his arrival at Abbaye des Vaux-de-Cernay in France

countries, according to an official statement. Jaishankar is also expected to hold bilateral discussions with his counterparts on the sidelines of the G7 meeting, it said.

Besides India, France has invited Saudi Arabia, South Korea and Brazil. According to a French official, there will be a session dedicated to the crisis in West Asia.

The ministers will deliberate on exploring different negotiation channels that could lead to de-escalation in the region and reopen maritime routes, the official said.

The foreign ministers will also discuss how to "tackle the nuclear and ballistic programme of Iran," the official noted. Global oil and gas prices have surged after Iran virtually blocked the Strait of Hormuz, a narrow shipping lane between the Persian Gulf and the Gulf of Oman,

which handles roughly 20 per cent of global oil and LNG (Liquefied Natural Gas). West Asia has been a major source of India's energy procurement. In the last couple of weeks, India has made diplomatic efforts focused on ending the conflict in West Asia as soon as possible and ensuring the unimpeded flow of energy through the Strait of Hormuz.

New Delhi thinks there could be serious ramifications for fuel and fertiliser security for many countries, including India, if the blockade of the shipping lane continues.

The Group of 7 (G7) brings together seven of the world's most advanced economies: Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, the United Kingdom and the United States. The European Union is also a member of the bloc.

6 Naxalites surrender in Chhattisgarh's Kanker

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kanker

Six Naxalites have surrendered in Chhattisgarh's Kanker district in last two days, a senior official said on Thursday.

Five Maoist cadres from the Rajnandgaon-Kanker border division and one from military company number 5 turned themselves in before the police and decided to join the mainstream over the past two days, Kanker Superintendent of Police

stream, he said.

The formal process of rehabilitation, including reintegration into society and submission of weapons, will be held later, he added.

Inspector General of Police, Bastar Range, Sundarraaj Pattilingam, reiterated his appeal to the remaining Maoist cadres to renounce violence and opt for a peaceful and dignified life.

He assured that those who surrender will receive all benefits under the Government's rehabilitation policy.



Nikhil Rakhecha said.

The surrendered cadres were identified as Area Committee Members (ACM) Mangesh Podiyami, Ganesh VK, Mangti Jurri, Hidme Markam alias Sunita, Rajee, and PPCM (platoon party committee member) Swaroopa Usendi from PLGA military company number 5, he said.

They handed over three weapons, including one Self-Loading Rifle (SLR) and two .303 rifles, to the police, he said. Based on the information they provided, efforts are underway to establish contact with other active cadres in the region and encourage them to give up violence and join the main-

More than 2,700 Maoist cadres have joined the mainstream in the past 26 months under the State's surrender and rehabilitation policy, he added.

On March 24, senior Maoist commander Papa Rao surrendered along with 17 of his associates in the Bastar region, marking a major development in the State's fight against Left Wing Extremism.

Following his surrender, Deputy Chief Minister Vijay Sharma, who also holds the Home portfolio, said that no senior-ranking Naxal operative would remain active in the State after Papa Rao's surrender.



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Order Order

Delhi HC upholds man’s acquittal in POCSO case, says horoscope not proof of age



The Delhi High Court has upheld the acquittal of a man accused of kidnapping and raping a 16-year-old girl, ruling that the horoscope and vaccination card were not proof of age and hence, he could not be prosecuted under the POCSO Act.

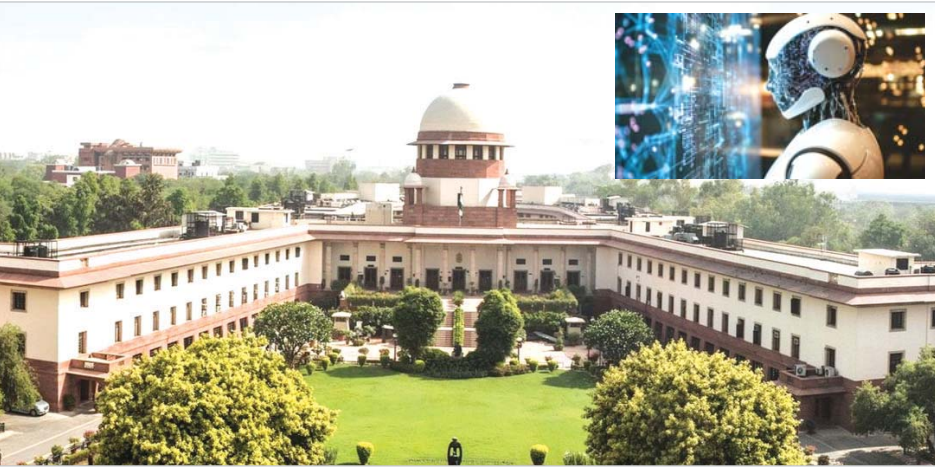
A bench of Justices Navin Chawla and Ravinder Dudeja said the survivor’s age is the “prime question” in cases under the POCSO Act, but the girl’s parents could neither state her date of birth nor produce an original birth certificate on record.

In his testimony, the girl’s father said his wife used their daughter’s horoscope – prepared at the time of her birth – for school admission.

However, the court said, “Admittedly, *janam patri* (horoscope) cannot be considered as proof of date of birth. Therefore, the age recorded in the school record based on the horoscope cannot also be considered as proof of age.” Date of birth in the Jachcha Bachcha Raksha Card or vaccination card was also not legitimate, it said. In the judgment passed on Wednesday, the bench concluded that in the absence of “authentic” documents, the prosecution failed to prove that the prosecutrix was a minor at the time of the incident, and therefore, the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act has no applicability in the case.

According to the prosecution, the girl, aged around 16 years, was kidnapped by the respondent in January 2013. She was found in Amritsar, following which the police booked the respondent for kidnap and rape under the Indian Penal Code and for penetrative sexual assault under the POCSO Act.

SC concern over AI-backed non-existent judgements



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court has voiced concern over growing “menace” of litigants and lawyers citing non-existent judgements generated by artificial intelligence. A bench comprising justices Rajesh Bindal and Vijay Bishnoi said the practice is becoming increasingly rampant across courts in India and throughout the world.

The observations were made by the top court while expunging remarks made by the Bombay High Court on a plea filed a director of a company.

“As a matter of indulgence, we expunge the remarks made in the aforesaid

paragraph. However, the fact remains that this menace is rampant in all courts now, not only in India rather throughout the world.

Everyone needs to be careful about this. In fact, this court is already seized of this matter on judicial side,” the bench said.

The High Court had noted in its order that the submissions of the appellant were generated using ChatGPT, including a judgement which had no citation in the real world.

“The respondent has filed written submissions in February 2025 and April 2025. From the overall tenor of the written submissions and a few give-away features, such as green-box tick-marks, bullet-point-marks, repetitive

submissions etc., this court strongly feels that the submissions are prepared using an AI tool such as ChatGPT or alike.

“A strong pointer is seen from a reference made to one alleged caselaw ‘Jyoti w/o Dinesh Tulsiani Vs. Elegant Associates’. Neither citation is given nor a copy of judgement is supplied by the respondent. This court and its law clerks were at pains to find out this caselaw but could not find. This has resulted in waste of precious judicial time,” the High Court had said.

It had said an AI tool can very well be used to aid research but there is a great responsibility on the parties to cross-verify the references and the materials generated by it.

HC issues notice to Siddaramaiah, wife, Lokayukta police, ED in MUDA case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

The Karnataka High Court on Thursday ordered serving notices to Chief Minister Siddaramaiah and his wife Parvathi BM in connection with the closure report filed by the Lokayukta police in the MUDA site (plot) allotment case. The court also sought a response from the Lokayukta police and the Enforcement Directorate on the B-Report (Closure report).

Hearing a plea filed by activist



Snehamayi Krishna challenging the B-Report filed by the Lokayukta police, Justice S Sunil Dutt Yadav ordered the issue of notices.

In the Mysuru Urban Development Authority (MUDA) case, allegations were made that compensatory sites were allotted to Siddaramaiah’s wife in an upscale area of Mysuru, with a higher property value than the location of her land that had been acquired by MUDA.

MUDA had allotted plots to Parvathi under a 50:50 ratio scheme in lieu of 3.16 acres of her land,

where it developed a residential layout.

Under the scheme, MUDA allots 50 per cent of developed land to landowners in exchange for undeveloped land acquired for residential layouts.

The Karnataka Lokayukta police, which registered the case against Siddaramaiah, his wife, and his brother-in-law, later gave them a clean chit by filing a closure report, which was admitted by the Special Court to try Public Representatives on January 28.

Delhi court sends 2 men to 11-day NIA custody for murder of Bangladesh leader

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court has sent two men accused of killing Bangladeshi political activist Osman Hadi, whose daylight murder sparked widespread violence in the neighbouring country, to 11-day NIA custody.

The two Bangladesh nationals, Faisal Karim Masud alias Rahul (37) and Alamgir Hossain (34), residents of Patuakhali and Dhaka, respectively, were arrested by the West Bengal Special Task Force (STF) on the intervening night of March 7 and 8 after being apprehended from the border town of Bongaon in North 24 Parganas district.

They were brought to the



NIA brings accused persons before court

FILE PHOTO

national capital on a transit remand by the National Investigation Agency on the evening of March 23, and the anti-terror agency produced them before the court the next day.

During the proceedings on Tuesday, Special Public

Prosecutor (SPP) Rahul Tyagi sought NIA custody of the accused, saying a detailed probe was needed to unearth the whole conspiracy. Allowing the agency’s plea, Additional Sessions Judge Prashant Sharma sent them to NIA custody for 11

days. Earlier, the STF had issued a statement, saying there was credible information that two Bangladeshi nationals, after committing serious crimes, including extortion and murder in Bangladesh, had fled and illegally entered India.

It had been said that the two accused entered Indian territory through the Meghalaya border and moved through different places in India, and finally came to Bongaon with the intention of crossing back into Bangladesh.

“They were trying to take shelter in the border area of Bongaon with the intention of crossing back into Bangladesh when the opportunity arises,” the statement said.

72-year-old Delhi man sentenced to 20 years rigorous imprisonment for rape of minor

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A court here has sentenced a 72-year-old man to 20 years of rigorous imprisonment for raping a minor last year, saying despite the victim addressing him as grandfather, he preyed upon her to quench his lust.

Underlining the betrayal of trust and erosion of societal values, Additional Sessions Judge Babita Punia said that the crime shattered the societal notion that elders protected children.

Judge Punia was hearing arguments on sentencing against the man who had been convicted under the penal provision for rape and Section 6 (aggravated pene-



trative sexual assault) of the POCSO Act. In its order dated March 24, the court said the victim was merely eight years old and so the foremost aggravating factor in the case was the comparative age of the convict and the victim.

“The victim used to call him ‘dada’ but he preyed upon her to quench his covetous-

ness and selfish needs – his lust,” the court said.

“The assault, in the considered opinion of this court, is not only on the child but it also profanes the very reverence our society holds for elders, eroding the foundation upon which families and communities rest. This also shatters our notion that

elders protect children,” it said. It trashed the defence argument seeking a lenient sentence on the grounds that it was “not a case of penile-vaginal rape but of oral rape.”

“The legislature has made no distinction whatsoever between penile-vaginal, penile-oral, penile-anal, digital or any other form of penetration. Oral rape (fellatio/oral penetration) squarely falls within the definition of penetrative sexual assault,” the court said. It then sentenced him to 20 years of rigorous imprisonment for committing the offence under Section 6 (punishment for aggravated penetrative sexual assault) of the POCSO Act.

Property of J-K man involved in anti-national activities attached

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Srinagar

The property of a proclaimed offender involved in anti-national activities was attached on Thursday in Baramulla district of Jammu and Kashmir. As part of ongoing efforts against the terror ecosystem, police in the Sopore area attached an immovable property belonging to an absconding suspect linked to an Egress and Internal Movement (Control) Ordinance (EIMCO) case registered at the Panzalla police station, a police spokesman said.

The EIMCO Act is used in Jammu and Kashmir to regulate or restrict the movement of people into, out of, or within the union territory. It is frequently applied in tandem with anti-terror laws to prosecute individuals involved in unlawful, anti-national, or border-crossing activities.

He further stated that the property in question consists of land measuring one Kanal and 12.5 Marlas located in the Fidarpora village, which is recorded in the name of Khurshid Ahmad Dar.

The accused has been evading legal proceedings and is wanted in FIR No. 02/2008 under Sections 2/3 of the EIMCO Act, the spokesman said.

According to the investigation, Dar is currently residing in Pakistan-administered Kashmir and is involved in anti-national



J&K Police executes property attachment procedures

FILE PHOTO

activities, including providing support to terrorist elements in the Kashmir valley, the spokesman stated.

Following the due legal process, proclamation proceedings under Section 87 of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) were initiated, leading to Dar being declared a Proclaimed Offender by the court, he added.

Subsequently, attachment proceedings were executed in compliance with court orders under Section 88 of the CrPC.

The attachment was carried out in the presence of officials from the Revenue Department and independent witnesses, with all proper procedures being observed, the spokesman noted, adding that attachment notices were served and affixed at the site.

Hathras court acquits professor accused of sexually exploiting female students

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

A court in Hathras here has acquitted a college professor accused of sexually exploiting female students on the pretext of helping them clear competitive examinations and secure jobs, officials said on Thursday. According to the prosecution, the court of Additional District Judge Mahendra Kumar passed the order on Tuesday, citing a lack of evidence and absence of corroboration by the alleged victims in their statements.

The accused, Rajneesh Kumar, a geography professor at a degree college, had faced allegations of sexually exploiting students, supported by purported photos and videos. However, during the trial, none of the witnesses or victims confirmed the allegations in court.

Officials said that although some witnesses and students were produced, only one complainant recorded a statement before a magistrate, and no victim substantiated the charges of sexual exploitation during court proceedings.

The court observed that the allegations against the professor could not be proved beyond a reasonable doubt and did not rule out the possibility of fabricated evidence being presented with the intent to implicate him. In the absence of sufficient evidence, the court acquitted Kumar.

The case had come to light after a student wrote to the women’s commission on March 6, 2025. Following a preliminary inquiry, police had registered a case and later arrested the accused from Prayagraj after he had gone absconding.

HC directs J’khand PCCF to appear in person in PTR tiger conservation case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

The Jharkhand High Court on Thursday expressed annoyance at the Principal Chief Conservator of Forest (PCCF) for not filing an affidavit in a public interest litigation (PIL) pertaining to the conservation of tigers in the Palamau Tiger Reserve (PTR) in the State. The High Court ordered the PCCF to appear in person in the case on the next date of hearing.

A division bench of Chief Justice M S Sonak and Justice Rajesh Shankar was hearing a public interest litigation filed by one Vikas Mahto on the conservation of tigers in the PTR. The division bench observed that it seems that the PCCF has not gone through the orders of the High Court and did not take it seriously. The court ordered the PCCF to be present in person on the next date of hearing and address the court for not filing his affidavit. An affi-



davit was filed by a subordinate of the PCCF, which was turned down by the High Court. The court observed that certain information was required after recording the suggestions made by the amicus curiae in the case, which were to be provided by the PCCF.

But, instead of an affidavit in the personal capacity of the PCCF, an affidavit has been presented by a subordinate, which was not accepted by the court.

The Palamau Tiger Reserve, formed in 1974, has no record of the big cat numbers going up or steps being taken to increase their population, the court had observed earlier while hearing the petition.

उत्तर प्रदेश पावर ट्रांसमिशन कार्पोरेशन लिमिटेड
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जेम निविदा सूचना, दिनांक-26/03/2026
जेम निविदा संख्या एवं कार्य का सक्षिप्त विवरण
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समय 14:00 बजे तक। विस्तृत जानकारी एवं प्रश्न जेम पोर्टल पर उपलब्ध है अतःतर समस्त सूचनाये इसी वेबसाइट पर ही प्रदर्शित की जायेगी।
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“रफ़्त हित में बिजली बचाये”
पत्रांक: 498/विद्योन्मोदन पनकी (कां)/
टी-0-1 दिनांक: 25.03.2026



Editor's
TAKE

Peace on paper, War in motion

As the US-Israel-Iran war escalates, diplomacy is struggling to keep pace, with no end in sight as Tehran summarily rejects the US peace proposal

The war in West Asia has now been raging for more than three weeks, yet no side is willing to budge from its position. What was supposed to last a few days has stretched for almost a month, and Iran has defied all logic in retaliating against the joint US-Israel attack. With Iran mastering asymmetric warfare with drones and draining the resources of the US, combined with bleeding the oil market through its siege of the Strait of Hormuz, Washington is quietly contemplating a respectable retreat. Even Iran is in bad shape, with a large part of its war machinery destroyed, its top leaders killed, and high casualties among its citizens. Yet the war rages on. Wars have their queer logic; after a point they are fought just for the sake of fighting, as both sides believe they cannot retreat ignominiously and look defeated. But logistics do not run on emotions.

The US is spending a billion dollars a day and has suffered losses in terms of its reputation and war paraphernalia. This is perhaps the reason the US proposed a 15-point peace plan that has been rejected by Tehran, which has offered its own counter peace plan. The American plan-reportedly offering sanctions relief, nuclear cooperation, and de-escalation frameworks-reflects a classic carrot-and-stick approach. It seeks to cap Iran's nuclear ambitions, ensure maritime stability in the Strait of Hormuz, and restore a semblance of regional order. Iran's response, however, is not merely a rejection; it is a reframing of the conflict. Its five demands – ranging from guaranteed war reparations to international recognition of sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz – signal that Tehran sees itself not as a party to be restrained, but as one to be compensated and legitimised. Iran is now seeking reparations for the losses incurred, and that itself shows that Iran is not negotiating from a weak position but knows that its strikes in Israel have created panic. With Israel's Iron Dome weakened and its interceptors rendered ineffective against the Fattah-2 ballistic missiles, both Iran and Israel stand on the same ground; both are vulnerable to air attacks, whether ballistic missiles or fighter jets. This is where Iran's confidence comes from. Iran also knows that a choked Strait of Hormuz will bleed the world economy, and there is immense pressure on the US to end the war or at least ensure oil flows freely through the strait. The proposals must be seen in this context. The US proposal is rooted in containment; Iran's counter is rooted in recognition. Washington wants behavioural change; Tehran wants strategic acknowledgement. For Iran, the Strait of Hormuz is a lever that promises sovereignty and deterrence. Tehran's insistence on formal recognition of control over the strait is unlikely to be accepted internationally, making this a near-insurmountable sticking point in negotiations. No major power willingly sets a precedent of paying for military action it deems justified. This alone makes Iran's proposal less a negotiating document and more a declaration of position. Yet reports of backchannel diplomacy via Pakistan and the possibility of talks in Turkey suggest that neither side is entirely closed to dialogue. Meanwhile, the war rages on, deepening human suffering and compounding damage to the environment, the economy and peace.

India must put farmers first in the US deal

The US trade deal appears tilted towards American interests. With trade policy needing to prioritise national welfare, India faces a tightrope walk between global ambition and safeguarding its farmers and markets



SUBODH
KUMAR MEHTA

Modern India envisions its freedom as a victory not only of a nation but of foundational truths. Our founding fathers of the Constitution equated national interest with fairness. While conducting bilateral trade agreements, the fundamental principles should be national interest and the well-being of the people. The vision must be based on advantage for the masses and not merely on international goodwill.

The ongoing US-India Bilateral Trade Agreement is said to be mutually beneficial and aims to double bilateral trade to USD 500 billion by 2030, from the current USD 191 billion. Donald Trump announced an interim trade agreement with India on his social media platform, "Truth Social." However, the actual text of this trade agreement remains veiled in secrecy. Washington has unilaterally made announcements regarding the agreement. On the other hand, the Government of India has not categorically rejected these claims. Officials, during interactions with the Parliamentary Committee, have stated that India is working on finalising the interim agreement with the USA and will issue a joint statement in due course.

Meanwhile, the Supreme Court of the United States pronounced a judgment stating that it is Congress that has the power, and not the President, to impose tariffs "unbounded in scope, amount, and duration" on any product from any country. In light of this judgment, both countries have decided to postpone the interim bilateral trade meeting until further notice. However, following the Supreme Court judgment, President Donald Trump confirmed that there would be no change to the US-India trade deal.

The main apprehensions and contentions about the interim deal concern the procedure and path being followed to review and relax restrictions on agricultural imports at the behest of Washington. Capitol Hill seeks access for agricultural products such as maize, wheat, soybeans, pulses, almonds, dairy products and other commodities. The interim agreement indicates that India may accept commitments in sectors such as defence, clean energy, crude oil, LNG, ethanol and civil aviation. On the other hand, India wants the USA to reduce tariffs further so that Indian goods can gain better access to the American market. Moreover, India is hesitant to negotiate on agricultural products and maintains silence on this contentious issue.

If India opens its market to US agricultural products, it will have cascading effects on Indian farmers in particular and the domestic market in general. India is also cautious regarding subsidies,



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as the WTO has been pressurising India to reduce subsidies and restrict the Minimum Support Price system. India is further cautious about the dairy sector because the American animal husbandry system allows non-vegetarian feed for cattle, whereas Indian cattle are fed vegetarian feed. This difference may have cascading effects on cultural and religious sentiments.

Through the US-India Bilateral Trade Agreement, the USA seeks to utilise the Indian market as a dumping ground for genetically modified (GM) grains, which may ultimately aggravate farmers' distress. Indian farmers cannot compete with highly subsidised American farmers and powerful corporate lobbies. Hence, it is of utmost importance to protect the interests of Indian farmers. One of the important reasons for the USA to seal the deal is that India currently imports nearly 18 per cent of its agricultural products. Due to high subsidies provided to American farmers, their produce enjoys cost advantages. In contrast, Indian farmers receive comparatively minimal subsidies, resulting in higher production costs. Thus, Indian farmers may face severe distress if India agrees to the proposed terms. US and Indian farmers do not operate on the same platform; therefore, any policy must be framed after analysing this structural difference. The WTO must also adopt a more just approach, as the Agriculture Agreement of 1995 is widely perceived as inequitable due to differences in farm inputs and government subsidies between India and the USA. The main bone of contention in the tariff tussle between India and the USA appears to be shifting towards the energy and agriculture sectors. This may put pressure on jewellery, textiles, leather and engineering goods, which employ millions of citizens. Moreover, as per Executive Order 14257 of the USA, there is a complete ban on certain Indian food items entering the US market. To resolve this, a monitoring committee may be constituted by the USA. At this juncture, the USA may reduce tariffs further if

India agrees to open its agricultural market, as the USA is eager to sell soybean, maize and corn for ethanol production. However, such imports may adversely affect Indian producers. India already has surplus stocks of animal feed. Ethanol producers argue that such imports would disrupt the domestic ethanol supply chain because India's production capacity could exceed consumption levels.

Five major aspects of the bilateral trade agreement merit attention. First, while India may not formally open its agricultural sector, the interim agreement suggests that the USA may derive significant benefits, particularly through

increased agricultural exports to India and improved prices for American farmers. Second, India does not permit genetically modified food products such as maize, soybean and certain dry fruits

due to concerns about potential impacts on human health. Allowing imports of GM animal feed products must be assessed in terms of long-term toxicity, allergies, inter-generational effects and broader public health concerns. Third, the issue of dairy products derived from cattle fed non-vegetarian feed may disturb cultural and religious sensitivities in India. Fourth, the ramifications of this deal may distort India's approach to pursuing national interest in an era of multi-lateralism and a multipolar world. Fifth, the disparity in farm subsidies between the USA and India remains significant, and the WTO Agreement of the Uruguay Round (1995) is often viewed as favouring developed countries like the USA.

Both nations must balance domestic economic concerns, commercial interests and cultural sensitivities. At present, bilateral negotiations appear tilted towards US farm products and bio-fuels, without sufficient clarity on improved market access for Indian exports. The Government of India must exercise extreme caution before granting any concessions on genetically modified products or opening the agricultural sector to external pressures.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

War destroys childhood long before it ends



ASHA IYER
KUMAR

2ND OPINION

One of the earliest lessons I learnt as a student of journalism is that not every piece of news that we read has the same impact on our nervous system. What decides the shock value of an event – no matter how tragic or distressing – is its proximity to our lives. That which transpires closer home will hurt us more than that which happens in a distant territory.

Events, no matter how dastardly, that happen in lands we have only seen on the atlas remain just bad news which we gloss over with a click of tongue to express disapproval and a sigh of relief that we are far removed from those ugly realities. That simple theory of proximity returned to me recently as I was getting worn to the bones with the goings-on in the region that I live in – the middle east.

For those who are bearing the direct brunt of the lunacy currently governing the world, the odds of waking up to a new day has become a matter of luck. For us here, close to the epicentre, the threat now isn't as immediate; it is a simmering uncertainty about how life would pan out in the weeks and months ahead; of not knowing if the semblance of normalcy is for real or if time has reserved some cruel surprises for us. With each day that passes without a settlement, the questions looms – will we get through this unscathed? The rest of the world is only getting mild feelers about the inconveniences the situation might cause if it spirals or naggingly drags out.

And this is only the big picture of a crisis that has many facets. In the midst of death, destruction and displacement that wars and armed conflicts cause, there is one segment of the population – so vulnerable and hidden from the glare – that not many have spared a serious thought to. It is almost as if their existence doesn't even deserve consideration on the negotiation tables. Children.

Every time there is an armed conflict anywhere in the world, the images of children paying the price in the currency of lives, limbs, family, education, food and the right to dream about a safe future fill me with uncontainable grief. These children are incapable of political sabre-rattling and rhetoric. They have no defences of their own.

All they have is a bleak future and experiences that will leave them scarred for the rest of their lives if they survive the conflict they do not even understand. When adults – armed to the teeth and often bereft of logic and sensibility – fight over land, ideology, power or revenge, they are not merely disrupting world orders; they are interrupting fledgling futures, dismantling cradles and thwarting tender dreams and desires. In many cases, children are even drawn into war zones as child soldiers, with no freedom to choose their futures. Their inability to resist makes them hapless victims of a desensitised adult world.

This piece is not about geopolitical dynamics or power equations. It is about empathy and emotions, and about what the future holds for the young ones caught up in these gruelling times. We have an obligation towards them.

Filling fear in their eyes and hunger in their stomachs is cruelty, and no adult can be absolved of this crime. As one young mother told me, "I am not scared for myself. I am deeply worried for my children and praying for their safety." That prayer lives in every mother's heart wherever unrest rules – often hushed by bombs and bullets, yet still waiting to be answered.

The writer is a Dubai-based author, columnist, independent journalist and children's writing coach

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Global trade faces risk

There are concerns over global energy supplies and maritime trade, which have intensified as Iran signalled it could expand its strategic response in the Middle East by targeting another sea route, the Bab el-Mandeb Strait. Tehran may consider opening a new front in the narrow passage if its territory or offshore islands come under attack. The warning comes amid escalating tensions in the region and has triggered alarm among global policymakers and markets.

The development follows heightened focus on the Strait of Hormuz, through which roughly a fifth of the world's oil and gas flows. Iran is reported to have tightened control over this critical route, raising fears of broader disruption to global energy supplies. The Bab el-Mandeb Strait, whose name translates to "gate of tears", connects the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden and the Arabian Sea. Any disruption in this corridor would force vessels to reroute around Africa via the Cape of Good Hope, significantly extending transit times and sharply increasing shipping costs. If both the Strait of Hormuz and the Bab el-Mandeb were affected simultaneously, a large share of global oil and gas flows could face disruption, potentially triggering volatility in energy markets and driving up prices worldwide.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

What we eat shapes brain health

What we eat in our 40s may decisively shape how our brain functions in our 60s and beyond. A recent study suggests that fewer than one in ten people manage to reach the age of 70 free from major disease while maintaining good physical, cognitive and mental health. The study indicates that a healthy diet in midlife significantly increases the chances of healthy ageing.

Researchers found that higher intake of fruits, vegetables, whole grains, nuts, legumes, unsaturated fats and low-fat dairy was associated with better ageing outcomes.

In contrast, diets high in processed foods, trans fats, sodium, red meat and processed meat were linked to poorer health outcomes and increased cognitive decline.

This is not merely a lifestyle suggestion but a public health warning. In India, preventive healthcare remains largely focused on physical illness, while brain health receives little attention. There is limited public awareness that everyday dietary choices can influence long-term cognitive health.

Healthy ageing begins in midlife, not old age. Public awareness on nutrition and brain health must therefore become a national priority.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

Peace talks without progress

The recent rejection of a 15-point ceasefire proposal by Iran shows how wide the gap remains between the two sides.

The US proposal demands nuclear dismantlement, missile restrictions and withdrawal from proxy activities, while Iran's counter-demands include security guarantees, financial compensation and recognition of sovereignty over the Strait of Hormuz.

These are not negotiating positions moving towards compromise; they reflect fundamentally different expectations of what a settlement should achieve. One side wants verifiable disarmament, while the other seeks guarantees against future military action and strategic recognition. Until this gap is realistically acknowledged, diplomatic proposals are unlikely to succeed.

Meanwhile, continued conflict is causing human suffering, economic disruption and instability in global energy markets. Prolonged conflict benefits no one and increases risks for global trade and security.

Diplomacy cannot succeed unless both sides move from maximalist positions to practical compromise. Peace agreements are built not on absolute victories but on mutual concessions and realistic expectations.

ABBHARNA BARATHI | CHENNAI

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE



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1971 GENOCIDE MUST NOT BE FORGOTTEN OR DENIED

This refers to "Bangladesh PM calls 1971 massacre a genocide" (March 26). The massacre of March 25, 1971, carried out under Pakistan's "Operation Searchlight", remains one of the darkest chapters in Bangladesh's history. Thousands were killed in Dhaka in a single night, and over the nine-month Liberation War, millions perished while countless women were subjected to horrific atrocities. Given this history, Bangladesh has every reason to demand an official apology and compensation from Pakistan for the atrocities and damages caused. Such a stance would not only provide justice to the victims but also strengthen Bangladesh's moral and political standing globally. Without accountability, relations with Pakistan cannot be considered genuine or respectful. Taking a

firm position until Pakistan recognises its crimes may be necessary to ensure that the events of 1971 are neither forgotten nor trivialised.

At the same time, Bangladesh must value its friendship with India, which played a decisive role in its liberation. India's support during the war was instrumental in the creation of Bangladesh, and maintaining strong ties ensures regional stability and cooperation. Friendly relations are important not only because of shared history but also for future cooperation in trade, energy, security and cultural exchange. Bangladesh may therefore adopt a dual approach - firmly seeking justice from Pakistan while strengthening its partnership with India.

O PRASADA RAO | HYDERABAD

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

The paradox of Iran’s enduring defiance

The combined might of the United States and Israel has pulverised Iran's military infrastructure, dominated its skies, and struck deep into its strategic heartlands with unprecedented precision. Yet beneath this overwhelming show of force lies a far more complex reality: Iran is neither paralysed nor surrendering

FIRST Column



JUGGI BHASIN

On the face of it, Israel and the United States have knocked the stuffing out of Iran. Iran's military, nuclear, missile and even governmental infrastructure has been shredded with precision bombing. America and Israel rule the skies over Iran and bomb it at will. And yet, mysteriously, Iran manages to fire a daily barrage of missiles and rockets on US assets in the GCC countries. And not only that, Iran has closed the Strait of Hormuz and controls it. They allow through vessels of their choice, which means that they have disrupted 20 per cent of both world oil and LNG traffic. But wait, there is more. Once in a while, they loosen off a missile headed towards an apartment complex in Dubai or Bahrain just to keep all these countries on edge.

Iran might be getting decimated, but it is not collapsing anytime soon. That reality has by now sunk in both Israel and America. The headline theological regime of the Khameneis stays firmly in place. The composed and urbane-looking Foreign Minister of Iran, Abbas Araghchi, makes daily appearances on television, speaking a surprising language of controlled defiance but reasonableness. And to top it all, the President of Iran, Masoud Pezeshkian, openly marched on the annual Quds Day along with thousands of others, challenging Israel and the US to do their worst.

So, what is the real story here? What is Iran signalling to America and the rest of the world? Before we dive into that question, let us get a snapshot of the American position. President Trump daily extols the brilliance of the American air campaign. Yes, he is correct. The Americans have unleashed a kind of precision bombing that the world has never known or seen before. Targets in Tehran, Isfahan, Shiraz and the oil export facility on Kharg Island have been struck with impunity, some of them repeatedly. And yet President Trump's face is creased with more worry lines than Pezeshkian's. Petrol prices are rising sharply in America, and only a core MAGA voter base, roughly 41 per cent, supports the President's war efforts. The rest of the country is either indifferent to this war or openly opposed to it. Republican prospects in the midterm elections in November appear to be dimming with each passing day.



IRAN KNOWS IT WILL TAKE YEARS TO REBUILD FROM THE DEVASTATION IT HAS SUFFERED. NO MORE NUCLEAR PLANS OR EVEN STATE OF THE ART MISSILE DEVELOPMENT

The writer is a veteran television journalist, author and geopolitical commentator. He is known for his views on global power shifts, intelligence history, India's national security architecture and contemporary geopolitical flashpoints

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 The Pioneer

What explains all this? Almost three weeks into the war, what is really going on? It now appears that the architects who devised the world's most sophisticated and deadly air campaign allowed themselves to be beguiled into the belief that a relentless clobbering from the air would force Iran to its knees and it would quickly capitulate. They forgot a basic fact. Iran is half the size of India, much of it mountainous, and its population density is almost one third that of the United States.

Air campaigns can at best degrade the enemy, but they cannot vanquish it. You need boots on the ground to finish the job. If President Trump is thinking of that option, then surely his advisers would have briefed him about a similar initiative in 1980 which ended in tragedy for America and put the Jimmy Carter presidency on notice. Then the objective was a daredevil rescue mission to free 53 American hostages held in Tehran. A helicopter and a transport plane collided in that mission, and eight US servicemen were killed. The mission failed, and Jimmy Carter's presidency went into terminal decline after that.

So the pertinent question is: despite Iran being bombed to the Stone Age, how is it that they are still calling the shots?

The answer to this vexed question is simple. You can start a war, but you must know when and how to end it.

Take India's example in matters of warfare. We started Operation Sindoor at a time and place of our choosing. We ended it in the manner of our choosing. We were crystal clear about our objectives when we went in for that short, intense conflict. We wanted to punish the planners and perpetrators of the Pahalgam massacre. We

wanted to degrade Pakistan's air power assets. We did both.

Remember, even at that time there were many voices in India that wanted us to liberate PoK (Pakistan-occupied Kashmir) and teach Pakistan a lesson for eternity. But we knew it was time to end the war. Continuation of the conflict could have left us in a war quagmire.

The concept of a short, sharp war unfortunately is lost on America. They tend to get bogged down in conflict. It happened in Vietnam from 1955 to 1975, then it occurred in Iraq from 2003 to 2011. It happened again in Afghanistan in 2001 and lasted a good twenty years till 2021. And now it could be happening again in Iran in 2026.

Their recent action in Venezuela was not a war. It was more of a targeted Special Forces strike with clear objectives in sight. And that is why it was supremely successful. It is entirely possible that the Iranians knew what was coming their way and were well prepared to deal with it. I do not think the Iranians were caught napping in the pre-war talks with the Americans. They knew Israel and America would attack them at some point in time. They knew they would soon lose control of their skies and that their major military and infrastructure targets out in the open would be targeted. The Americans and Israel, hunting in pairs, would go after their missile launchers and nuclear sites.

I believe they factored in that loss. Think about it. If the Americans evacuated their air bases in the GCC countries before Iranian drones hit them, would it not stand to reason that the Iranians also moved their missile launchers underground? The under-

ground would have a special connotation for Iran. Their missiles, drones and launchers would have been moved to underground locations. After all, it was Iran that earlier supplied basic technology to Hamas to create tunnels in Gaza when the Israelis came hunting. Why would Iran not have a more sophisticated underground defence system installed for itself?

Probably they created a highly mobile system that enables them to move launchers from place to place to escape detection. That explains their continuous attacks on GCC countries' infrastructure.

Even then, the shock and awe of the initial bombing run by American and Israeli forces stunned the Iranians. The successful assassination of the Ayatollah seared the Iranian body politic. Despite all their preparations, the Iranians were dazed and numbed. That was the best opportunity for the US to realise its objective of regime change. The Iranians were reeling. The Ayatollah's death galvanised protesters in Iran who hated the spiritual leader. If America had curtailed its bombing plans and allowed the indigenous protest movement to grow and topple the regime, then a different story might have unfolded. The momentum was with America. But Israel had other ideas. Regime change was only an initial step for them. They really wanted to dismember Iran into pieces so it would never pose a threat to them again.

For reasons unknown, America went along with this thinking. The bombing runs were intensified, and a girls' school was bombed, for which no one has claimed responsibility. A turning point was reached; the old dynamics of the Middle East set in. It soon became a David versus Goliath situation. The tyrannical Iranian regime started to gain worldwide sympathy. Even Iranian protesters who had celebrated the Ayatollah's death on the first day withdrew. Since then, they have preferred to lay low and keep quiet, not so much out of fear of intimidation from the Iranian authorities but because they could not bear to see their country torn apart.

In a strange way, the continuous American action on Iran has stabilised a tottering, unpopular regime. The IRGC and the remaining Iranian establishment quickly recovered from the initial shock and awe phase and resorted to asymmetric warfare. History is replete with examples of how proponents of asymmetric warfare eventually win. In the sixties and seventies, the Americans bombed

every nook and corner of Vietnam. Even then, their air power was the most formidable in history. Despite all that and the use of deadly chemicals like Agent Orange, the Vietnamese, with barely enough to eat, sporting simple sandals and carrying the ubiquitous AK-47, eventually prevailed and won.

The Iranians are doing something similar. They are waging asymmetric warfare from underground locations. They know perfectly well that it does not require a navy to close the Strait of Hormuz. IRGC fighters equipped with assault rifles, rocket launchers and underwater drones could do that.

There are no easy options left for anyone in this war. If America pulls out now, the Iranians will fill the vacuum and terrorise the GCC states even more. They are already controlling the oil flow of GCC countries through the Strait of Hormuz. If America prolongs the war, fuel prices will rise further in the US, stagflation could set in, and more body bags would be shipped home. The US President might then as well kiss the midterm elections goodbye.

Iran knows it will take years to rebuild from the devastation it has suffered. No more nuclear plans or state-of-the-art missile development for now. But it will carry on with asymmetric warfare, probably using it against GCC countries to pressure them and force them to help rebuild Iran in the future.

Besides other things, the bombing of Iran has laid to rest fond memories of our ex-non-aligned warriors in India and other parts of the globe. BRICS — the new avatar of the old Non-Aligned Movement — is signalling that it is every country for itself, and the global south can unite but only in television debates. India knows all this and, disregarding the white noise of opposition politicians, is striking deals with Iran separately to secure its energy security through the Strait of Hormuz. An amazing footnote in this bloody war is the commendation India has received from all three combatants in this war — America, Israel and even Iran. They all call India "a trusted partner". Surely, we must be doing something right to deserve this. But the future is bleak. As investors worry about the future of GCC countries, their economies could tank, Indian workers could be laid off in the Gulf, and remittances from our workers could dry up.

Look at it any which way. It is a lose-lose scenario all the way. The low moan of the foghorn of loss and defeat is heard all the time. The sweet, resonating bell of victory has not been heard even once.

Lotus: The forgotten soul of India’s cultural imagination



RAGHVENDRA SINGH

To most of us in the Indian subcontinent, especially the younger generation, the Lotus as a flower occupies no special significance. It is appreciated as just another beautiful specimen of flora. A uniform ignorance exists about the fact that the Lotus (Kamal) is intricately connected not only with the Bharatiya, but many other cultural ethos across time and space. This flower is deeply embedded in India's historical psyche. Let us take the case of Bharatiya literature and art (paintings and sculpture), which denote our culture. Literature and art serve as a mirror of the glory of our nation. Through them, it is possible to understand our past. What is left unexplained in one realm is made clear through the other, for literature and art act as real mirrors, reflecting images that no longer exist. The ancient poet Dandin, in his famous work Kavya Rasa, talks of Bharat's historicity quite succinctly:

“The image of fame of early kings reflected in the mirror of literature does not disappear, even now, even in their absence.”

For an appropriate understanding of one, the other acts as a supplement. A ready example that comes to mind is that of Kamal: the Padmanabha aspect of Vishnu, the Lotus aspect as a seat (Kamalaasan), Charankamal, Lotus motifs and many such examples. Ajanta and Bagh Caves are regular art galleries (chitrashalas). We learn of Bharat's history from both Bharat's ancient literature and art.

Let me again quote from Dandin's Dasakumarcharita:

“May the foot of Trivikrama render you good, the stalk of the Lotus residence of Brahma.”

Remarkably, Bharatiya Sahyaya is very much a living tradition wherein symbolism plays a great role. Aspects of nature contribute greatly to its rich tradition. As an emblem, the Lotus plays a key role in Bharatiya iconography. The Lotus' connection with Bharatiya culture is inextricable. Ancient texts contain repeated references to the Lotus, linking it to Hindu philosophy. The Rig Veda, Atharva Veda, Chandogya Upanishad and Puranas are replete with the metaphor of the Lotus. The Lotus has a long association with Brahma, Vishnu, Surya, Saraswati and Lakshmi. The importance and value of the Lotus can be discerned in temples across the globe. What is so important about the allegory of the Lotus that it enjoys such an exalted status in Bharatiya ethos? Why is this resplendent aquatic flower so deeply entrenched in Bharat's cultural fabric?

The Lotus has been revered for its purity and

spiritual significance in Bharat since ancient times. In the realm of art, the Lotus holds an esteemed place. The exquisite carvings of Lotus motifs have embellished the walls, pillars and ceilings of iconic temples for centuries. The recurring presence of Lotus designs in Bharat's architectural marvels signifies great aesthetic finesse and spiritual sanctity. The delicate beauty of the flower has made it a popular motif in Bharatiya ancient paintings. It also has a special place in Bharatiya literature, where it figuratively represents elegance, purity and love.

Several Lotus motifs and themes abound in Bharatiya sculpture and paintings. The Lotus, in all its forms, has been used in medallion patterns in early Bharatiya stupas like Bharhut. The Amravati and Bharhut Lotus medallions are incomparable for their sheer grace and variety. Bharhut and Amravati display intricate depictions of Lotus blossoms in their sculptures and reliefs. These sites date back millennia.

In Ajanta, the motif of the Lotus has been utilised in all possible ways, sometimes running the whole length of panels in a meandering creeper fashion, as buds, as flowers in bloom, in the most soothing ways. Ajanta Caves, as we know, are a great human experience, the only remaining evidence of styles of paintings that developed in Bharat and travelled with Buddhism to the Himalayan region and thence across Central Asia, China, Japan and Korea. They carried with them the motifs of the Lotus to all these countries. The caves of the earlier phase date from the 2nd century BCE. One feels a sense of awe looking at the remnants of these paintings.

The Lotus occurs as a central ceiling panel in the mandapams of temples. The Lotus, like the mandala, has a centre point, the source of creation, that expands outwards. In Lotus medallions, this is depicted through concentric circles having a distinct centre, the wellspring of life. The concentric rings are suggestive of fluidity and life's cyclical nature. The Lotus lies at the heart of the creation story in Bharatiya ethos. While Lord Vishnu lay asleep on his serpent bed, Adishesha, a Lotus emerged from his navel with Lord Brahma sitting on it. Even Lakshmi, the goddess of prosperity, is believed to have emerged from the Lotus.

There is practically no Bharatiya deity that is not shown holding or sitting on the Lotus seat. The Lotus represents eternity. The imagery of the Lotus in ancient Bharatiya sculpture is a testament to its enduring significance in guiding individuals towards higher consciousness.

The Chola bronzes, exemplifying exquisite craftsmanship, often feature deities standing or seated on Lotus pedestals. These bronze sculptures, intricately detailed with Lotus motifs that represent divine grace and purity, reflect the profound symbolism associated with the Lotus in Hindu mythology.

Bharatiya miniature paintings showcase the Lotus in various forms, capturing its grace and elegance. These delicate artworks, from the Mughal to Rajput schools, portray gods, goddesses and royal figures adorned with garlands of Lotus flowers, underscoring its association with beauty, grace and divinity. Sanskrit literature, especially the works of Kalidasa, often weaves the imagery of the Kamal into poetic verses, elucidating its significance as a metaphor for beauty and the blossoming of love and emotions. The Kamal, with its ability to emerge unblemished from muddy waters, serves as a powerful metaphor for spiritual enlightenment, resilience and triumph over adversities in Kalidasa's verses.

The Kamal, according to its nature, rises with the sun and drops when the sun sets, alluding to regeneration and rebirth — the cycle of life and death. The water- and dirt-repellent structure of its waxy petals symbolises purity. The Kamal is also an emblem of Saraswati and Lakshmi.

Kamal signifies purity in spirit, for it grows in murky water and yet produces clean and beautiful petals. The rolling down of water from the Kamal petal denotes freedom. It is also a symbol of self-generation or "svayambhu" in Sanskrit. Kamal forms the throne of Lord Buddha.

The individual's mind is compared to the Kamal, which has to go through its initial stages of development in murky water before it establishes itself as a beautiful flower. An individual's evolution goes through the same stages on its path to knowledge. The opening of each petal is the progressive unfolding of human consciousness. The chakra system, or the energy centres within the human being, is compared and associated with the varied number of petals of the Kamal.

The following verse from the Bhagavad Gita encapsulates the non-attachment and aloofness inherent in the Sanatan religion: “One who performs his duty without attachment, surrendering the results unto the Supreme Lord, is unaffected by sinful action, as the Lotus leaf is untouched by water.” Kamal in Bharatiya culture transcends mere aesthetics. It embodies a far deeper meaning. In terms of spiritual symbolism and philosophical expression, it is omnipresent. Sadly, not many of us realise it. There are myriad other motifs in Bharat's ancient paintings and sculptures whose understanding remains incomplete until the lens of concurrent literature is applied. There is a need for Bharat and the world to appreciate this praxis. It was no mere coincidence that Kamal was consecrated as part of the G20 logo when Bharat organised this global event in September 2023. It is no mere coincidence either that Kamal is Bharat's national flower, manifesting a pro-planet vision.

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Dowry deaths expose India’s gender crisis



SWAPNA MAJUMDAR

The bitter truth that many women are not safe even in their homes was underscored once again by the spate of dowry-related deaths reported in the last three months across India. On March 17, 2026, a nurse in Gurgaon was reportedly poisoned by her radiologist husband just four months after their love marriage. A month earlier, in February, a woman in Aligarh died after a hot iron was pressed against parts of her body. Her family claimed that she had been regularly assaulted for dowry. In January this year, a woman living in Pilibhit, UP, was burned alive allegedly after she and her family were not able to pay dowry. Had they registered a complaint with the police, would they have been alive?

Maybe, and then maybe not. The most recent statistics reveal that the majority of crimes against women recorded by the National Crime Records Bureau in 2023 were of cruelty by the husband or his relatives (31.4%). Domestic violence accounts for more than 30% of all crimes against women, with 65% of Indian men believing women should tolerate violence in order to keep the family together, and that women sometimes deserve to be beaten.

So why don't women seek help from the police? According to the 2025 National Annual Report and Index on Women's Safety (NARI) by the National Commission for Women, two-thirds of harassment incidents go unreported as social stigma and distrust of the police keep many survivors from seeking help. The report found that 75% of women distrust the police and legal redressal systems, leading to only one in three victims filing a formal complaint. In other words, for every one woman who reports violence or harassment, two others stay silent due to fear, shame or lack of faith in the system.

But when women do find the courage to file First Information Reports (FIRs), they face delays and barriers. Law enforcement officers are often either dismissive of women's concerns or prefer "settling" matters through counselling, particularly in domestic violence cases. They often lack the capacity to effectively support women, or sometimes become perpetrators of violence against women.

When a study from the four largest cities in Madhya Pradesh found that only one per cent of women experiencing violence had reported it to the police, and that women made up



a small share of the Indian police force at seven per cent, the MP Police Department decided to do something about it. They teamed up with J-PAL South Asia to study how they could improve access for women in distress.

A women's help desk model within police stations was developed in partnership with the Madhya Pradesh Police Research and Training Department in 180 police stations. Evaluation after two years of this model showed that police stations with dedicated women's help desks were more likely to register cases of crimes against women and domestic violence, particularly when help desks were run by women officers. Based on these findings, the MP Police Department scaled up the help desks to 950 police stations across the state.

If this intervention is adapted by other states, it may save the lives of women. Perhaps then women will feel safe enough to file complaints. The worrying fact is that patriarchy is so deeply entrenched that men can kill their wives for petty reasons, like the man from Odisha who bludgeoned his wife to death for not cooking rice with the curry she served him, or the husband from Maharashtra who killed his wife because the meal served was deemed too salty for his taste.

India slipped from 129th position to 131st out of 148 countries in the 2025 Global Gender Gap Report. With an estimated one in three women reporting domestic and sexual violence over their lifetime, whatever progress has been made in women's empowerment has been undermined by the high rates of gender-based violence. How many more women have to die before gender equality becomes a reality?

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BLASÉ CAPITAL

ALL THAT GAS



A week ago, the largest terminal for liquefied natural gas (LNG) in the world, Qatar's Ras Laffan, was brutally attacked by Iranian missiles and drones. Fires raged across the massive complex, which covers nearly 300 sq km, or the size of a large city, according to reports. Within hours, millions of dollars' worth of investments vanished in thick and huge puffs of smoke and flames. The terminal accounted for a fifth of LNG's global supplies, and nearly 17 per cent of the nation's gas infrastructure. Qatar declared force majeure, or an inability to supply the contracted gas to buyers due to factors beyond its control.

Saad Sherida al-Kaabi, CEO, QatarEnergy, which owns the terminal, was categorical when he claimed that global supplies may be impacted "for up to five years." It may take years to restore the terminal, and get it back to the original operational strength. The problem, according to experts, is that LNG is a different container than a barrel of crude oil. It is a complex structure, which is expensive to build, and as expensive to maintain, and repair. Ras Laffan involved investments of tens of billions of dollars. Hence, the technology and money needed to take care of the war-related damages may take years.

In addition, there is another complexity. The gas fields in Qatar and Iran are linked through an underground system, and are part of the "same massive geological structure." Together, they form the world's largest natural gas reserves, which are separated by territorial borders. Hence, more attacks on Iran's energy facilities, and oil and gas reserves, may further impact future supplies from Qatar. If the US president, Donald Trump, sticks to his original threat to blow up the entire gas field in Iran, there are repercussions. But he has backtracked a bit, although his 15-point peace plan was rejected by Iran.

Possibly, the most affected consumer nations of Qatar's LNG are in Asia, and include India, China, South Korea, and Pakistan. There are a few European nations that depend on it, and include Italy, Poland, and Belgium. If Ras Laffan stays inactive, or out of the global supplies for years, these nations will feel the pinch years after the war is over. They will need to access additional supplies of crude oil, which is in short supply due to the siege in the Strait of Hormuz, but can be restored more quickly once peace reigns. Russian, American, even Venezuelan oil may become crucial, even as the Gulf hikes post-war supplies.

In the interim period, coal may emerge as the dark horse, the diamond among the energy sources. As gas supplies falter, the premium on it increases, and "some nations will probably go back to using coal. This may especially be the case with India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, and a few other Asian countries that are very sensitive to high fuel prices." India's annual coal production crossed a billion tonnes for the second consecutive year, and policy-makers have urged the state-owned near-monopolist to look for ways to further increase supplies.

"Some European countries may even see coal as a cheaper option. Following the events in the Gulf, this 'spark spread' (the profit margin from gas-fired electricity) has fallen, narrowing the gap in Europe with the 'dark spread' (profit from power using coal)," explains a media report. There are talks of reopening closed-down coal-based plants, both in Europe and America. The coal-related positives will play out in the same manner with alternative fossil fuels like shale gas, and shale light oil, which are available in abundance in the US.

For economic and business reasons, the price hikes in the case of gas are more significant than those in coal in the recent past. Gas prices, according to some estimates, have more than doubled. In comparison, coal prices are up, "but not as much." Of course, this will imply pushing the entire 'green' narrative into the background, at least temporarily. Similar arguments cropped up in the aftermath of the Russia-Ukraine war, when Europe faced a gas supply crisis from Russia. Then too, there was talk of reopening coal-based units, and enhance the use of coal.

Clearly, consumer nations will need to adopt a flexible attitude towards energy security, and energy sources. Long-term strategies related to green energy, and Climate Change, may take a back seat, as the policy-makers grapple with immediate concerns related to shortages. In India, even as the policy-makers claim that there is no shortage of fuel and liquefied petroleum gas (LPG), rules were changed to increase the period for buying a new gas cylinder from three weeks to five weeks. Apart from restrictions on commercial users, such changes enhance the panic situation, and create fears that push consumers to hoard.

According to a media report, "Unlike oil, the LNG shortage has turned from a logistical problem, the closure of Strait of Hormuz, into a structural one. The damage to the Qatari production facility may take several years to repair. This means that gas prices... are likely to remain elevated for some time." Gas-related economic and business pains will continue despite the 'coal' pills. Energy supply chains may forever undergo changes, like logistics did after the pandemic.

The Pioneer

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BUSINESS10

This Act is more than just an act

Intentions and ideology are married under new corporate laws

It is not a secret that the proposed changes to the Companies Act, which were referred to a joint parliamentary committee, will prove to be huge steps in 'ease of doing business.' Corporate leaders, and board directors will be relieved as many actions are likely to be decriminalised. However, opposition politicians claim that they will undermine the powers of the law-makers, and hand over the responsibilities to the executive. Lawyers make a distinction between lapses that are deemed more severe than others. Despite the good intentions, there are indications that ideology has crept in the new laws.

For example, some of the acts of the corporate boards, which have a fiduciary and crucial role to play to protect the rights of the shareholders, will move from the criminal arena to civil one. Fines and penalties are lower than the earlier laws. Thus, some corporate lawyers feel that the so-called "bedrock of corporate governance," or the actions and decisions of the corporate leaders and directors may not be questioned as rigorously as they need to be. Minor, or lower, fines may make them complacent, and compliance may take a hit.

This is crucial in the context of the recent decision by Atanu Chakraborty, who recently and shockingly resigned as the non-executive chairman of HDFC Bank for reasons related to "my values and ethics." The stock bumped down by 10 per cent in four straight sessions before it perked up again. The issue apparently related to the mis-selling of a certain kind of bonds by the bank's Dubai office. The bonds, which are structurally complex, and sold to sophisticated investors, were purchased by the retail clients. Dubai's financial authority banned the operations in September 2025.

Days after the resignation, Sebi chairman,

Tuhin Kanta Pandey, put the insidious incident in perspective. He reminded the corporate world that independent directors like Chakraborty need to protect the rights of the minority shareholders, and must act "responsibly." Hence, "No one is expected to make insinuations without proper evidence and recordings," the Sebi head added. He said that the market regulator would thoroughly investigate the aspects of the matter. There was a system to deal with the concerns of the independent directors. In effect, responsibility implies responsibility within the confines of the law.

Now, consider how the defaults related to holding an annual general meeting (AGM) will be treated under the new corporate laws. At present, the fine is ₹1,00,000 plus a continuing one of ₹15,000 a day. The new law states that this will remain intact, but the total will be capped at ₹2,00,000 if an AGM is not held. The open-ended liability, which depends on the time-period of the offence, will turn into a closed one. If an AGM is not held for 12 months, the payment will be ₹2,00,000, and not ₹1,00,000, plus ₹15,000 x 365, or ₹55,75,000.

One can look at the differences in the penalties for company-related legal issues, and welfare-related stakeholders ones. A breach in the directors' responsibility statement, which is mandatory and relates to the affirmation that the directors kept proper records, and maintained accounting standards, will attract a fine of ₹3,00,000. An inability to spend the mandatory amount on corporate social responsibility (CSR) can attract an amount of up to ₹1,00,00,000. Thus, the first is seen as a technical oversight, and the latter as something that affects public interest, especially those of the poor and local communities.

Over the past few years, CSR has emerged as a controversial issue. Businesses complain that they are forced to invest in causes that they are not comfortable with. Management experts contend that CSR should focus on research and innovation, rather than welfare. Observers imply that the CSR money is either wasted, as family members of the promoters run the foundations, or even siphoned off to line the pockets of promoters-linked individuals. The Government, by insisting on high fines, feels it is a necessity in public interest.

Of course, the high penalty forms a part of other measures that seek to ease the difficulties in CSR spending. According to a media report, the net profit threshold for CSR will be doubled to ₹10 crore, and the time to transfer the unspent funds will be hiked by three times to 90 days. "The central government may exempt certain classes of companies from CSR obligations," states the report. In comparison, it is just the maximum penalty that rises to ₹1,00,00,000. Some may contend that this is a case of good intentions mixed with ideology.

What is crucial is that there is a feeling that a failure to spend the mandatory CSR can be technical, and individual oversight, which can be corrected without major consequences. It may be related to clearances-related timing, i.e., a specific project or some projects were delayed due to external reasons, or internal procedures. In many cases, subsidiaries need to seek permissions from the parent firms. It can be linked to issues related with completion of the projects, which were delayed because of factors that were not in control. Heavy fines for such technicalities, compared to directors' fiduciary duties, seem odd.

In the recent past, public interest, and protecting the rights of the common masses has reflected in legislation. The prime example is the ban on real-money online gaming, which was completely unexpected by the industry. Once the Supreme Court rulings made distinctions between games of chance and skill, and the Government imposed high taxes on online gaming, the businesses expected tighter rules. Instead, there was a ban because of the sufferings of the people, who lost their savings, or wasted emergency funds required for healthcare. Welfare of the people trumped the cause of the industry and businesses.

According to a media report, lawyers feel that the striking gap in the new proposed corporate laws relate to asset stripping by promoters, directors, senior management, and others. One of the prominent ways to do this is to shift the assets to other linked or non-linked entities without the permission of the shareholders of the company that originally held them. Since there is no specific penalty for such acts, the "general provision applies, levying a penalty of ₹10,000." Over the years, asset-stripping has returned as major corporate fraud.

Thus, on an overall basis there is a definite case for the ease of doing business, and make the lives of the directors easier. At the same, there are some issues that the Government will impose.

Yet again, this March, unexpected rainfall affected crops across large swathes of the country. Met experts link the unseasonal downpour, including hailstorms and snow in some areas, to increased western disturbances. Ripe rabi crops such as wheat and mustard become highly vulnerable due to such events. Current on-field damage assessments indicate a loss of harvest of 15-25 per cent in areas that faced wind and hail affects, and 5-10 per cent higher post-harvest fungal losses in cereals that are under the wet conditions.

Jayanta Bhattacharya
Senior Journalist

As usual, the farmers' plight has political connotations. The Government swung into immediate action, but stressed that its focus extended beyond production to the scientific assessment of damages, proper settlement of insurance claims, and timely assistance to the farmers. Union agriculture minister, Shivraj Singh Chouhan, chaired a high-level, comprehensive meeting to review the conditions of the agriculture sector. He stressed the immediate needs of farmers, which included the processing of the insurance claims, and functioning of relief mechanisms. "If farmers have suffered losses, their insurance claims should be prepared properly and scientifically so that we can support our farmer brothers and sisters," said Chouhan.

For the farmers' unions, such language smacks of a propensity to delay immediate actions to save the growers, and provide inadequate compensations. "We cannot allow the suffering of March 2026 to become a footnote in a government report. If the Centre can arrange funds for corporate bailouts, it must find funds to save farmers. We will not forgive this dance of death between the Centre and states," warned Rajan Kshirsagar, president, All India Kisan Sabha (AIKS), a Left-leaning farmers' group. A Communist Party of India (CPI)-affiliated organisation attacked the policy-makers at the Centre and states with charges of "gross negligence, deliberate underreporting of losses, and a callous delay in releasing pending relief measures."

Media reports warned that repeated unseasonal weather conditions tighten supplies, push the prices of staple food upwards, and stress farm incomes. This is especially true because farming contributes a large share to employment, as well as GDP. Agriculture con-

Rain dance, or 'dance of death'

Unexpected showers, hailstorms rain more woes on farmers

tributes around 18 per cent to the GDP, and employs nearly 45 per cent of the workforce, according to the World Bank. The month of March is usually the harvest time for major rabi crops such as wheat, mustard, gram, and potatoes. Sudden changes in weather affect produce, and send shockwaves among the farming community.

As per the current estimates, wheat and mustard crops are under extreme stress, and may cause distress for the growers the season. Hence, the situation in some sensitive states is rocky. In addition, the post-harvest crops left in the fields tend to absorb extra moisture due to the untimely rains, and develop fungi, which leads to losses. Thus, multiple factors can impact production. Coming as it does during a period of geopolitical disruptions due to the Iran war, may add to the woes of the farmers, who may be hit by inflation and shortages.

The agriculture minister directed fast-tracking of crop insurance, which is crucial to protect returns, and incomes. However, the AIKS claimed that the state-run insurance scheme has "once again been exposed as a vehicle for corporate loot, with the government acting as a facilitator for the insurance companies." Although there were no specific details, the hints are that the insurers deliberately underpay the claims, or do not entertain them. The

farmers are left in the lurch, as they run from pillar to post to claim the due amounts, and suffer due to losses.

Coming back to the weather conditions, in Northwest India and Delhi-NCR, the reports indicated a sharp transition "from soaring temperatures to wettest March in three years, with significant rainfall on March 18-20." In the northern parts, a form of a mild heatwave in the first of March changed into cold weather, with rains and snow (in some parts). States such as Jammu and Kashmir, Himachal Pradesh, and Uttarakhand faced "erratic weather" with widespread rain and snowfall in the higher reaches. Hailstorm alerts were issued in Punjab, Haryana, and parts of Uttar Pradesh, according to farmers' unions.

While in the Northeast, Assam and Meghalaya were battered by heavy to very heavy rainfall (up to 20 cm), West Bengal and Sikkim experienced extremely heavy rainfall exceeding 21 cm. Vidarbha and Chhattisgarh saw isolated thunderstorms and hailstorms, even as some pockets dealt with prior heatwave conditions, the AIKS added. Erratic showers and thunderstorms affected Telangana, interior Karnataka, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu, with heavy rains recorded in isolated places of coastal Andhra Pradesh and Kerala. However, there may be cases, say the farmers, where the

damages are being underreported.

Quoting reports from on-ground and local members, Kshirsagar dismissed Maharashtra's initial assessments as "farce aimed at protecting the government's image rather than providing relief." While the state agriculture department admitted to minimal crop damage "across a meagre few thousand hectares," the farmers' union claimed that its reports "paint a picture of apocalyptic ruin" in several state districts like Vidarbha and Marathwada. Some experts feel that this is a typical political-bureaucratic reaction to dilute the bad news, not create a panic, and avoid high payments to the farmers.

"In Akola and Amravati, we have reports of hail the size of stones ruining ready-to-harvest wheat, pulses, oranges, and bananas, yet the official figures are a fraction of the reality. This is a deliberate attempt to keep compensation figures low. We demand that the correct ground data be collected via mandatory joint field visits by revenue officials in the presence of farmer representatives, scrapping the opaque remote-sensing-only model," added Ravula Venkai, general secretary, AIKS.

But the Government states that its objective is to ensure that policy measures, relief mechanisms, and the outreach of the various welfare schemes are coordinated effectively so that the farmers receive timely and adequate support. Senior officials, including the agriculture secretary, and agriculture commissioner, were directed to ensure that wherever the farmers required assistance, coordination with the state governments was strengthened. Chouhan stressed that crop cutting experiments need to be conducted promptly, losses assessed scientifically, and immediate reliefs provided without delays. He urged for "time-bound action at the field level" in areas affected by the heavy rainfalls, hailstorms, or other adverse weather conditions. Farmers' unions remain unhappy and dissatisfied. They want a comprehensive relief package not as loans, but as ex-gratia compensations, apart from clearances of pending claims, repeal of the Disaster Management Act, 2025, and an overhaul of the crop insurance scheme.

(The author has more than three decades of experience across print, TV, and digital media)

West Asia disruptions could choke growth, spur inflation: ADB

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The West Asia conflict could lower economic growth in Asia Pacific region by up to 1.3 percentage points over 2026-2027 and raise inflation by 3.2 percentage points if energy market disruptions last more than a year, according to a research by the Asian Development Bank (ADB).
“The conflict affects economies in Asia and the Pacific through higher energy prices, supply chain and trade disruptions, and tighter financial conditions. Tourism and remittances could also be impacted,” ADB said in the report.
The report outlines three risk scenarios indicating that effects on the region’s developing economies will depend largely on

the duration of disruptions, it said. Under a short-lived conflict, energy price pressures would ease relatively quickly. More prolonged disruptions would lead to larger and more persistent impacts on growth and inflation, it said.
Adverse effects on growth will be most severe for economies in developing Southeast Asia and the Pacific, with inflation rising highest in South Asian economies, it said, adding, the scenarios reflect the high degree of uncertainty around how the conflict and the associated disruptions will evolve, and should be treated with caution.
In addition to higher energy prices, they account for broader supply chain disruptions and a global tightening of financial conditions, it said. “Prolonged energy

disruptions could force economies in developing Asia and the Pacific to navigate a difficult trade-off between weaker growth and higher inflation. Governments should focus on containing market stress and protecting the most vulnerable, while adopting policies to improve longer-term resilience,” ADB Chief Economist Albert Park said. The report suggested policies should focus on stabilisation rather than suppression of price signals. Allowing higher energy prices to pass through, at least in part, can encourage energy conservation, fuel switching, and investment in alternative energy sources. Broad price controls or generalised subsidies risk distorting incentives, delaying adjustment, and misallocating resources, it said.



With regard to fiscal support, it said, it should be targeted and time-bound and priority should be given to supporting vulnerable households and the most affect-

ed industries. Well-targeted measures can cushion the social impact of higher prices while containing fiscal costs and preserving incentives to adjust to the shock, it said. Besides, it said, central banks should focus on limiting excessive market volatility while keeping a close watch on inflation expectations.
“The priority should be to provide targeted liquidity support to preserve orderly market functioning. Tightening policy too aggressively risks amplifying growth headwinds and exacerbating financial volatility. While some tightening may be warranted, anchoring inflation expectations with effective central bank communication will remain key,” it said.
Governments should curb energy demand where feasible, it said, adding, practical measures include temperature mandates to limit air-conditioning, cuts to non-essential lighting, peak-hour elec-

tricity-saving campaigns, and work-from-home or staggered schedules.
Incentivising public transport use and car-free days in urban areas on public holidays can also help reduce transport fuel use, it added.
ADB is a leading multilateral development bank supporting sustainable, inclusive, and resilient growth across Asia and the Pacific.
Working with its members and partners to solve complex challenges together, ADB harnesses innovative financial tools and strategic partnerships to transform lives, build quality infrastructure, and safeguard our planet. Founded in 1966, ADB is owned by 69 members-50 from the region.

Govt to open driving schools in 120 aspirational districts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The Government, in partnership with the industry, will open driving schools in 120 aspirational districts and 500 blocks that are socially, economically, and educationally backward, to create one crore jobs in the country in the next five years.
During a conversation with film star Aamir Khan at a Sadak Suraksha Abhiyan event here in the capital, Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari said there is a shortage of 22 lakh drivers in the country and the Government has opened 200 driving schools.
“We have decided to open driving training centres with

the help of the industry in the 120 aspirant districts and 500 aspirant blocks which are socially, economically, educationally backward. We will provide employment to one crore youth through this initiative,” the minister said.
On road safety he said unfortunately it is true that India is at the top in terms of the number of road accidents in the world.
Today, India records more than five lakh accidents and 1.8 lakh related deaths every year. About 66 per cent people are in the age group of 18-44 years. Three per cent of India’s GDP is lost due to these accidents, he noted.
He highlighted that there are five reasons for road accidents.
First, road design and engi-



Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari

neering. He informed, “We identified black spots and have spent ₹40,000 crore to remove them. The other reason for accidents is landslide in hilly areas. We have identified 350 such spots and about 280 were improved.”
He noted that the other reason for accidents are automobile engineering.
He said, “Our automobile industry is in the third posi-

tion in the world with ₹23 lakh crore (turnover) following the US at ₹79 lakh crore and China at ₹49 lakh crore. We aim to take our automobile industry at the top in the world in next five year.”
He noted that the third reason for accidents is enforcement.
Fourth reason is human behaviour. “There is no fear and respect for law in the country. About 50,000 people’s lives can be saved by just wearing helmet while riding bikes. About 30,000 people can save their life by just fastening seat belts,” he said. He stated that the number of instances of drunk driving has come down.
Khan said, “I take road safety very seriously. I also make mistake once in a while as I am a human being. But by and large I am very strict on safety on roads. I expect the entire country should take road safety very seriously.”
He said the Government can bring laws, rules or provide facility, but ultimately if people are not using these then the issue will not be resolved.
He noted that people wear helmet only due fear of police. “We should understand that wearing helmet will save our life irrespective of presence of policemen.”
He also mentioned about people buying clips to avoid seat belt. Khan suggested that the seat belts for passengers in school buses be made compulsory for children’s safety.

World shares fall, oil climbs



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Hong Kong

World shares traded lower and oil prices rose back to around \$100 per barrel on Thursday as a de-escalation of the Iran war remained uncertain. US futures were down 0.7 per cent.
In early European trading, Britain’s FTSE 100 lost 1.3 per cent to 9,977.65. France’s CAC 40 fell 1.1 per cent to 7,762.41, and Germany’s DAX dropped 1.6 per cent to 22,583.07.
Tokyo’s Nikkei 225 was trading 0.3 per cent lower at 53,603.65. South Korea’s Kospi lost 3.2 per cent to 5,460.46. Hong Kong’s Hang Seng fell 1.9 per cent to 24,856.43, while the Shanghai Composite index was down 1.1 per cent to 3,889.08.
Australia’s S and P/ASX 200 edged down 0.1 per cent, while Taiwan’s Taiex was trading 0.3 per cent lower.
Oil prices were up again on Thursday. Brent crude, the international standard, rose 3.2 per cent to \$100.39 per barrel. It was below \$95 on Wednesday. Benchmark US crude was 3.5 per cent higher

at \$93.44 a barrel.
The rise in oil prices came as Tehran on Wednesday dismissed a ceasefire plan by the US, after the administration of US President Donald Trump offered a 15-point proposal to Iran and Trump this week delayed a self-imposed deadline to “obliterate” its power plants in order to force Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz.
Trump insisted late Wednesday that Iran is still negotiating following its rejection of the US’s ceasefire proposal.
Iran also launched more attacks on Israel and Gulf Arab countries as Israel launched airstrikes on Tehran and the US prepared to deploy more American troops to the region.
With the Strait of Hormuz, a crucial waterway between Iran and Oman where roughly a fifth of the world’s oil typically passes through, remaining largely closed after the Iran war began, oil prices have fluctuated, climbing around 40 per cent since the beginning of the war, which is now in its fourth week.

Two-thirds of people find Govt buses value for money: Study

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Two-thirds of people feel that Government buses are value for money, while half of them want an easier booking process and better point-booking services, says a study.
According to the study by online bus ticketing platform redBus, road transport corporations have high functional relevance and are preferred by working professionals and students.
The study is based on responses from more than 11,000 people on Government-owned intercity bus

services (RTC/ ST / STU / Roadways), a statement said.
The top reasons passengers choose RTCs are visiting their homes (25 per cent), travelling for festivals and special occasions like weddings (25 per cent), work (21 per cent), and studies (11 per cent), it stated.
About 52 per cent of RTC users are working professionals and 27 per cent are students — making younger people the second largest segment of passengers.
Among 18-25 year olds, 61 per cent said education was their main reason to travel by RTCs, underlin-



ing the state transport’s role in enabling youth mobility.
Students were also the most price-sensitive group, with 46 per cent of them travelling in the sub-₹750 bracket, compared to other cohorts, it stated. It stated that the average price of booking a seat (ASP) on RTCs is lower than the ASP for similar types of private buses.
The RTCs are perceived as much more affordable than private buses; this may stem from the fact that RTC bus tickets have mostly fixed prices, but private bus operators change prices depending on seasonality and demand, it stated.

India initiates probe against imports of subsidised Chinese, Indonesian paperboards

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India has initiated a probe against imports of subsidised Chinese and Indonesian paperboards as it is allegedly impacting domestic players, according to a notification.
The commerce ministry’s investigation arm Directorate General of Trade Remedies (DGTR) has started the exercise following a complaint filed by Indian Paper Manufacturers’ Association on behalf of the domestic industry.
The applicant has alleged that exports of multi-layer paperboards by Chinese and Indonesian firms, which is subsidised by the respective countries, are hurting margins of Indian companies.
They have requested for initiation of an anti-subsidy or countervailing investigation on imports of boards originating in or exported from these two countries.
The applicant has alleged that the producers/exporters in these two



nations have benefited from the subsidies provided at various levels by their respective Governments in the form of grants, loans, guarantees, taxes, export credits, goods and services, or equity infusions.
“On the basis of the duly substantiated written application filed by or on behalf of the domestic industry, and having satisfied itself, on the basis of prima facie evidence submitted by the domestic industry, substantiating existence of countervailable subsidies on production and export... the authority hereby initiates an investigation,” the DGTR said in a notification.

It will determine the existence, degree and effect of alleged subsidisation. If found that the subsidisation is impacting Indian firms, the directorate would recommend the amount of anti-subsidy duty, which if levied, would be adequate to remove the injury to the domestic industry.
Multi-layer paperboard is majorly used in the packaging sector for pharmaceuticals, FMCG products, food & beverages, electronics and high end cosmetics. It is also used for printing of brochures, as book covers and in publishing industry.
In two separate notifications, the DGTR has stated that it has initiated sunset review of anti-dumping duty on imports of seamless tubes, pipes and hollow profiles of iron, alloy or non-alloy steel; and certain flat rolled aluminium products exported from China.
Hindalco Industries has filed an application before the DGTR seeking initiation of sunset review investigation of anti-dumping duties on certain aluminium items exported by Chinese companies.

Vijay Mallya takes swipe at critics who laughed at his investment in RCB as ‘vanity project’

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Fugitive businessman Vijay Mallya, the original owner of Royal Challengers Bengaluru, on Thursday took a dig at critics who called it “investment as a vanity project” after the cricket franchise was sold for almost \$2 billion (₹18,776 crore).
Mallya, who had bought Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) for ₹450 crore in 2008, in a post on X congratulated the new owners of RCB, saying, “I wish them the very best and Godspeed with the most valuable IPL franchise.”
The sale of cricket franchise RCB by United Spirits Ltd (USL) almost tops a record \$2 billion (₹18,776 crore), considering it also includes a ₹540-crore payout for the Women’s Premier League



Fugitive businessman Vijay Mallya

and a 5 per cent commission to the cricket body BCCI by the consortium of buyers, according to sources.
USL had on Tuesday announced the sale of RCB in a ₹16,660-crore all-cash deal to a consortium of Aditya Birla Group, The Times of India Group, Bolt Ventures

and Blackstone. Reacting to the development, Mallya wrote, “When I bought the franchise in 2008 for ₹450 crore, most people laughed at me and criticised my investment as a vanity project.”
He further said, “Behind my much touted madnness was building the Royal Challenge

brand and hence I named the franchise RCB.”
He noted that it was “immensely gratifying to see my ₹450 crore investment grow to ₹16,500 crore (₹16,660 crore).”
Mallya said RCB will always remain a part of his DNA with “indelible memories including picking the young Virat Kohli who is now amongst the best in the World.”
In his post, Mallya thanked all RCB fans who came on board during his “stewardship and beyond” asking them, “to support RCB the Lion of Bengaluru. Namaskara.”
Mallya, who fled to the UK in March 2016, is wanted in India over a default of ₹9,000 crore that was loaned to erstwhile Kingfisher Airlines (KFA) by several banks.

Freight surge, LPG shortage amid West Asia crisis hit exports from east India

BISHASWAR MALAKAR
■ Kolkata

The West Asia crisis has pushed freight costs for Europe-bound cargo up by 60-80 per cent, with exports falling by as much as 50 per cent for some exporters while hundreds of containers got stranded at Kolkata port, industry representatives said on Thursday.
Calcutta Customs House Agents Association (CCHAA) president Mannu Choudhary told PTI that freight charges have risen by over 40 per cent due to rerouting through the African route, while war surcharges imposed by shipping lines have taken the total cost escalation to 70-80 per cent for shipments to Europe and the US.
Exporters also complained of a shortage of containers.
“Shipping lines are denying freight details to exporters, who

are now waiting. No fresh containers are being accepted by shipping lines,” he said.
Choudhary said around 600 containers that had entered Kolkata port for loading were being returned to the city following last-minute cargo cancellations.
Of these, around 400 have already been taken back, while the remaining 200 are in the process of being cleared.
Former EEPIC India chairman and managing director of Nipha Ltd, Rakesh Shah, said the situation was “dire”.
He said the LPG supply crunch was compounding production difficulties, as the fuel is used in the finishing process for certain manufactured goods, including engineering products.
Freight rates have risen 60-80 per cent depending on destina-



tion, containers are in short supply, and exports have fallen by up to 50 per cent, he added.
“March used to be the best month, but this will turn out to be the worst month for shipments,” Shah said.

He said the engineering goods industry, which had been expecting growth of 3 per cent to 3.5 per cent over the previous year, would now lose incremental exports and was likely to end the current fiscal flat.

“We were up 2 per cent till January, but with February and March, the geopolitical headwinds will eliminate the growth factor,” he said.
Shah said exporters were also unable to take advantage of the falling rupee due to disruptions in logistics and order execution.
On the Government’s relief measures, Shah acknowledged the freight neutralisation scheme offering 50 per cent reimbursement but flagged a critical implementation gap.
“There is a lack of clarity on the total freight equalisation benefit, which is making our internal calculations difficult,” he said.
Choudhary said the port trust and Concord have offered reduced tariffs, and weekly CCFC (Customs Clearance Facilitation Committee) meetings are being held at the Custom House with all

stakeholders. Further stakeholder meetings are scheduled for March 23 and 24, he added.
Perishable cargo from the eastern region, particularly shrimps and fish, has been among the worst affected, along with engineering goods, textiles and medicines meant for European markets.
While medicines are largely being transported by air, last-minute flight cancellations and mid-air route changes are pushing up air freight tariffs.
“Crisis is still there. Exporters are a little concerned. The environment is insecure,” Choudhary said, adding that he expects shipping lines to cooperate in reducing charges in upcoming discussions.
The Jawaharlal Nehru Customs House (JNCH) at Nhava Sheva had on March 13 directed all shipping

lines and non-vessel owning common carriers (NVOCCs) to pass on relief granted by the Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority (JNPA), including a 100 per cent waiver on ground rent and dwell time charges and an 80 per cent waiver on reefer plug-in charges for eligible Middle East-bound containers stranded between February 28 and March 14, 2026.
The Government, on March 19, approved the ₹497 crore ‘RELIEF’ (Resilience and Logistics Intervention for Export Facilitation) scheme under the Export Promotion Mission.
Implemented through ECGC Ltd, the scheme covers shipments between February 14 and March 15, 2026, with up to 100 per cent risk coverage for conflict-linked losses, and up to 95 per cent coverage for exports between March 16 and June 15, 2026. (PTI)

FROM THE WORLD

SINGAPORE

Indian charged rash driving

An Indian-origin man was on Thursday charged in a Singapore court for driving a luxury sports car with his two children sitting on the car boot. Prem Anan Sugunakumar was handed one count of rash act that endangered the safety of children below the age of 14, according to a report by Channel News Asia.

He is said to have driven the vehicle along an upmarket housing enclave on October 20, 2025 and allowed the children, aged eight and seven, to sit atop the rear boot of the car. In court, Prem's lawyer said that his client would be "taking a certain course" and asked the court to reflect an early plea of guilt. He asked for time to take instructions from his client. The case will return to court on April 22. Videos of the incident made the rounds on social media last year.

ITALY

Meloni Govt minister resigns

Italy's legally troubled tourism minister resigned on Wednesday in the fallout of Premier Giorgia Meloni's failed referendum on judicial reforms. The departure of Daniela Santanche is a sign that Italy's 3 1/2-year-old right-wing Government has been weakened by Monday's ballot box defeat of a key measure. Meloni had demanded Santanches resignation after two justice ministry officials stepped down in the wake of voters' resounding rejection of judicial reforms in a vote that was widely seen as a de facto confidence test on Meloni's leadership. In a statement on Tuesday, Meloni said she hoped Santanche would make a similar decision "in the same spirit of institutional sensitivity." Santanche, who was seen as a key member of Meloni's Brothers of Italy party, has been politically damaged by multiple long-term trials and investigations, including alleged false accounting.

UAE: Debris from missiles kills two, including an Indian

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Dubai

At least two persons, including an Indian, were killed and three others injured on Thursday when debris of missiles intercepted by the UAE's air defence system fell on a street in Abu Dhabi, local media reported.

The second person killed in the incident is a Pakistani national, while the three injured also include an Indian, Abu Dhabi Media Office reported.

UAE's air defences are responding to incoming missile and drone threats from Iran at regular intervals, according to the Ministry of Defence of the United Arab Emirates. "Abu Dhabi authorities have responded to an incident involving falling debris in Sweihan street, fol-



Man walking on the rubble of a destroyed building that was hit in an Israeli airstrike in the southern port city of Tyre, Lebanon

lowing the successful interception of a ballistic missile by air defence systems," Abu Dhabi Media Office posted on social media.

"The incident has resulted in the deaths of two individuals of Pakistani and Indian nationality, and in injuries ranging from serious to moderate sustained by three individuals of Emirati, Jordanian

and Indian nationality," it added. The total number of deaths has risen to 11 after the latest incident in Abu Dhabi, Gulf News reported.

The UAE air defences systems on 26th March 2026 engaged 15 ballistic missiles and 11 UAVs launched from Iran, the Ministry of Defence said in a social media post on Thursday. Since the start of

the blatant Iranian attacks, UAE air defences have engaged 372 ballistic missiles, 15 cruise missiles and 1,826 UAVs, it added.

"The attacks resulted in the martyrdom of 2 members of the armed forces while performing their national duty, in addition to the martyrdom of a Moroccan civilian contracted by the Armed Forces, as well as 8 fatalities of Pakistani, Nepali, Bangladeshi, Palestinian and Indian nationalities," it said.

A total of 169 people were also injured, with injuries ranging from minor to moderate and severe.

The injured included nationals of the UAE, Egypt, Sudan, Ethiopia, the Philippines, Pakistan, Iran, India, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Azerbaijan, Indonesia, Sweden and Tunisia.

Ships queue up at Asian ports due to West Asia crisis

GURDIP SINGH ■ Singapore

With the Strait of Hormuz almost closed amid the ongoing war in the Gulf region, merchant vessels, including oil tankers, have started to queue up at ports across Asia while operators wait for clarity, a media report said Thursday.

Sourcing data that showed longer queues and delays at major Asian ports, including



at the richest city-state, The Straits Times pointed out that more vessels carrying Gulf-bound cargoes could seek anchorage in Singapore and Malaysia's Tanjung Pelepas and Klang ports in the coming weeks, if the crisis drags on.

Starting February 28, the US and Israel launched joint strikes against Iran, which in turn, retaliated, spreading the war to the entire Gulf region. The Strait of Hormuz is a strategically important choke point for the world's energy supplies. (PTI)

Iran-US tensions escalate over Strait of Hormuz

JON GAMBRELL/DAVID RISING

■ Dubai

Iran and the United States appeared at an impasse Thursday, with each side hardening its position over talks and setting the stage for another potential escalation in the Middle East war.

Thousands more US troops neared the region, while Tehran tightened its grip on the crucial Strait of Hormuz. Sirens over Israel warned of barrages of incoming Iranian missiles and Gulf nations worked to intercept fire. Heavy strikes were reported in Iran's capital and other cities.

In a war that appears defined by who can take the most pain, the US has offered shifting but ambitious objectives, including ensuring Iran's missile and nuclear programs are no longer a threat and ending Tehran's support for armed groups in the region. Washington at one point also pushed for the overthrow of Iran's theocracy.

While the US-Israeli campaign has hit Iran's military and Government hard, killing top leaders and striking scores of targets, Iran continues to fire missiles and there is no sign of an uprising against the Government.

For Iran's leadership, by contrast, merely outlasting the onslaught could be seen as victory.

It may be hoping to get the US to back down because it is



Responders inspecting the remains of a residential building hit in an overnight strike during the US-Israeli military campaign in Tabriz, Iran

successfully roiling the world economy with its stranglehold on the Strait of Hormuz, raising prices at the pump for drivers, prices in the grocery store for families and costs for businesses the world over. A Gulf Arab bloc said Thursday that Iran is exacting tolls to ensure safe passage of ships.

The US and Iran have both produced a list of demands, and now appear at an impasse. Short of a negotiated solution, the US would need a dramatic escalation to end Iran's attacks and restore the free flow of oil through the strait.

Trump vowed to strike Iran's power plants if it doesn't fully reopen the strait, and his new deadline for that looms this weekend, when the war will also mark a month. With its stranglehold on traffic through the Strait of Hormuz, which leads from the Persian Gulf toward the open ocean, Iran has

been blocking ships it perceives as linked to the US and Israeli war effort, but letting through a trickle of others. Jassem Mohamed al-Budaiwi, of the Gulf Cooperation Council, a bloc of six Gulf Arab nations, said Iran was charging for safe passage through the strait. The Fars and Tasnim news agencies, both close to Iran's paramilitary Revolutionary Guard, quoted lawmaker Mohammadreza Rezaei Kouchi as saying that parliament was working to formalize that process.

"We provide its security, and it is natural that ships and oil tankers should pay such fees," he was quoted as saying. Lloyd's List Intelligence called it a "de facto toll booth" regime.

"While not all ships are paying a direct toll, at least two vessels have and the payment is settled in yuan," Lloyd's List said, referring to China's currency. (AP)

Head of IRGS navy killed, claims Israel

ASSOCIATED PRESS

■ Jerusalem

Israel said Thursday it killed Commodore Alireza Tangsiri, the head of Iranian Revolutionary Guard's navy - the key official overseeing the closure of the strait.

Israeli Defence Minister Israel Katz said he had been killed along with other senior naval commanders in a strike overnight. Iran did not immediately acknowledge Tangsiri's killing.

Israel said it carried out a wave of attacks early on Thursday targeting Iranian infrastructure, and air defenses were heard in Tehran. Heavy strikes were also reported around Isfahan, home to a major Iranian air base and other military sites, as well as one



of the nuclear sites bombed by the US during the 12-day war in June.

Sirens sounded very early on Thursday morning in parts of Tel Aviv and cities in central Israel and later explosions were heard in Jerusalem. Since the war began, more than 1,500 people have been killed in Iran, its Health Ministry says.

Seventeen people have been killed in Israel, while

three Israeli soldiers have also been killed in Lebanon. At least 13 American troops have been killed. More than a dozen civilians in the occupied West Bank and Gulf Arab states have also died.

Authorities said nearly 1,100 people have died in Lebanon, where Israel has targeted the Iran-backed Hezbollah militant group, which has fired into Israel.

Afghans hold mass funeral for airstrike victims

ABDUL QAHAH AFGHAN

■ Kabul

Dozens of people were buried in a Kabul cemetery on Thursday in the second mass funeral of victims killed in an airstrike that hit a drug rehabilitation center in the Afghan capital earlier this month.

Bulldozers opened a large pit into which individual graves were dug for the 60 coffins. Afghan officials have said hundreds of people were killed when a Pakistani airstrike hit the 2,000-bed Omid Addiction Treatment Hospital on March 16.

The UN humanitarian affairs office has said the total death toll is still under verification. Pakistan has denied targeting civilians,



saying it struck an ammunition depot.

The strike came amid escalating fighting between Pakistan and Afghanistan that began in February and has seen repeated cross-border clashes as well as airstrikes inside Afghanistan, including several in Kabul. Pakistan accuses Afghanistan of pro-

viding a safe haven for militants who carry out attacks inside Pakistan, especially for the Pakistani Taliban.

The group is separate but closely allied with the Afghan Taliban, which seized power in Afghanistan in 2021 during the chaotic withdrawal of US-led troops. Kabul denies the charge. (PTI)

Pakistan declared last month that it is in "open war" with Afghanistan. The conflict has alarmed the international community, particularly as the area is one where other militant organizations, including al-Qaida and the Islamic State group, still have a presence and have been trying to resurface.

The two sides declared a temporary truce last week ahead of the Muslim holiday of Eid al-Fitr, following mediation by Saudi Arabia, Turkey and Qatar.

The truce expired this week, and renewed fighting erupted on Wednesday, with Afghan officials saying at least two civilians had been killed in eastern Afghanistan and others had been wounded. (PTI)

India, China ties on correct path of improvement: Chinese FM Wang Yi

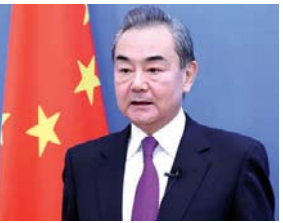
KJM VARMA

■ Beijing

India, China relations have embarked on a "correct path" of improvement, and their shared interests far outweigh differences, Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi said on Thursday.

Under the strategic guidance of the leaders of both countries, China-India relations have embarked on a correct path of improvement and development, Wang, who is also a member of the Political Bureau of the ruling Communist Party of China (CPC), said.

Facing a complex and turbulent international situa-



Wang Yi

tion, China is willing to work with India to implement the important consensus reached by the leaders of both countries, uphold the principle of viewing each other as development opportunities rather than threats and treat each other as partners rather than competitors, he said during a farewell call on the outgoing

Indian Ambassador Pradeep Rawat. India, China relations, which were frozen for over five years following the military standoff in Ladakh, improved after the meetings between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Chinese President Xi Jinping at Kazan in Russia during the BRICS summit in 2024 and in Tianjin on the sidelines of the SCO summit last year.

In the last few months, India and China have stepped up efforts to stabilise their relations, seeking a reset after the 2020 military standoff in the Galwan Valley plunged ties to the lowest point in decades. Wang said that as two neighbouring

countries and major emerging economies, India and China's shared interests far outweigh their differences, an official press release issued by the Chinese Foreign Ministry said.

Without the modernisation of China and India, there can be no modernisation of the world, he said.

China is also willing to expand mutually beneficial cooperation across various fields, safeguard the common interests of the Global South, strengthen multilateral collaboration within mechanisms such as BRICS, and consolidate the hard-won positive momentum in China-India relations. (PTI)

Balendra Shah 'Balen' set to be sworn-in as Nepal's youngest Prime Minister

SHIRISH B PRADHAN

■ Kathmandu

Balendra Shah 'Balen' was on Thursday elected as the leader of the Parliamentary party of the Rastriya Swatantra Party, paving his way to become Nepal's youngest elected prime minister on Friday.

The 35-year-old rapper-turned-politician senior leader of the Rastriya Swatantra Party (RSP), which won a landslide victory in the March 5 poll, will also be the first person from the Madhes region to hold the top executive post in the country.

Nepal chose fresher Balendra Shah 'Balen' -



Balendra Shah with sun glasses, arriving for a swearing-in ceremony of newly elected members of the House of Representatives at the Federal Parliament in Kathmandu, Nepal

popular only as Balen - and his RSP to form the next government decimating the traditional parties in the first general elections since last year's violent Gen Z protests that sought generational change and corruption-free regime.

The RSP that had projected Balen as the prime ministerial candidate, secured a massive 182 seats out of a total 275 seats in the House of Representatives (HoR), making it eligible to form a majority government under Article 76 (1) of the Constitution. Of the 275 members of the HoR, 165 are elected through direct voting and 110 through pro-

portionate voting. Soon after the oath taking ceremony of the newly elected HoR members, the central committee meeting of the RSP formed its Parliamentary party. "The Parliamentary party meeting unanimously elected Balen as its leader, the formally qualifying him for the top executive post of the country," Shanker Shrestha, secretary of the RSP's central organisation committee, said.

Balen has been given full authority to form the new cabinet under his leadership, Shrestha said. The members of the new cabinet will be finalised later in the evening, he added.

Earlier, the newly elected members, including Balen, of the HoR took the oath of office at the federal parliament building, beginning the process of government formation three weeks after the voting concluded.

The eldest member of the House, Arjun Narasingha KC, 78, administered the oath of office and secrecy to the newly elected lawmakers at the federal parliament secretariat in Singha Durbar.

As per the tradition, on Wednesday, President Ramchandra Paudel administered the oath of office and secrecy to KC, elected to the Lower House under the proportionate voting system

representing Nepali Congress party. On Friday, according to sources at the President's Office, Balen will be sworn-in as the prime minister during a special ceremony at the President's Office, Sheetal Niwas. Sources close to Balen's secretariat said he is likely to form a small cabinet with the number of ministers ranging between 15 to 18.

Balen, a rapper-turned-politician, defeated four-time prime minister K P Sharma Oli in the Jhapa-5 constituency, a long-standing stronghold of the Communist Party of Nepal (Unified Marxist-Leninist), by a huge margin.

By securing more seats than the simple majority (138

seats) enough to form a government, the RSP is just two short of a two-thirds majority that is required in case his party wants to amend the constitution.

Balen and the RSP tsunami almost wiped out the traditional parties with the Nepali Congress winning only 38 seats, followed by the Communist Party of Nepal- Unified Marxist-Leninist (CPN-UML) with 25, and the Nepali Communist Party getting only 17 seats.

The Shram Sanskriti Party won seven seats and the Rastriya Prajatantra Party with five. One result has been withheld pending a court case. (PTI)

North Korea, Belarus sign friendship treaty

DASHA LITVINOVA
■ Seoul

Belarus's President Alexander Lukashenko and North Korean leader Kim Jong Un held talks in North Korea's capital on Thursday and signed a friendship and cooperation treaty.

Lukashenko, who was in Pyongyang on a two-day official visit, hailed the document as "fundamental," and said that relations between the two countries are "entering a new stage," according to his press service.

"Yes, we didn't have close cooperation, largely due to our own fault. But I am sincerely pleased to note that cooperation has now



North Korea's leader Kim Jong Un and Belarusian President Alexander Lukashenko attend an official meeting ceremony in Pyongyang, North Korea

significantly intensified," Lukashenko said. "In today's reality of a global transformation, when the global powers openly ignore and violate interna-

tional law, independent countries need to cooperate more closely, consolidate efforts aimed at protecting their sovereignty and improving the well-being of our

citizens," he said. Lukashenko's press service quoted Kim expressing "solidarity and full support" for Belarus and speaking out "against unlawful pressure on

Belarus from the West." Belarus is a close ally of Russia. Lukashenko allowed Moscow to use Belarusian territory as a staging ground for the Kremlin's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in February 2022, and later authorised the deployment of Russian tactical nuclear weapons in Belarus.

Kim has also tilted his foreign policy toward Moscow in recent years, sending thousands of troops and large quantities of weapons to support Russian President Vladimir Putin's war in Ukraine while portraying the North as part of a united front against Washington. Lukashenko and Kim last met in September 2025 in Beijing. (AP)

2 men released on bail for suspected antisemitic hate crime in Britain



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ London

British police said on Thursday that two men arrested in connection with an arson attack that destroyed four ambulances owned by a Jewish charity have been released on bail.

The two British nationals, aged 45 and 47, were detained on Wednesday on suspicion of arson with intent to endanger life, London's Metropolitan Police Service said in a statement. The men were released under strict bail conditions and will be closely monitored, police said. Authorities on Wednesday described the arrests as an important breakthrough in the case, but noted that three people were visible in the closed-circuit camera footage of the attack.

"We continue to work to try and identify all of those involved in this appalling attack and the investigation team is working around the clock to do this,11 said Commander Helen Flanagan, head of Counter Terrorism Policing London.

Mangled plane in LaGuardia crash towed from runway



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ New York

All but four of the passengers injured in Sunday's deadly collision between an Air Canada plane and a fire truck have been released from the hospital, the airline said Wednesday, as crews began moving the mangled aircraft off the runway at New York's LaGuardia Airport.

The crash, which remains under investigation, killed two pilots. Roughly 40 people were treated at area hospitals for a range of injuries, some serious. Further details on the four people who remained hospitalised were not immediately available. The plane, which originated in Montreal, was carrying 76

people, including the crew, when it slammed into the fire truck that had driven out onto the runway. Seconds before the collision, an air traffic controller had cleared the truck to cross the runway.

Since Monday, much of the wreckage had remained on the tarmac, blocking access to one of two runways at one of the country's busiest airports.

Just before 5 pm on Wednesday, airport workers began towing the remnants away. Two big tow trucks working in tandem also righted the badly damaged fire truck, which had been laying on its side since the crash. The jet's tail end was lifted onto a large dolly, which was then towed via long tethers by two vehicles driving side by side.

24 killed as bus plunges into river in Bangladesh

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

At least 24 people were killed and several others remain missing after a bus plunged into a river in Bangladesh while attempting to board a transport ferry, officials said on Thursday.

The accident occurred in the southwestern district of Rajbari at the Dauladia terminal when the bus fell into the Padma River at about 5.15 pm on Wednesday, officials said.

They estimate that the Dhaka-bound bus was carrying around 40 passengers, including several children, most of whom were returning to the Capital after their Eid holidays.

According to local fire service officials, 24 bodies have been recovered. Twenty-two bodies were recovered from inside the bus, including 11 women, six men and five children.

"(Salvage vessel) Hamza retrieved the bus with its cranes," fire service official Sohail Rana told reporters at the scene. He added that the divers earlier recovered bodies of two women in their late 50s or early 60s and found the others as the bus was salvaged at around Wednesday midnight after six hours of efforts amid rough weather.

Fire service and coast-guard divers continued their search for the missing people with military and police assistance, according to Rana. According to Rajbari district administration offi-



cials, Prime Minister Tarique Rahman called them for updates on the salvage campaign and ordered an investigation into the accident.

Police and witnesses earlier said about 11 passengers managed to swim ashore or were rescued, but most others remained missing.

"When the bus was heading towards the ferry from the pontoon, another smaller utility ferry hit the pontoon. It plunged into the river as the bus driver lost control of the steering," the terminal's supervisor Monir Hossain said.

"Right before our eyes, the bus fell into the river, but we could do nothing," he added.

Doctors at Dauladia Health Complex said two women were brought dead while another woman, herself a doctor, received treatment.

According to witnesses and officials, many of the passengers were members of the same family. While several of them survived as they stood outside, their relatives were on the bus as it drowned.

Moscow to provide naval escort to merchant ships carrying cargo

VINAY SHUKLA
■ Moscow

Moscow will provide naval escort to ships carrying Russian cargo following growing cases of Western navies intercepting such vessels, the country's maritime board said.

The Maritime Board of Russia, headed by the top Kremlin aide, Nikolai Patrushev, in a meeting on Wednesday, devised a set of rules for countering detention of Russian ships on high seas and international shipping lanes, portnews.ru web portal for seafarers reported. Although



these guidelines primarily cover the Azov-Black Sea basin and the Baltic Sea region, ensuring secure and efficient navigation, it was not clear whether the naval escort would be provided beyond these parts of

the World. The decision comes as European nations have stepped up efforts to disrupt Russia's so-called shadow fleet of tankers used by Moscow to deliver hydrocarbons to its traditional customers in India and China, and growing demand in Asian markets in the wake of the West Asia crisis and blockade of the Strait of Hormuz by Iran.

"Shipowners engaged with Russia have been instructed on how to coordinate with the Navy," Patrushev announced, saying oversight of cargo ships operating for Russia has been reinforced. (PTI)

Maduro's legal battle continues in US

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ New York

Former Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro returns to a New York courtroom on Thursday as he seeks to have his drug trafficking indictment thrown out over a geopolitical dispute over legal fees.

Maduro's lawyer contends that the US is violating the deposed leader's constitutional rights by blocking Venezuelan Government funds from being used to pay his legal costs.

It's the first time that Maduro and his wife, Cilia Flores, will be in court since a January arraignment at which he protested their capture by US military forces



and declared: "I am not guilty. I am a decent man, the constitutional president of my country."

Flores has also pleaded not guilty. Both remain jailed at a detention centre in Brooklyn, and neither

has asked to be released on bail. Judge Alvin Hellerstein has yet to set a trial date, though that could happen at the hearing.

Maduro and Flores continue to enjoy some support in Venezuela, with murals and

billboards across the Capital, Caracas, demanding their return. But while Maduro's ruling party remains in power, he has slowly been erased from the Government of Delcy Rodriguez, Venezuela's acting president.

Rodriguez has replaced senior officials including Maduro's faithful defence minister and attorney general, reorganised agencies, appointed ambassadors and eliminated tenets of the self-proclaimed socialist movement that has ruled Venezuela for more than two decades.

She has even shaken up state television, which had been dominated by Maduro's hourslong evening appearances.

EU lawmakers approve external migrant detention centers plan

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Brussels

European lawmakers voted Thursday to ease the setting up of new migrant detention centers outside the European Union, known as "return hubs."

Members of the European Parliament voted 389-206 in favour, with 32 abstentions. Right-wing parties made an alliance with far-right groups that they had previously shunned to pass the measure, while parties of the left and centre voted against.

Any EU nation can now negotiate on its own or in small coalitions to deport migrants not to their home countries but to facilities yet to be built outside the 27-nation bloc. Already, Greece, Germany, the Netherlands, Austria, and Denmark have entered into negotiations with governments mainly in Africa to host sites to hold migrants denied asylum.

Far-right parties in Europe have praised the deportation policies of US President



Donald Trump and have called for the EU to adopt a similar approach.

Belgium's far-right Vlaams Belang party and Germany's far-right AfD party both said in January that they want to form a police group focused on finding and deporting migrants akin to US efforts.

However, human rights groups say migrants are being brutalized and pushed back illegally at EU borders, while legal protections are increasingly being hollowed out.

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Washington

India's Deputy Chief of Mission in the US Namgya Khampa met Congresswoman Sarah Elfreth to discuss further strengthening collaboration in defence, trade and investment.

Khampa met the Democrat Congresswoman from Maryland, who is a member of the House Armed Services Committee, here on Wednesday.

"They discussed recent global developments and ways to further strengthen

India-US collaboration in defence, trade & investment, and people-to-people ties," the Indian Embassy here said in a post on X. On Tuesday, the deputy chief of mission met Congresswoman Suzan DelBene from Washington state and thanked her for her support to the India-US partnership.

"They discussed issues of bilateral interest - trade, technology, defence partnership, and recognised the contributions of the Indian-American community in the relationship," the Embassy said.



Chinese envoy assures Pakistan of continued support in meeting with PM Shehbaz Sharif

SAJJAD HUSSAIN
■ Islamabad

Chinese ambassador Jiang Zaidong met with Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Thursday and pledged his country's "continued support" for trade and investment in Pakistan, a statement said.

Jiang also appreciated Pakistan's "economic resilience" in the meeting, also attended by Deputy Prime Minister and Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar and other officials, a statement by the PM Office said.

Appreciating China's steadfast economic support, the Prime Minister reaffirmed



Pakistan's commitment to advancing the second phase of the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor, called CPEC2.0, with a focus on agriculture, industrial coopera-

tion, and priority infrastructure projects, it stated. Ambassador Jiang "commended Pakistan's economic resilience and reform efforts, and reaffirmed

China's continued support, particularly in trade and investment," it added.

Both sides also expressed satisfaction at ongoing exchanges and looked forward to high-level engagements to mark the 75th anniversary of diplomatic relations.

Sharif also highlighted Pakistan's constructive role in promoting de-escalation in West Asia while discussing the regional situation. He also emphasised continued close coordination at all levels on issues of mutual interest while reaffirming the enduring Pakistan-China All-Weather Strategic Cooperative Partnership. (PTI)

Cuban President confirms Raul Castro's involvement in US talks amidst crisis

ANDREA RODRIGUEZ
■ Havana

Former Cuban President Raul Castro is involved in talks between the island and the United States, and they're still in the early stages, Cuban President Miguel Diaz-Canel said.

The talks come amid increasing tensions between the two nations, with Cuba plagued by nationwide blackouts resulting from a crumbling power grid and an ongoing oil blockade implemented by US President Donald Trump, who has threatened tariffs on any country that provides oil to Cuba and recently said he'd



Cuban President Miguel Diaz-Canel

have "the honour of taking Cuba" soon.

The talks overall are being handled collectively by the Cuban government, Diaz-Canel told Spanish leftist

leader Pablo Iglesias in a videotaped interview that lasted more than an hour and was shared by state media. Iglesias was in Cuba as part of a delegation of

some 600 activists from 33 countries who arrived last week to deliver humanitarian aid. "A process of conversations that leads to an agreement is a long process," Diaz-Canel told Iglesias, who produced the interview for his crowdfunded TV channel, Canal RED.

"First, we must build a channel for dialogue. Then, we must build common agendas of interests for the parties, and the parties must demonstrate their intention to move forward and truly commit to the programme based on the discussion of those agendas," Diaz-Canel said. In late January, Trump threatened tariffs on any

country that sells or provides oil to Cuba as he pushes for a change in the island's political model.

Although the initial threats were formally softened, the embargo has remained in place, and the island has not received any fuel shipments in the past three months.

Prolonged power outages and a near-paralysis of economic and social life are the visible consequences on the island, which in the last week experienced two nationwide blackouts that left millions without electricity as Cuba's power grid continues to crumble. The US has said that Cuba was in negotiations, and Trump has threat-

ened that he would take over the island soon. Diaz-Canel was more nuanced in his response and said his officials and those from the US State Department "held recent talks".

He also addressed speculation surrounding the role that Castro, 94, would be playing a role in these overtures. "The other thing they've tried to speculate about is that there are divisions within the leadership of the revolution," Diaz-Canel said, not clarifying who he was referring to.

Castro "is one of those who, along with me and in collaboration with other branches of the (Communist

Party, the government, and the State, has guided how we should conduct this dialogue process, if this dialogue process takes place," the president added.

He noted that Castro is "the historical leader of this revolution, even though he has relinquished his responsibilities", and that he maintains a "prestige earned with the people" due to "historical recognition that no one can deny". Raul Castro, who succeeded his brother, Fidel, as president, led historic talks with former US President Barack Obama in 2014 that led to the reopening of embassies and re-establishment of diplomatic relations. (AP)



public information, confirmed the total as about \$1.2 million. The settlement resolves a 2023 lawsuit in which Flynn sought at least \$50 million and asserted that the criminal case against him amounted to a malicious prosecution.

It also represents a stark turnabout in position for a Justice Department that during the Biden administration had pressed a judge to dismiss Flynn's complaint.

From Helsinki to the Himalayas: The strategic rise of India-Finland space tech cooperation



PARTHA P ROY CHOWDHURY

As India advances its ambitions under Aatmanirbhar Bharat and Viksit Bharat, partnerships with technologically advanced democracies are shifting from trade-led engagements to capability-driven collaborations. Finland's space and dual-use technology ecosystem is emerging as an operationally relevant partner in India's evolving security and industrial landscape.

India and Finland share a diplomatic relationship that dates back to 1949, rooted in democratic values, institutional transparency, and a strong commitment to technological progress. Recent diplomatic and industry engagements between India and Finland signal that this relationship is evolving to one of increasing strategic importance. Finnish participation in global strategic platforms hosted by India, including the Raisina Dialogue and emerging international forums on artificial intelligence and digital governance, reflects growing recognition that technological partnerships are becoming central to the evolving India-Europe strategic equation.

High-level visits between Indian and Finnish leaders, along with ministerial and industry delegations, have increasingly focused on innovation ecosystems, digital infrastructure, quantum technologies, sustainability, and space. These engagements are not merely ceremonial; they signal recognition that technological sovereignty, resilient supply chains, and trusted industrial partnerships are now central pillars of geopolitical alignment.

For India, this shift aligns squarely with the twin national frameworks of Aatmanirbhar Bharat (self-reliant India) and Viksit Bharat (developed India by 2047). For Finland, whose economy is deeply innovation-driven, India represents scale, industrial depth, and a long-term strategic partner in the Indo-Pacific. This emerging convergence is most visible in space and defence-related technologies — sectors where operational relevance increasingly defines the depth and direction of partnerships.

India's operational Imperatives: Space as strategic infrastructure
India's security environment is shaped

by complex geographic, strategic, and climatic factors. The country manages long continental borders across some of the world's most challenging terrain, maintains vast maritime responsibilities in the Indian Ocean Region, and frequently confronts climate-driven disasters. At the same time, the rise of grey-zone and hybrid threats has compressed decision-making timelines, particularly in high-altitude and littoral theatres where situational awareness can determine operational outcomes.

In this context, space-based capabilities have become foundational infrastructure rather than optional technological assets. Satellite-enabled systems now underpin all-weather surveillance, maritime domain awareness, sovereign access to geospatial data, and rapid disaster response mechanisms.

Under the framework of Aatmanirbhar Bharat, India's strategic emphasis is not merely on accessing advanced technologies but on developing indigenous capability, secure data architectures, and co-production models that reduce long-term external dependence. This approach naturally creates space for partnerships with technologically advanced ecosystems that can complement India's expanding domestic capabilities. Finland's emerging space technology sector fits into this evolving equation.

Finland's Space-Tech ecosystem: Engineering for extreme environments

Finland's technological strengths are shaped by geography and necessity. Operating in Arctic conditions has cultivated expertise in radar imaging, communications resilience, autonomous systems, and high-reliability engineering designed to function in extreme environments.

At the centre of Finland's rapidly evolving New Space ecosystem is ICEYE, a company that has pioneered small-satellite Synthetic Aperture Radar (SAR) constellations capable of delivering high-resolution imagery irrespective of cloud cover or time of day. Unlike optical satellites, SAR systems penetrate cloud cover and operate effectively at night — a decisive advantage in regions where weather conditions frequently obscure optical observation.

For India, where cloud cover during the monsoon season can render optical systems ineffective for extended periods, radar continuity becomes operationally significant. Persistent observation



capability ensures that surveillance and monitoring functions remain uninterrupted despite environmental constraints. The technological strengths that Finland has developed for high-latitude environments translate effectively into India's geographic realities. The same radar imaging systems designed for Arctic regions can support surveillance in snow-bound Himalayan zones, enable monitoring across cyclone-prone eastern and western coastlines, assist flood mapping in vulnerable river basins, assist in areas facing forest fires, and strengthen maritime awareness across the Indian Ocean. In this sense, Finnish radar technologies are geographically as well as technologically compatible with India's requirements.

ICEYE: From startup innovation to strategic capability

ICEYE's trajectory illustrates how European space companies are evolving from niche innovators into strategic defence partners. The company operates the world's largest constellation of small SAR satellites, enabling high revisit rates and rapid tasking capabilities that significantly improve real-time monitoring.

ICEYE has entered joint ventures and defence collaborations in Europe to integrate space-based reconnaissance capabilities with terrestrial defence systems, including with Germany's Rheinmetall, a partnership that has resulted in the largest NewSpace satellite contract in

history. The company has also secured contracts with European armed forces aimed at strengthening sovereign intelligence capabilities.

These developments reflect a transition from purely commercial earth observation toward deeper integration with national security architectures.

For India, the relevance of such technologies lies not in simply importing satellite imagery but in exploring collaborative models that support domestic capability building. Partnerships could potentially encompass local manufacturing arrangements, the establishment of data processing nodes within India, development of secure ground infrastructure, joint research initiatives and integration with India's evolving defence-space architecture.

ICEYE's increasing engagement with India's defence and space ecosystem suggests that groundwork for such collaboration is already being explored. Any meaningful partnership would likely require localisation and long-term industrial embedding consistent with India's broader strategic frameworks.

Operational applications for India

Accurate, consistent data independent of weather conditions is a crucial component in meeting India's dynamic strategic and operational requirements. ICEYE's SAR capabilities complement these needs across domains such as border management, maritime securi-

ty, and even disaster response capabilities. Persistent radar monitoring across cloud-prone, mountainous regions enables surveillance independent of imaging systems, while maritime oversight can be strengthened through the detection of "dark vessels", operating without AIS transponders. These complementary capabilities of SAR monitoring would enable a cohesive strengthening of India's border management systems across domains, empowering the country with key insights from increasingly significant theatres of geopolitical competition.

Domestically, disaster response capabilities represent another significant arena for the implementation of SAR surveillance, from flood mapping to cyclone assessment: weather-independent data offers stronger intelligence than optical systems and allows for actionable information in crisis situations. This capability further supplements India's expanding infrastructure corridors, including pipelines, border roads, and railways, which require long-term monitoring in shifting weather and climatic conditions.

Several Indian states face the dual challenge of forest fires and deforestation, and can benefit from this technology. SAR's climate monitoring capabilities additionally has applications within agriculture, including via soil moisture assessments and crop monitoring, capabilities which have vital implications for food security and economic planning.

Across international and domestic applications, SAR surveillance represents an indispensable strengthening of intelligence capabilities. The strategic value of space-based monitoring would strengthen India's abilities to respond to geopolitical, economic, and climatic shifts, representing operational continuity as well as resilience.

Data, sovereignty, and Dual-Use technology

Space technologies are inherently dual-use. Imaging, communication, and navigation systems serve civilian and military functions simultaneously.

As geopolitical competition increasingly revolves around information dominance and data access, trusted partnerships in these domains become strategically significant.

For India, building secure supply chains and sovereign data ecosystems is as important as acquiring hardware capabilities. For Finland, collaboration with India offers access to long-term scale within a stable democratic frame-

work. Seen through this lens, the emerging partnership contributes to broader goals: strengthening technological resilience among democratic nations, ensuring responsible use of space, promoting transparent data governance and creating distributed, secure technological architectures.

Beyond 2026: Toward Institutional Collaboration

The logical next stage of India-Finland space cooperation will likely involve deeper institutional and industrial integration. This could include the establishment of joint research centres, development of satellite assembly and integration facilities within India, and collaborative satellite missions.

The creation of data processing hubs in India would further strengthen sovereign data capabilities, while structured training programmes and skill development exchanges could support the development of a specialised workforce for the expanding space sector.

For Finnish firms, the transition from exploratory engagement to embedded presence will depend on alignment with India's regulatory frameworks and industrial participation models. For India, the key question will be whether such partnerships genuinely transfer knowledge and embed capability rather than replicate technological dependency. ICEYE's evolution from a Finnish scale-up into a strategic defence collaborator across Europe illustrates the kind of technological maturity and industrial capability India increasingly seeks to engage with — provided such collaboration is embedded within co-development frameworks.

The trajectory is becoming increasingly clear: from goodwill to implementation, from trade to technology ecosystems and from procurement to partnership. In an increasingly uncertain geopolitical environment, India and Finland are discovering that strategic trust combined with technological depth can form a durable axis of cooperation, stretching from Helsinki to the Himalayas.

Author is Vice President, Missions at ICEYE, and serves as Head of Missions for India. He also served at the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT), Govt, as part of the Invest India team. Chowdhury has also had the honor of serving as Aide-de-Camp to the Governors of Uttarakhand and Uttar Pradesh, where he headed the Governor's office and worked closely with the Ministry of Defence. A veteran of the Indian Army, Chowdhury served with the Ladakh Scouts (Infantry Battalion)

Mahamanav Mission delegation meets VP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A delegation of Mahamana Malviya Mission(MMM), under the leadership of Hari Shankar Singh National President and Dr. Ved Prakash Singh, Secretary General, met Vice-President of India on February 16, 2026 and gave him all the 23 volumes of Sampurn VANGMAY(Total Collective Work of Bharat Ratna Pandit Madan Mohan Malviya).

The first 11 volumes were released by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on December 25, 2023.

The rest 12 volumes were released by CP Radhakrishnan, Vice-President of India, on December 25, 2025. The senior official of MMM: Dr. CB Tripathi, Animesh Sexena, Dinkar Singh and Archana Gupta were also present in the meeting.

The Vice-President gave the blessings and his best



wishes to the MMM for such tremendous work done by its members without any govt. support.

The same delegation of Mahamana Malviya Mission met with Vijender Gupta, Speaker of Delhi Legislative Assembly and gave him all the volumes (23) of Sampurn VANGMAY of Madan Mohan Malviya.

It is worth to mention here that all the volumes of Sampurn VANGMAY have been prepared by the dedi-

cated members of MMM under its vibrant leadership and it was published by the government of India.

It is also submitted that hardworking members of MMM visited all over the country to collect the authentic documents related to work done by Hon'ble Malviya ji.

The MMM is an association of BHU alumnus and its central office, 'Malviya Smriti Bhawan', in the national Capital.

PM Modi briefed by LuLu's Yusuffali as Food Supplies to GCC continues from India

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India continues to play a crucial role in ensuring stable and uninterrupted food supplies to Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC) countries, even amid ongoing global challenges.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi was recently briefed by Yusuffali MA, Chairman of LuLu Group, on a series of initiatives aimed at maintaining supply continuity.

The meeting, held at the Prime Minister's official residence in New Delhi, focused on ensuring the steady availability of essential food items across the Gulf region.

The GCC, home to a large Indian diaspora, has long depended on Indian-origin food products as a staple in daily consumption. Discussions highlighted the need to strengthen



supply chains and maintain price stability during a period marked by global uncertainties.

LuLu Group, which operates more than 280 supermarkets across the GCC, remains a key player in regional food distribution.

Its recent interventions are part of broader efforts by both private retailers and Governments to prevent disruptions in essential supplies, while also maintaining market confidence and

34 dedicated chartered flights have been deployed so far, with similar numbers expected in the coming days. These efforts are backed by LuLu's extensive sourcing and export infrastructure across multiple Indian states, where production and logistics hubs are operating at enhanced capacity to meet rising international demand.

Yusuffali further shared plans to expand these operations in the coming weeks, with additional chartered flights and cargo shipments being scheduled to support sustained demand.

Prime Minister Modi acknowledged the significance of these efforts and assured full support from the Government of India to facilitate the smooth export of food products to GCC nations, reinforcing India's role as a reliable partner in global food security.

avoiding panic buying. During the interaction, Yusuffali outlined the group's large-scale supply initiatives, which have already facilitated the movement of approximately 15,000 tons of food products — both perishable and non-perishable — from India to GCC markets.

These shipments have been executed through a mix of exclusive chartered flights, cargo vessels, and regular shipping services. According to the company,

Bajaj Finserv Dhuniverse, with Shankar-Ehsaan-Loy, to unveil Voice of Nation

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

Bajaj Finserv on Thursday announced the grand culmination of Bajaj Dhuniverse, its digital-first music talent platform, with the finale set for March 31, in Mumbai. The event will unveil the 'Voice of the Nation' in the presence of legendary composers Shankar-Ehsaan-Loy.

Over the past six months, Bajaj Dhuniverse has emerged as a credible, technology-led pathway for music discovery,



enabling over 60,000 aspirants — from metros to deep geographies — to audition through audio and video submissions and be discovered by Shankar-Ehsaan-Loy.

The grand finale will feature live performances by ten finalists and one wildcard entrant — all shortlisted by Shankar-Ehsaan-Loy. The winner will be offered the opportunity to co-create the Bajaj's sonic identity with Shankar-Ehsaan-Loy and create an independent album with Zee Music Company.

"We owe it to the nation and our people to invest in creating platforms that harness potential and create new role models. We continue to invest in platforms across performing arts, sports, technology and culture, and Bajaj Dhuniverse is one of our long term commitments. The response we have received in Year 1 gives us the tailwinds and the courage to make this even bigger and better in Year 2," said Manav Mianwal, President — Digital Platforms.

Delhi to switch off lights for Earth Hour on Saturday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

People across the city will unite to turn off non-essential lights and appliances from 8.30 pm to 9.30 pm on Saturday.

This action is part of Earth Hour 2026, the world's largest grassroots environmental movement, and will connect us with millions around the globe.

In a statement, city power discoms have urged Delhiites to participate in Earth Hour on Saturday by turning off non-essential electrical appliances between 8.30 pm and 9.30 pm to promote a sustainable environment.

BSES discoms BRPL and BYPL have joined the event promoted by WWF-India.

Guwahati to host ODI and Test Match in India's International Home Season 2026-27

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) has officially announced the schedule for Team India (Senior Men) International Home Season 2026-27, bringing exciting news for cricket fans in Assam and the Northeast.

Assam Cricket Association (ACA) is pleased to share that Guwahati has been selected as a host venue for two prominent international fixtures during the season.

As part of the West Indies Tour of India, which will begin on September 27, 2026, and features a three-match ODI series, Guwahati will host the 2nd One Day International on September 30, 2026.

Further adding to the excitement, Guwahati will host the prestigious Border-Gavaskar Trophy. The much-anticipated five-match Test series against Australia is scheduled to begin on January 21, 2027, with the 3rd Test match set to be played in Guwahati from February 11 to February 15, 2027. This marks a significant milestone for Assam as the city continues to strengthen its position as a key destination on India's



BCCI Secretary Devajit Lon Saikia with ICC Chairman Jay Shah

international cricket map. Hosting both an ODI and a Test match in a single season reflects the growing stature and capability of the region in organising world-class cricketing events.

ACA expresses its sincere gratitude to ICC Chairman Shri Jay Shah and BCCI Honorary Secretary Shri Devajit Saikia, for entrusting Guwahati with these prestigious fixtures.

The Association remains committed to ensuring top-notch arrangements and delivering an exceptional and memorable experience for players, officials, and spectators alike.

4 Lakh to get free medical aid via HDFC's 8 mobile units

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

HDFC Bank on Thursday announced a tie-up with Smile Foundation to roll out eight mobile medical units (MCUs) in remote North Indian areas, targeting primary healthcare for over 4 lakh people.

Under the bank's CSR arm 'Parivartan', the two-year drive (April 2026 to March 2028) will span Jammu & Kashmir, Ladakh, Punjab and Uttarakhand. MCUs will deliver OPD consultations, diagnostics, free medicines and referrals to public health centres.

Focus areas include maternal — child care, NCD screenings for hypertension, diabetes and anaemia, plus school programmes on hygiene, nutrition and men-



strual health. "This will bridge critical gaps in healthcare access for underserved regions," said Nusrat Pathan, Head-CSR, HDFC Bank.

Santanu Mishra, Co-Founder and Executive Trustee, Smile Foundation, added: "The partnership boosts last-mile delivery

and supports Government initiatives." Smile Foundation will handle implementation, deploying medics per ICMR protocols and linking to National Health Mission schemes.

The effort aligns with SDG 3 and Anemia Mukd Bharat.

BRIEFLY

Mbappe denies that Real Madrid examined wrong knee



Kylian Mbappe on Wednesday denied media reports that claimed Real Madrid examined the wrong leg when the France star sustained a knee injury late last year. The soccer show “After Foot” on French broadcaster RMC Sport reported this week that the Spanish club had initially scanned his right knee, rather than the left one, in December. Other media outlets in Spain ran similar stories, nearly all of them citing RMC. Mbappe played throughout January but was then sidelined for three-and-a-half weeks before making his latest comeback. “The report that said that they (examined) the wrong knee is false,” Mbappe said at a press conference ahead of France’s World Cup warmup against Brazil. “I am maybe responsible indirectly for this situation, because when you don’t communicate on what’s happening, it opens doors to others’ interpretations.”

Bengaluru FC appoint Munoz as head coach



Bengaluru FC on Thursday announced the appointment of Spaniard Pep Munoz as the new head coach until the end of the 2026-27 season. Munoz will take charge of the first team as the club looks to continue competing at the highest level. Munoz has previously worked within FC Barcelona’s youth set-up with Barca U19 and Barcelona B, and has also spent time in China with Qingdao Huanghai and Shandong Luneng, in addition to working with the Chinese national team. His first full role as head coach came in Cambodia with Preah Khan Reach Svay Rieng, where he enjoyed a successful two-year stint that saw the club win the league twice and the League Cup once, while also reaching the final of the AFC Challenge League. Munoz will be joined by Ferran Borrás, who comes in as part of BFC’s coaching staff. “The decision to join Bengaluru FC was an easy one for me. It is a model club in Indian football. I have only heard very positive things from my fellow Spanish compatriots who have been or are in India about the club, the city, and the supporters,” Munoz was quoted as saying in a press release.

Hamilton makes it clear he’s back in the F1 chace

STEPHEN WADE ■ Suzuka (Japan)

Lewis Hamilton said he finished a recent morning training run and returned to his hotel sweating after his workout to find a few fellow Formula 1 drivers just getting up. “I know that none of the drivers I’m racing against have trained as hard as I have and given it what I have, especially at my age as well,” the 41-year-old Hamilton said Thursday at the Suzuka Formula 1 circuit in central Japan, site of Sunday’s Japanese Grand Prix. “I love that — that I still have that drive to push myself,” he added. Not that he needed a boost: Hamilton is Formula 1’s



most decorated driver. He’s won the most races (105), claimed the most poles (104) and has been on the podium 207 times. And the British driver is tied at seven with Michael

Schumacher for season championships. But if he needed extra motivation he found it last year in his first season racing with F1’s most storied team — Ferrari — after record-setting

Champions League: Benfica fined for fans’ racism at Real Madrid game

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Nyon (Switzerland)

Benfica was fined by UEFA on Wednesday for racist abuse by fans at a Champions League game against Real Madrid, whose forward Vinicius Junior was allegedly racially abused by Gianluca Prestianni. UEFA’s investigation of Prestianni is ongoing, and the verdict on a separate charge against Benfica for misconduct by fans at the Feb. 17 game in Lisbon was published Wednesday. Benfica was fined 40,000 euros (\$46,000) for “illicit chants and gestures by two



supporters,” UEFA said. The club must serve a one-year probation period to avoid closing part of the Stadium of Light at a future European competition game. Benfica previously suspended five fans who were under investigation for

“inappropriate behavior in the stands of a racist nature.” Television images showed some fans making monkey gestures after Madrid’s 1-0 win in the first leg of the Champions League knock-out playoffs round.

India high on compound archers’ strong show

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Bangkok

There was no stopping the dominant run of India’s compound archers as the top-seeded mixed team pair of Rajat Chauhan and Chikitha Taniparthi stormed into the final but the recurve contingent endured disappointment in the Asia Cup World Ranking Tournament Stage 1, here on Thursday. For India, two bronze medals are already in the bag, five entries are in the finals, and in addition, the country is in contention for two more bronze medals, keeping them on course to surpass last year’s eight-medal haul (five gold, two



silver, one bronze). The compound mixed team duo of Chauhan and Taniparthi, who received a

direct entry into the quarter-finals as top seeds, underlined their class with back-to-back wins.

They defeated Chinese Taipei 159-155 in the quarters and then got the better of fourth-seeded Kazakhstan

Gable signs with Real American Freestyle wrestling

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ New York

Olympic gold medalist Gable Steveson has signed with Real American Freestyle wrestling, the company announced Wednesday. Steveson won gold for the United States at the Tokyo Olympics in 2021 and was named the Hodge Trophy winner as the nation’s top college wrestler twice while competing for the University of Minnesota. The 25-year-old heavyweight will make his RAF debut in May at a location to be determined. “Signing an athlete of Gable’s caliber is a defining moment that reinforces our mission to be the professional home for the world’s best,” RAF CEO and co-founder Chad Bronstein said. “Gable is a once-in-a-generation talent who brings a level of star power and technical dominance that perfectly aligns with the high-stakes atmosphere we’ve built.” Those numbers should increase significantly. Steveson, who has 1.4



million Instagram followers, is a showman known for executing backflips after his biggest victories. The move means a rematch with Wyatt Hendrickson now is a real possibility. Hendrickson beat Steveson to win the national title in 2025, a shocker that drew national attention beyond the sport. Hendrickson’s dramatic late takedown in the final gave him the 5-4 win and ended Steveson’s win streak at 70 matches. Hendrickson signed with RAF last year and is the heavyweight champion. Steveson has been active the past five years. After his second college championship at Minnesota, he left his shoes in the center of the mat to symbolise his retirement. He joined World Wrestling Entertainment and performed mostly in NXT, the company’s developmental brand. After his release, he tried out for the NFL’s Buffalo Bills, but he did not make the roster.

Tough outing awaits Indian skeet shooters

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Tangier (Morocco)

India’s skeet shooters will have their task cut out as they face a strong line-up of participants on the first day of the season-opening ISSF Shotgun World Cup here on Friday. The event will feature some of the world’s most accomplished athletes competing in a strong field at the Club Tangeois de Tir. Day one of competition will start with 75 targets for both men and women which will be followed by 50 targets and the finals on Sunday. A highly-competitive field consisting of Olympic and world champions have entered the competition. India have entered the



maximum quota of six athletes in both men and women along with two shooters each in both men and women who will be competing for ranking points. The women’s field is packed with stars with reigning Olympic champion Francisca Crovetto Chadid of Chile, who is returning to international competition

after maternity leave, headlining the competition along with world champion Samantha Simonton of the United States. Diana Bacosi of Italy, a double Olympic and double world champion, also starts and former world champion Dania Jo Vizzi of USA, Kazakhstan’s world championship medalist Assem

Orynbay are among other shooters in the fray. The Indian team comprises Olympian Maheshwari Chauhan and siblings Darshana Rathore and Yashasvi Rathore. Yashasvi, the youngest of the two, was placed second in the 68th Nationals and also won silver in the junior category at the Asian Championships in Shymkent last year. Areeba Khan and Mansi Raghuvanshi will also be competing, but only for ranking points. In the men’s event, an 82-strong field entered the competition with 2025 World Championship bronze medalist Emil Kjeldgaard Petersen of Denmark headlining the list.



Sunit registers win at ALPHA Sports Academy Golf Championship

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Patna

Sunit Chowrasia announced his return from a long injury layoff with a hard-earned one-shot victory at the ALPHA Sports Academy Golf Championship, the fourth event of the DP World PGTI, here on Thursday. Kolkata-based Chowrasia (71-65-73), nephew of the legendary SSP Chawrasia, who was the overnight leader by three shots, came up with a steady 73 in the third and final round to bag his maiden title as he totalled seven-under 209 for the week. The 31-year-old’s win earned him a prize money cheque worth ₹3,17,875 that lifted him from 41st to sixth position in the 2026 DP World PGTI NexGen Order of Merit. Bipin Mukhiya (68-75-67) shot the last day’s best score of 67 to gain four spots and

finish runner-up at six-under 210. Bipin’s second-place finish propelled him from seventh to first position in the NexGen merit list. Divesh Rana (68), Vinay Kumar Yadav (72) and Rajesh Kumar Gautam (74) took a share of third place at three-under 213. Md Nawab had the best finish among the Patna-based professionals after he secured tied 13 th place at one-over 217. Chowrasia, who had matched the lowest round of the tournament with his 65 on day two, was not at his best on Thursday but still hung in there till the end to prevail over his nearest rivals. He had a mixed front-nine with two birdies and two bogeys. Then on the back-nine, he conceded one bogey but made some solid pars as well to come through as the eventual champion.

Latest phase of World Cup ticket sales announced

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ London

FIFA announced on Wednesday plans for a final round of World Cup ticket sales. World soccer’s governing body said over one million tickets had been sold by the end of the previous release between December and February and additional tickets would be put on general sale April 1 to the end of the tournament, which runs from June 11 to July 19. The latest phase comes after FIFA president Gianni Infantino proclaimed in January that the demand for tickets was the equivalent of “1,000 years of World Cups at once” and all 104 matches at the latest edition Cup would be sold out. FIFA has faced criticism over its ticket pricing strategy for the tournament, which is co-hosted by the United States, Canada and

Mexico. Fans accused FIFA of a “monumental betrayal” in December when tickets were put on general sale ranging from \$140 for the cheapest group games to \$8,680 for the final. On Tuesday, Football Supporters Europe said it had joined with consumer group Euroconsumers to make a formal complaint with the European Commission over prices. FSE has criticised the exorbitant face prices and the employment of “dynamic pricing” for the first time at a World Cup, which could see costs rise even further. FIFA said remaining tickets would be sold on a first come first served basis. It said the latest phase would enable fans to select specific seats, while those who have already bought tickets would be able to see which seats they have been allocated from April 1.



Senegal appeals to get AFCON title from Morocco at CAS

GRAHAM DUNBAR ■ Geneva

Senegal’s appeal to be reinstated as Africa Cup of Nations (AFCON) champion was registered Wednesday by sport’s highest court, which set no timetable for a likely long process toward a verdict in a heated soccer controversy. The Senegal soccer federation is challenging a surprise ruling last week by the Confederation of African Football (CAF) to strip the title won in a chaotic final on the field in January and award it to host nation Morocco. An appeal to the Court of Arbitration for Sport (CAS) in Switzerland was promised



last week by the Senegalese government, which also called for an international investigation “into suspected corruption” within the African soccer body.

CAS said in a statement that the Senegal federation also asks for extra time to file an appeal brief because CAF has not yet given detailed written reasons to explain its verdict.

“At this early stage of proceedings and considering the (Senegal federation) request to suspend deadlines, it is not possible to anticipate a procedural timeline and to indicate when a hearing will be scheduled,” the court said. CAF appeal judges took the title from Senegal two months after the final in Rabat as punishment for players walking off in protest during a 15-minute stoppage after Morocco was awarded a penalty that was set to decide the title with the last kick. The referee eventually restarted play after the Senegal team returned, and the Morocco penalty was

then saved sending the game into extra time. Senegal scored the only goal in extra time to beat the host nation 1-0. The laws of soccer state the referee’s decision on the field of play is final. The CAF judges, however, cited a tournament rule that any team refusing to play “shall be eliminated for good from the current competition.” The verdict last week in Morocco’s appeal of CAF disciplinary rulings from January fueled a perception the country, which will co-host the 2030 World Cup, has increasing influence in international soccer politics. (AP)

Guwahati among five venues for Border-Gavaskar series

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

After hosting a Test match against South Africa in November last year, Guwahati's Barsapara Stadium has now secured a game in the 2027 Border-Gavaskar series between India and Australia that will be the highlight of the national team's home schedule unveiled by the BCCI on Thursday.

The Indian board released the calendar for the senior men's team's home season, which will comprise five Tests, nine ODIs and eight T20Is. The ODI matches will certainly be keenly observed as the legendary white-ball duo of Virat Kohli and Rohit

Sharma are expected to feature in all of them.

The series against Australia, spread over January, February and March of 2027, will start in Nagpur from January 21, followed by Chennai (January 29-February 2) with the third Test in Guwahati from February 11 to 15 after an eight-day gap. The fourth Test in Ranchi will be played between February 19 and 23, while the final Test in Ahmedabad will commence on February 27.

Among the five venues, as per rotation, Nagpur (last hosted Test vs Australia in 2023), Chennai (last hosted Test vs Bangladesh in 2024), Ranchi (last hosted Test vs England in 2024) and Ahmedabad (last hosted vs

THE INDIAN BOARD RELEASED THE CALENDAR FOR THE SENIOR MEN'S TEAM'S HOME SEASON

Australia in 2023) have all got their due games.

However, it wasn't clear as to how Guwahati, which hosted India's last home Test series (vs South Africa in November 2025), again features in rotation while Mumbai and Kolkata are not a part of the marquee series.

It is not known whether the Cricket Association of Bengal or the Mumbai Cricket Association had expressed inability to host a Test against Australia.

While the Australia Test series is the main attraction during the home season, India will also play host to the West Indies, Sri Lanka and Zimbabwe. In fact, Zimbabwe will be playing in India in a bilateral series for the first time since 2002 when Sourav Ganguly was leading India.

The season will comprise 22 international matches in 17 cities with the West Indies tour of India, starting on September 27 this year. The tour will feature a three-match ODI series followed by a five-match T20I series.

The ODIs will be played in Thiruvananthapuram (September 27), Guwahati (September 30) and New Chandigarh (October 3) before the action shifts to the T20Is, which will be hosted across Lucknow (October 6), Ranchi (October 9), Indore (October 11), Hyderabad (October 14) and Bengaluru (October 17).

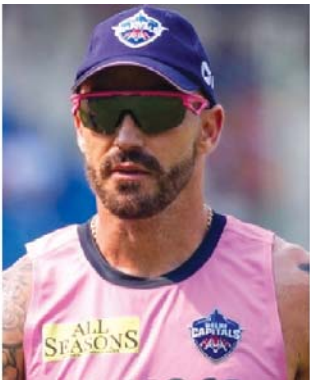
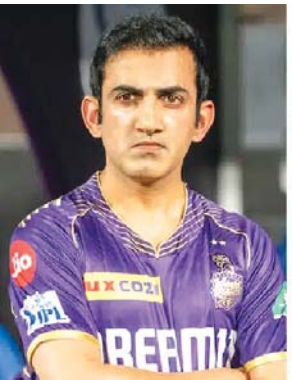
India will then host Sri Lanka in December for a white-ball series comprising three ODIs and as many T20Is.

The ODI leg will be played in Delhi (December 13), Bengaluru (December 16) and Ahmedabad (December 19), while Rajkot (December 22), Cuttack (December 24) and Pune (December 27) will host the T20Is. At the start of the new year, Zimbabwe will tour India for a three-match ODI series in January 2027.

The matches will be held in Kolkata (January 3), Hyderabad (January 6) and Mumbai (January 9).

New faces: 10 talents who are ready to own IPL this season

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ New Delhi



Vaibhav Sooryavanshi and Ayush Mhatre hogged the limelight in their debut IPL season last year and in the upcoming edition too, there would be quite a few who would like to justify the tournament tagline of "Where Talent Meets Opportunity".

PTI takes a look at one rookie from each of the 10 franchises who are expected to make a name for themselves in the next eight weeks.

The list comprises both Indian and international names who either haven't yet made their IPL debut or have played less than five games so far.

Prashant Veer (Chennai Super Kings):

There are plenty of cricketers in India, who bowl slow left-arm orthodox and bat left-handed. But none of them are faced with the task of filling up the big boots of Ravindra Jadeja like the 20-year-old Amethi-born Prashant Veer.

Never before has one witnessed Chennai Super Kings invest so heavily in youth. The franchise bagged him with a ₹14.20 crore bid, based more on potential and how the scouts felt after looking at him during trials.

The 20-year-old has only nine Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy (SMAT) matches under his belt but with a bowling economy rate of



6.45 and a batting strike-rate of 167 plus, Prashant Veer is expected to play a big part for the 'Canary Yellows' this season.

Auqib Nabi (Delhi Capitals): At 29, Nabi isn't a spring chicken and has a good

eight years of domestic cricket under his belt but the anticipation surrounding his IPL debut would make DC fans believe that they are in for something special.

After a stellar Ranji

season during which he claimed 60 odd wickets to singlehandedly get the trophy for Jammu and Kashmir, the 'Baramullah Express's big-match temperament and India prospects will be judged this year. He has played 34 T20 games for J&K in SMAT and the economy rate of 7.74 is good for someone who mostly bowls in Powerplays.

The only worrying factor will be his average speed, which is in early 130s and could be cannon fodder for international batters.

Ashok Sharma (Gujarat Titans): Ashok, one of the fastest young bowlers in India, has been a part of Rajasthan Royals set-up but hasn't got a

game so far in the IPL.

There are no guarantees that the 23-year-old will get one this season with GT, especially with Mohammed Siraj and Prasidh Krishna being around as first two choices along with Kagiso Rabada.

However, among back-up Indian pacers, Ashok could be looked at by head coach Ashish Nehra, especially after clocking 150 kmph at this year's SMAT.

Tejasvi Dahiya (Kolkata Knight Riders): Kolkata Knight Riders head coach Abhishek Nayar's protegee Angkrish Raghuvanshi is being prepared as the batter-keeper since he has already played a couple of IPL seasons. (PTI)

KKR was stronger under Gambhir: Faf du Plessis

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Gautam Gambhir's fierce competitiveness might have often made him the "villain in the story", but that trait of him strengthened the teams such as Kolkata Knight Riders that he was part of in the past, reckoned former South African captain Faf du Plessis.

Two of KKR's title wins in the Indian Premier League have come under the captaincy of Gambhir, who has now coached the Indian team to triumph in the ICC Champions Trophy 2025 and this year's T20 World Cup.

"My perspective of Gambhir is obviously very different from the guys who play with him. He's always the villain in the story when it comes to playing against him, but you respect that," Du Plessis told JioHotstar.

"And that's the key thing with Gautam Gambhir, he's so competitive. He does not worry for one second about being liked by anyone. His job as a leader is to set high standards and have accountability within the dressing room," Du Plessis said

Gambhir sets high standards and accountability in any dressing room—a motivating factor for the opposition captain as well.

"From the outside, as a fellow leader playing against him, you want to beat him because of the way he carries himself as the opposition, but you respect the fact that he sets such high standards," he said.

"That's what good leaders do, and he's created that since the day he started playing. If you look at his record, you have to take your hat off and say, from a leadership perspective, KKR with him was a stronger team," the South African remarked.

Du Plessis, who led Royal Challengers Bengaluru, said the leadership role was not restricted to the skipper alone in franchise cricket.

"People always think of the captain when they look at leadership within an organisation or team. Yes, the captain plays a role, but for me, it runs down from the top. It's your owners, coach, and the leadership group within the team," Du Plessis said.

I have unfinished business at Asian Games: Mirabai Chanu

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Raipur

Medalling at the Asian Games remains the one milestone Mirabai Chanu is desperate to achieve this year, with the Tokyo Olympics silver-winning weightlifter terming it "unfinished business" in an otherwise illustrious career.

For more than a decade, Chanu has been the face of Indian weightlifting. An Asian Games medal is the only silverware missing from the Manipuri's decorated cabinet, which includes a Tokyo Olympics silver, three World Championship medals and as many Commonwealth Games podium finishes.

"The Asian Games is very important personally because I still have unfinished

business there. The competition level is very high, which makes it even more challenging and exciting," Chanu said at a press conference following the opening ceremony of the inaugural Khelo India Tribal Games here.

Chanu's journey in the Asian Games has been marked by near-misses and setbacks. She finished ninth on debut at the 2014 Asian Games and was forced to skip the 2018 edition due to a back injury.

The closest she came to a podium finish was in the 2022 Asian Games, where a hip injury derailed Chanu's campaign at a crucial moment, leaving her just short of a medal.

Now 31, Chanu is eyeing what could be her final

appearance at the continental showpiece, with the goal of finally adding the one missing medal to her decorated cabinet. However, with the Commonwealth Games

scheduled in July-August and the Asian Games to begin from September 19, one of the key challenges for Chanu will be adjusting her weight. She will compete in the



48kg category at the CWG before moving back to 49kg for another attempt at an Asian Games medal.

"I will keep my weight within 48 kg till the Commonwealth Games, but within two months of it, there are Asian Games, which is in 49 kg, so I will have to switch back."

Chanu praised the launch of the Khelo India Tribal Games, describing it as an important platform for athletes from remote regions.

"This is a proud moment for me personally as a player to see the government prioritising numerous sports initiatives like Khelo India Tribal Games.

"The KITG will give a platform to all those athletes, hailing from remote places,

Asian Games: High demand for personal coaches, Ministry asks, show us why?

POONAM MEHRA ■ New Delhi

Grappling with a "surge in requests" for inclusion of personal coaches in India's Asian Games contingent, the Sports Ministry has mandated that "demonstrable contribution" and "regular association" with athletes will be pre-requisites for the inclusion in the strictly curated list.

The continental showpiece is set to be held from September 19 to October 4 in

Aichi-Nagoya, Japan. India is expected to field 700-plus athletes at the event, and the support staff cannot be more than 33 per cent of the overall size of the contingent as decreed by the Olympic Council of Asia (OCA).

However, at the 170th Mission Olympic Cell (MOC) meeting here on Wednesday, the issue of increased demand for personal coaches and in case of some disciplines, the number of coaches equalling or exceed-

ing the athlete strength, came up for threadbare discussion.

"Multiple requests for personal coaches beyond prescribed norms have been received," a well-placed source told PTI, placing renewed focus on an issue that triggers controversy before almost every multi-sport event.

"There have been instances in the past that a new coach has travelled with the athlete despite him/her



getting trained by some other coach in the months leading up to major international tournaments," he added without taking names. The Sports Ministry had laid down the selection guidelines for athletes last year in September.

It had stated that "only those sportspersons, coaches and support staff will be part of the contingent, whose names have been cleared at cost to the government and no additional sportspersons,

coaches and support staff will be included even at no cost to the government.

The ministry had also stated that only athletes with "real chance of winning medals" will be considered for inclusion based on continental rankings. Only those among the top-six in individual and top-eight in team sports at the Asian level are eligible for nomination from the national federations.

Following the MOC discussion on the issue of coaching

staff for the Asiad, where India would be aiming to better its best-ever performance of 106 medals achieved in the previous Hangzhou edition, the ministry has stepped in to ensure a cap on the number of travelling officials.

The source said that the performance-linked guidelines for selection of coaches and support staff will ensure "accountability and align with international accreditation norms."